

Phil 101 Introduction to Philosophy

Numbered Transcript

PHIL 101 • Dr. Daniel Bonevac

Contents

Lecture 1. On Virtue

Lecture 2. On Deontology

Lecture 3. On Consequentialism

Lecture 4. On Realism

Lecture 5. On Skepticism

Lecture 6. On Rationalism

Lecture 7. On Empiricism

Lecture 8. On Idealism

Lecture 1: On Virtue

At a glance — Bonevac opens with virtue and the question of how to live.

- 1.1 Well, hello. This is the first segment of a course on philosophy, a short course. We're going to start with questions of ethics and then proceed to other areas of philosophy. I want to begin this section by talking about virtues, good states of character, things that we ought to aspire to be.
- 1.2 Let me begin by asking a basic question: What is ethics? Ethics is a part of philosophy, and philosophy is, well, the pursuit of good judgment. In fact, you could define ethics as the most practical part of philosophy, the part that focuses on how to live, and what to do, and what kind of person to be. And so that's what we're going to start out talking about. But to say it's the most practical part of philosophy might not seem that helpful unless we know what philosophy is.
- 1.3 So philosophy, well, Plato defines it as the pursuit of wisdom. He talks about lovers of sights and sounds, which is most of us most of the time. And there's nothing wrong with that. It's fine to be focused on the concerns of ordinary life and all the wonders of the world. But we should also, he thinks, focus on larger questions. Think about the world in a broader way. What does it consist of? What is there really? How do we know? What is it reasonable to believe? Then, how should we live?
- 1.4 That's what ethics is all about: how to live. It's the pursuit of practical wisdom, the wisdom of, well, good judgment about how to live. I think it has three parts. The person who seems to me to lay out those three parts most clearly is the ancient Chinese philosopher Confucius. I typically start in ethics by talking about Confucius because he defines these areas of ethics, I think, more clearly than maybe anyone else.
- 1.5 There are three basic questions. The first one is a question of character. "What kind of person should I be?" If I'm thinking about how to live, the first thing I want to think about is myself, how do I want to be? What kind of person should I be? What kind of character traits should I try to develop? That's one fundamental question of ethics: What kind of person should I be? The second is a question of action. Faced with a certain problem: "What should I do?" How do I go about thinking about it?—that's a third one. "How do I decide what to do?" And for that matter, how do I decide how to live in general? How do I decide what kind of person to be? Is there a method I should be using? Are there reasons I should be acting upon? Are there reasons I should avoid acting upon?
- 1.6 Those questions—what to be, what to do, and how to decide—are, I think, the most fundamental questions we have to answer in ethics. Now, you could say, "Is one of these questions fundamental?" One of the odd features, I think, about the history of ethics is that most thinkers have thought one of these is basic and the others are derivative.

- 1.7** So, for example, virtue ethics, which we're going to be talking about in this first lecture, takes character as fundamental. It says the basic question of how to live is just what kind of person to be. If I begin thinking that way, I can think that I don't have to ignore questions of action or decision, but it's kind of obvious what to say about them. I start with a theory of what kind of person I ought to be, and then I think, well, what should I do? I should do what a virtuous person would do. Indeed, Aristotle says that explicitly.
- 1.8** How to be just? What should I do to be just? Well, do what a just person would do. Now, you might think that's not terribly helpful unless I already know what a just person would do. That's one of the classic critiques of virtue ethics. If I'm not virtuous, I say, "Well, I should do what a virtuous person would do, but I don't know what that is." We'll confront that problem a little later. Then decision: I should decide as a virtuous person would decide. In a sense, once I've answered the question of character, you might think I've answered all those questions.
- 1.9** Now, I think Confucius does not think that. He is what I call a pluralist. That is to say, he thinks there are real questions of character, real questions of action, real questions of decision. I do have to say something about what kind of person I ought to be, what I should do, how I decide. But those are three independent questions. They have relations to each other. But on the other hand, it's not like one is all you have to answer, and the others follow automatically. Let's see how his theory is structured.
- 1.10** He does have to answer those three questions. What kind of person should I be? His answer is, "I should be a person of virtue." His term for that is "rén." What should I do? Well, that's about action. He says, "I should follow the rules of propriety," in Chinese "lǐ." Then how should I decide? "I should focus on 'yì,'" which is righteousness. He's got three different components of the theory, each of which answers those questions. The theory of rén tells me what kind of person I should be. Then the theory of lǐ, what I should do. Finally, how to decide, that's the role of yì.
- 1.11** Those components are three separate components. They're different, and they are related—we'll talk a little about the relations. But answering one doesn't just automatically give you the answer to the others. No component reduces to the others.
- 1.12** Let's start with this question of character. What kind of person should I be? Here, you face a problem, and really, it's not just a problem for Confucius. It's a problem for any virtue ethicist. Because if you think, what kind of person should I be, what are good traits of character that I should try to develop? You can go on for a long time.
- 1.13** I once gave myself the task to write down every term, every noun or every adjective I could think of that denoted a good character trait. Well, in 45 minutes, I had written down 250 of them, and I stopped, not because I ran out of ideas, but because my hand was tired and I had wasted 45 minutes doing this. But it became very clear there are a lot of them, and I hadn't even gotten to other languages or other things like that. There's a vast array of things we ought to be.

- 1.14** One way to pursue virtue ethics is to say, "All right, there are lots of virtues. Let's talk about them." But most thinkers in this area have said, "We've got to identify some as central." If I just give you a list of a thousand things you ought to be, you might think, "Where do I even start?" Hard to know where to go with that. You might identify a few as central, but what does that mean?
- 1.15** Maybe they're the most important. They come up more often. They're really central to human life in ways that some others aren't. Maybe they're just really useful. They arise in social interactions all the time, let's say. Maybe they let you acquire others more easily. It might be that if you have this virtue, then you can learn other virtues readily. Then you might have a very strong thesis that if you have these, you actually have all the others. You already have all of virtue. I think Confucius has that sort of model, and so does Socrates, as we'll see.
- 1.16** So Confucius does single out five as fundamental. He says, "To be able to practice five things everywhere under heaven constitutes perfect virtue." So what are the five? Seriousness, generosity, sincerity, diligence, and kindness. I should be serious. I should take life seriously. None of this, "Life is just a bowl of cherries," stuff for Confucius. Secondly, I should be generous. I should be focused on the needs of others, not just my own.
- 1.17** I should be sincere. In fact, some Confucians think that's really the most fundamental of all of these things. I should be sincere, and that means not just honest. It means really I need to—in my actions, in my thoughts, in my words— actually say what I mean, do what I mean, and in particular, avoid self-deception. I've got to do this with myself as well. I've got to be diligent, so I've got to be hard-working. Then finally, kind. I need to think about others not only in helping them fulfill their needs, but in general, showing them kindness.
- 1.18** Now, that's one aspect of his theory. He says, "These five things are the most fundamental. If you have those, you really have all the rest." But another really important thesis of Confucius that emerges in the Analects, but maybe even more clearly, in another work about the Doctrine of the Mean. He says, "Virtue is a mean between two extremes." It's between two different vices. You can basically do something too little or too much. And in between, you've got to find the right amount. We'll see this view in Aristotle as well.
- 1.19** Here's a common-sense view that he's departing from. First of all, you should be serious. Well, what's the opposite of serious? Intuitively, it's being frivolous, being unserious. Generous? Well, the opposite of that we might think is being stingy. Sincere? Opposite, insincere. Diligent? Well, lazy. Kind? Maybe being mean, unkind. But he says that's not—that's part of the story, it's not the full story.
- 1.20** You can also be too much in all of these areas. For example, you could be too serious, and then you just become somber. You could be too generous and turn out to be just

profligate. You might be too sincere, then you're just reckless. You might be too diligent. All work and no play makes Jack a dull boy. Then, finally, you might be too kind. You might be actually indulgent. There are times when maybe you shouldn't be kind in response to a situation or a person's actions.

- 1.21** Now, how do you know when you're in that zone of virtue and when you're doing something too little or too much? How do you know when you're working the right amount, for example, and not slacking off, but also not working too hard? He says, "You just have to know that." Knowledge is what tells you. And knowledge, he says, results from the investigation of things. So in the end, you just have to figure it out. And it would be nice if he had a rule saying, "Here's the rule, here's what you do!" But he thinks that's impossible.
- 1.22** You just have to learn this partly by observing other people, partly by observing what happens to you. You spend lots of time working all night on a paper, let's say, you turn it in, or you submit it to a journal, and you find out, "Oh, that wasn't very good. Apparently, my mind at 4:30 AM is not that sharp after I've been working for 12 hours on the same thing." You just have to learn this through experience.
- 1.23** Now, those five virtues, he says, are enough, but that's not to say they're the only ones that matter. There are others he analyzes in similar ways. For example, you should be respectful. You could be too respectful, then you just become bustling. You need to be cautious, you don't want to be careless. But on the other hand, too much caution makes you timid. You want to be straightforward, a straight shooter, as they say. Too little of that, you become devious, manipulative, and so on. But too much of that, you're just rude.
- 1.24** Strength, that's good. The opposite is weakness. But on the other hand, you can be too strong, you can be extravagant. Finally, he talks about humility. Humility is a virtue, he thinks—pride is a vice—but you can have too much humility. You can become self-effacing. In all those cases, too, you need knowledge to figure out what's the right amount of straightforwardness, for example, or strength or humility, and when you might be going too far.
- 1.25** Now, one thing I find fascinating is that he turns this on virtue itself, *rén*. Can you have too much *rén*? He contrasts it with small-mindedness if you have too little. So if the virtuous person is doing the right thing for the right reason, somebody who is not virtuous is small-minded. They are, in Plato's terms, just focusing on the sights and sounds and not thinking about what really ought be done.
- 1.26** But can you be too virtuous? I think for Socrates, Plato, Aristotle, the answer would be, "No, virtue is getting it right." But for Confucius, interestingly, the answer is yes. You could be too virtuous. And he calls that being simple. You might just think it all reduces to one thing, and that's much too simple. The world is a complicated place. So it's hard to think about people who are maybe too virtuous—that's not the usual problem we

run into, but—I tend to use Lisa Simpson, and The Simpsons is a good example of someone who is maybe simple in this way, too virtuous.

- 1.27** Now, as I mentioned, that's not the only thing we have to do in a theory, according to Confucius. We also need a theory of action. In one sense for him, it's simple: we follow the rules of propriety. And that's a kind of old-fashioned sounding word to us, but he just means do what's appropriate, do what your society, that situation, and so on calls for. That's going to be highly context-sensitive.
- 1.28** What's appropriate in a classroom, that's different from what's appropriate in a movie theater, that's different from what's appropriate in a bar or a restaurant, and that's different from what is appropriate at a football game. You can scream and shout and cheer and boo at a football game. I'm glad people don't do that in my philosophy classes. Well, I might not mind the cheering, but the booing, definitely not. In any case, those things are different.
- 1.29** Now, there is another difference. It's not just the context that matters; it also matters what your relationship with a person is. Here is the very first section of the Analects. The Master said, "Isn't it pleasant to learn and apply what you've learned? Isn't it delightful to have friends coming from far away? Isn't he a person of complete virtue who doesn't get angry that others don't recognize him?"
- 1.30** Now, at first glance, that's an odd way to begin a major book of a major philosophical and religious tradition. I mean, think about other examples like, "In the beginning, God created the heavens and the earth." Or the beginning of Aristotle's metaphysics, "Everyone, by nature, desires to know." Here we just get, "Isn't it pleasant to learn and apply what you've learned?" But I think there's something actually really deep going on here.
- 1.31** "Isn't it pleasant to learn and apply what you've learned?" My learning takes place within myself, and then I learn to apply it. That's something that's about me and happening within the self. "Isn't it delightful to have friends coming from far away?" That's about people I know and I'm close to— friends, family members. Then, "Isn't he a person of complete virtue who doesn't get angry that others don't recognize him?" "That others don't appreciate him," might be a better translation. Well, that means, yeah, that's about others. That's about mere acquaintances, strangers, and so on.
- 1.32** That tripartite division—my relation to myself, my relation to those who are close to me, and then my relationship to other people—I think that's really fundamental, and it runs throughout the Analects. He often has this three-part division. If you start paying attention, you realize it's always self, family and friends, and other people that he's tracking. In effect, he's saying different virtues matter, different rules of appropriate behavior matter. I can behave one way with close friends, family members, and so on, but I can't act that way around people on the street.

- 1.33 Just last weekend, I was at a wedding, saw all these family members I haven't seen in years. We all rushed, gave each other hugs. I don't do that with the average person on the street. I don't take a flight and say, "Hey," and hug everyone else on the plane. I would get in big trouble if I did. There are different rules depending on these different relationships.
- 1.34 We might chart it this way. There is a way I behave toward myself, a way I can behave toward those close to me, a way I can behave toward others. There, I'm just talking about what's appropriate behavior. But now different virtues apply in these ways as well. Moreover, if you look carefully there, you see arrows at the level of family and friends pointing up and pointing across. He says there are two virtues that really matter at that level.
- 1.35 One is fraternal submission, and the other has to do with filial piety. One of those is horizontal. It's about the relationship between, say, parents and children, or the relationship between bosses and employees, the relationship between generals and captains and privates and so on. It's within a hierarchy. Some people have a higher position of authority than others.
- 1.36 Then some are simply vertical. The relation you have with siblings or coworkers or friends, typically, those are equality-type relationships. Sometimes there's a authority and there's a ranking. There's a higher position and lower position. It's the vertical aspect of that. Sometimes it's horizontal, and there's equality to that. They both matter.
- 1.37 In one sense, yes, there are three levels here, but actually, there are four kinds of relationships. My relation to myself, my relation to those above me or below me in a hierarchy, those at the same level, and then just strangers. There, I have lines pointing in all sorts of directions because there may be many of those types of relationships. So we need to pay attention to those traditional rules about how to behave, but recognizing they're going to be sensitive to context and sensitive to relationships.
- 1.38 Now, how do I actually develop virtues? I obey these rules. Confucius says, "You want to know how to be a virtuous person, how to be a person of rén? Well, obey these appropriate rules, and you will develop the right kinds of habits. And once they're second nature, they will become virtues." You learn to think about things in the right ways, you learn to feel things in the right ways, you learn to behave appropriately. And it requires subduing yourself. It often means, "I can't do I want, I've got to do what's appropriate."
- 1.39 Now, to say these things are context-sensitive and also sensitive to human relationships, isn't to say that there isn't anything that's absolutely universal. Zi Gong, one of his students, asked, "Is there one word to serve as a rule for practice throughout life?" Confucius said, "It's reciprocity. What you don't want done to yourself, don't do to others." It's a close relative of the golden rule, sometimes called the silver rule. It's

the negative version. "If you don't want other people to treat you that way, don't treat them that way."

- 1.40** How do I develop rén virtues? How do I actually learn to be the right person who does what he ought to do and is what he ought to be? I've got to subdue myself, I've got to return to propriety. If I can do that, it'll be all good. And how do I do that? Mostly, again, it's the negative side, he stresses. "Don't look at what's contrary to propriety. Don't listen to what's contrary to propriety. Don't speak what's contrary to propriety. Don't make a move contrary to propriety."
- 1.41** You'll often see little things like this. The monkey is, "Don't listen, don't speak, don't see." The idea here is try to avoid things that are inappropriate. So he doesn't start by telling you, "Here's what you must do." He tells you, "Avoid the inappropriate things, and you will develop the right kinds of habits and eventually the right character."
- 1.42** How do I go about making decisions? Here, it seems to me hard to say much except to think about what's right. Focus on righteousness rather than gain. So in other words, don't be for anything or against anything. Follow what is right. Think about virtue, not comfort, not favors, not self-interest, not advantage. Think about what is right. In short, righteousness, he says, is just the desire to do what's right because it's right. The superior person does the right thing for its own sake because it's the right thing to do.
- 1.43** Let's move on to Greek philosophy and think about Socrates. Socrates also gives us a view that is centered on this question of what person I ought to be. It arises in one particular dialogue that I want to talk about and that I often use in my classes, called the Laches. He's talking to an Athenian general just after the Peloponnesian War. Laches is the general, and a variety of other people, all of them have fought in the Peloponnesian War. Socrates himself was quite heroic in battle in that war.
- 1.44** He comes upon them as they're discussing the question: How should we educate our children? We want them to grow up to be good people, strong people, courageous people. How do we do that? We know how to encourage them to be successful, but how do we make them good? That's what raises the question: What is it to be good? What is virtue? Specifically in the context of the dialogue: What is courage? Since they've all been fighting in the war and one of them is a general, they all agree that courage is an important virtue. Part of being good is being courageous. But what does that mean? What is courage?
- 1.45** So Socrates asks them that. And Laches, the general, responds this way, "He's a man of courage who does not run away but remains at his post and fights against the enemy." Now, that's a pretty good definition of courage in a way. You're standing your ground, not running away, fighting. But Socrates doesn't actually like it very much. Partly, he says, "That's just an example." But really, you could think, if we understand it a little less literally, the idea of standing up for what you believe, not running away from a fight, that seems like an important aspect of courage.

- 1.46 But Socrates is interested in finding both false positives and false negatives. He wants to say that there might be instances of standing, fighting, not running away, that aren't actually courageous. There might also be examples of courage that aren't examples of standing, fighting, and not running away. He goes through a variety of cases, which, if we had more time, I'd talk about. Some of them involve infantry maneuvers and cavalry maneuvers, and so on.
- 1.47 But the basic idea is this: I stand, I fight, I don't run away. Is that courage? Well, what if I do that for the wrong reason? I've got the right external behavior, but I don't have the right internal state of mind. Now, maybe I'm just vicious. I stand and fight and don't run away because I just like a fight. Maybe it's because I'm afraid of what's going to happen to my family if I run away. Maybe all sorts of things are going on through my head. Maybe I'm psychotic, and I ought to be running away. But whatever it is, I do that, but I don't have the courageous state of mind.
- 1.48 However, on the other side, I might actually be courageous, but not stand and fight. Here, some of the military examples are relevant, but you might think there are other kinds of courage than that. For example, we talk about people actually fighting a disease and being courageous in their fight against cancer or against some other illness. They might be courageous in taking a stand, metaphorically speaking here, but there's no question of running away and so forth. So you might think, "I don't know, there are other kinds of behaviors that might exhibit courage."
- 1.49 There, you're considering an external factor. Maybe there are other ways of being courageous. Indeed, even in the military context, one of Socrates's examples, are people who retreat but do it to regroup and then attack from the flank. That seems to be an example of courage, and yet they did run away. They didn't stand and fight. That doesn't seem quite right.
- 1.50 So Laches says, "All right, maybe that's not the best definition. So here's another one: an endurance of the soul." Socrates immediately says, "What endurance?" He says, "A wise endurance of the soul." Now, how is that a definition of courage? Again, we can ask these questions: Are there examples of wise endurance that are not courageous? And are there examples of courage that don't involve a wise endurance? In both cases, the answer seems to be yes.
- 1.51 A wise endurance that is not courageous? What about cases where there is no danger, there is no risk? I wait in the airport for hours for my delayed flight. It's a wise endurance of the soul, but there's no danger, there's no risk. It would be bizarre to think that was courageous.
- 1.52 Are there examples of courage that don't involve a wise endurance? Yes, sometimes endurance isn't an issue at all. I act quickly. The grenade comes into the car, let's say, and I quickly toss it out, or I fall upon it and so on. I act courageously in doing that, risking myself. Or I see the child on the bicycle suddenly veer into the street, and I rush

over to grab the child before the car comes. Those are examples of courage, and yet there's no wise endurance there. There was nothing to endure. Endurance takes time.

- 1.53** Also, Socrates points out something interesting, which is that sometimes the more foolish the endurance seems, the more courageous we think it is. In other words, if I go up against great odds, and you might say, "Wow, I think you're crazy to actually fight under those circumstances," that seems more courageous than if I go in filled with confidence that I'll be able to prevail. All of that suggests there's something wrong. Can we do better?
- 1.54** You might think that we started out with a definition, standing, fighting, and not running away. That was purely external. Part of the problem was that it wasn't broad enough to cover the external factors, but part of it was that it left out everything internal, everything about states of mind. Then we focused on something that involves states of mind, a wise endurance of the soul. But that's purely internal. We seem to be ignoring the external behaviors. We also were just ignoring the factor of risk or danger. Maybe we need both of these. We need something external, but also something internal.
- 1.55** We need to talk about behavior, but also being in the right state of mind. We might think this is true not just of courage, but of virtue in general. I've got to be doing something that seems virtuous, but I also have to be in the right state of mind. In other words, I have to have the external part: I've got to be doing the right thing. But also for the right reason, and that's the internal part.
- 1.56** If we're reading this dialogue carefully, we can realize that I need external and internal factors. I need to talk about what I'm doing because there are actions as well as states of mind or states of character that are virtuous or vicious. But I also need to think about why I'm doing it, doing it for the right reason.
- 1.57** Now, at this point, Nicias actually introduces a definition. Laches gives up, but Nicias gives one, and there's a subtle joke in the dialogue because he had heard this from Socrates himself before. So he's giving Socrates, Socrates's own definition: "knowing what inspires fear or confidence." We could summarize this by saying, roughly, knowing what to fear and what not to fear, knowing when to be confident or when not to be.
- 1.58** But now the moment we start thinking about that, we realize that that's an odd thing to say. First of all, we said we probably need external and internal factors. But look at this: "knowing what inspires fear or confidence"—that's purely internal again. So again, we seem to be risking losing the external altogether. But there's another thing that's odd. If we start analyzing it in terms of false positives and false negatives, we can think, "Can I know what inspires fear or confidence without being courageous?" It seems like the answer is yes. I could know what I ought to do and not do it. I could know. I should stand here at my post and face the enemy, but in fact, I run away, and I might feel

terribly guilty knowing that I didn't do what I knew I ought to do. That example of weakness of will seems left out here.

- 1.59** Also, could there be examples of courage where I don't know what inspires fear or confidence? Well, when I act without thinking, maybe I act immediately, for example, to pull the child off the bicycle that's in front of the car, or maybe I act quickly to fall upon or to bat away the grenade that's tossed in our direction. And there, I'm acting without thinking. It's not really a question of knowing something. I'm not even thinking about it. It's an automatic reaction. So in both cases, it seems like this isn't the right solution.
- 1.60** Interestingly, Socrates has a different objection. He says, "If we take that definition seriously, courage is going to end up being all a virtue, not just a part of it." Now, why? Fear and confidence are directed at the future. So knowing what to fear and knowing when to feel confident, that's knowledge about the future. But all of my knowledge of the future is based on my knowledge of the present or the past. So I can know about the future and know what the grounds of fear and confidence are, only if I know things in general.
- 1.61** So in short, it looks like I've just got to know what's good and bad. I've got to know good and evil, better and worse, right and wrong. And that's really all of virtue. That's not just courage. If it's a matter of knowing good and evil, knowing better and worse and right and wrong, that's just virtue, he says. And we could apply every virtue.
- 1.62** In fact, in some of the other early dialogues of Plato, Socrates does that. It turns out then that every virtue ends up meaning knowing what to do and what not to do, what's better than what. Let's call that wisdom, practical wisdom, knowing what to do. Well, then, every virtue just comes down to wisdom. That is a thesis that scholars have referred to as the unity of the virtues. It does seem to be something fundamental to Socrates's outlook. He thinks all the virtues come down to wisdom. So when we say philosophy is the love of wisdom, that's really just the love of virtue. They're the same thing because if you have wisdom, you have all of virtue.
- 1.63** It seems to follow, then, that there is no such thing as weakness of will. There's no such thing as giving in to temptation and having that be a moral problem. Now, that's shocking. But basically, the idea is that if you know what to do, you'll do it. So vice, not doing what you're supposed to do, that's a matter of ignorance. You didn't know what to do. So all vice is ignorance. All virtue is knowledge. And he says that nobody would willingly choose the lesser good.
- 1.64** If I offer you a job and I say, "I'll pay you \$20 an hour or \$30 an hour," you say, "What's the catch?" "No catch. Just take your pick." Of course, you're going to take the \$30 an hour. I mean, take the one that's better, right? You might be thinking, well, still, you're thinking about what's better on the whole, and you are always going to choose the better thing. He says that, of course, people will choose the better. There's no such

thing as knowing this is better than not doing it. The problem is that people often don't know what's better.

- 1.65** You're trying to lose weight, but you sit there with that bag of cashews and keep eating them. You shouldn't do that. But he says that that looks like a case of knowing what you ought to do and not doing it, but that's not the right analysis. The fact is, you don't know how to compare the long-term health benefit of weight loss, and so on, to the short-term goodness of eating those cashews. The fact is, we're just lousy, he says, at comparing these long-term and short-term goods.
- 1.66** Psychologists sometimes give little kids a marshmallow test. They give them a marshmallow, and then they say, "I'm going to be back in 10 minutes. If you haven't eaten the marshmallow by that time, I'll give you a second marshmallow." Some of the kids are willing to wait, so they get two marshmallows instead of one. But some of them gobble the marshmallow. They can't wait. Some films of this are actually funny because you see the little kid staring at the marshmallow, then looking away, trying to distract himself and so on, finally giving in.
- 1.67** But the idea there is: Can I wait 10 minutes to get a second marshmallow? There's the short-term yumminess of this marshmallow, and then there's the benefit of having a second one. The fact is that we're not that great at making those comparisons, even when it's that simple and that straightforward.
- 1.68** Now, Plato thinks in *The Republic* that Socrates has it wrong. All of this is coming from Platonic dialogues, but you can tell roughly that in the early dialogues, he's depicting more or less the historical views of Socrates. By the time we get to *The Republic*, though, even though Socrates is still the spokesperson, Plato's own views start coming out. Here is the way Aristotle describes the situation as he and Plato see it. This is, by the way, part of the evidence that those early dialogues are really telling us the Socratic view.
- 1.69** Socrates thought there was no such thing as weakness of will. "No one, when he judges, acts against what he judges best. People act so only by reason of ignorance." Now, this view plainly contradicts the observed facts. The Greek there is the phenomena, the common opinions, and so on. But he says that it seems obvious that sometimes I know what to do and don't do it, or I know I shouldn't do something and I do it anyway. And so any view, like Socrates's, that says, "Oh, that never happens," seems plainly wrong.
- 1.70** Now, in the end, Aristotle thinks there is a point to it. But nevertheless, it looks like it's completely wrong headed. We have in history all sorts of examples and in literature, all sorts of examples of weakness of will. The classic one from *Genesis*: "When the woman saw that the fruit of the tree was good for food and pleasing to the eye and also desirable for gaining wisdom,"—gaining wisdom again, not always a good thing—"she

took some and ate it. She also gave some to her husband who was with her and he ate it. The eyes of both of them were opened."

- 1.71** Here, in Ovid, "Desire persuades me one way, reason another. I see the better and approve it, but I follow the worse." That idea of knowing the better and doing the worse seems to be possible, and Plato is convinced it is possible. Here's why. He says, "Consider a case of conflict in which a person who has willpower resists his desires, and the person who's weak-willed gives into them. A person in such a situation seems to be at war with himself."
- 1.72** Here's why he thinks Socrates really gets it wrong: because Socrates says, "It's a matter of choosing the better. Sometimes I don't know what's better." Is it better to eat the marshmallow now or wait 10 minutes and get two marshmallows? Long term, short term, we can make bad judgments about that. But it's a question of, what's really better? It's as if you're looking at two different insurance policies, saying, "Which one is the better deal here?" and so on. That's not something that makes you feel like you're at war with yourself.
- 1.73** But he says that temptation is like that. The case of really being tempted, of being like, "I should not do this, I should not do this," but nevertheless, you desperately want to do it. You feel a sense of psychological conflict. You feel at war with yourself. And that internal tension, he thinks, is something Socrates can't explain. We just feel torn apart. We're being pulled in different directions.
- 1.74** One part of me is saying, "I want to do this. I want to do this." Another part is saying, "Don't do it. Don't do it." And he says that that's not just a metaphor. There must be different parts of the soul that are at war with each other. They're fighting each other. They're pulling me in different directions. Kind of like angel Homer and devil Homer. Okay? One is saying, "Do it anyway." The other is saying, "No, don't do it."
- 1.75** Now, Plato thinks in general, there are three parts of the soul. It's not just reason and desire. There is the rational element, reason, that thinks. There's the appetitive element, desire, that wants. But he says there's also the spirited element, emotion, that feels. The idea here is that we have conflicts, most often maybe, between reason and desire, between wanting and thinking. It's not the best thing. But sometimes it's feeling that enters in. We can have conflicts between reason and feeling. We can have conflicts between desire and feeling.
- 1.76** Sometimes, in fact, in the Phaedrus, he describes it this way, "Reason is like the driver of a chariot, and he's got two horses, one of which is desire and is quite unruly. The other, emotion, usually cooperates with him, but nevertheless has to be controlled." So we get at least these three kinds of conflict: reason versus desire, reason versus emotion, and even desire versus emotion. That's the one that's usually hardest for people to think about, and indeed, Aristotle, and much of the tradition later forgets about it.

- 1.77** In Paul, for example, it's simply spirit versus flesh. In Aristotle, it's a matter of the rational versus the irrational parts of the soul. And so that emotion versus desire conflict is thought to be less interesting. But Plato thinks it's very real. I may have a desire, and yet I may be disgusted by my own desire or feel guilty about my own desire. And so feeling and emotion can come into conflict, even if reason has nothing to do with it.
- 1.78** Now, there are in Plato four different cardinal virtues—cardinal here, simply because they are fundamental, given that analysis of the soul. Three parts, you might think they're going to be three, but we've got to have the proper balance among them, which is the fourth. So wisdom, that is the excellence of reason. Self-control, that's the excellence of desire. Courage is the excellence of emotion. And then justice is the excellence exhibited by them all being in harmony, there being a proper balance. So in the chariot, for example, having the right amount of tension on the reins so that the driver and the horses are all in harmony.
- 1.79** Augustine, who is a platonist in most respects, actually does not like this part of Plato. He wants there to be one soul, not three parts of the soul or three different souls, partly because he wants God to be a Trinity, and he doesn't want each of us to be a Trinity. But he has a deeper reason, too. He says that Plato has a basic principle here, which is that whenever we experience this conflict and feel torn, there are different parts of the soul that are actually at war with each other.
- 1.80** But he says, "Wait a minute. Reasons can conflict with each other." I might have some reasons for believing this, but also some reasons for believing the opposite. It looks like then reason can be in conflict with itself. Desires can conflict. I might want this and I might want that, and I can't have both. I can have a conflict of desires. Or emotions can conflict. Think of Catullus's poem, *Odi et Amo*, "I hate and yet I love." Why? You may ask. "I don't know, but I feel it, and I'm in torment." That's the whole poem, and it's about an emotional conflict. Reason really has nothing to do with it. Desire doesn't have anything to do with it. It's about a love-hate relationship with his unfaithful lover.
- 1.81** Augustine says that if that's right, won't we end up with thousands of parts? Basically, every thought, every desire, every feeling is going to be its own part of the soul. Better, he says, to have one soul that simply has lots of different emotions and desires and thoughts. Now, he has an interesting response then. Here's what temptation is. He says that it's not a conflict between desire and emotion or desire and reason, or for that matter, emotion and reason. It's just having a desire you don't want to have.
- 1.82** "I want that chocolate bar. I don't want to want that chocolate bar, but I do." Okay, that's the problem. So what's the weakness of will? It's acting on a desire I don't want to have, a desire I do not endorse, I don't approve of, or, for that matter, failing to act in accord with a desire that I do approve of, that I want to have. If it's a question of exercising, maybe I want to want to exercise, but I don't actually want to exercise. And

so it can go either way. I have this desire I don't want to have, or I'd lack a desire that I do want to have. That's the problem.

- 1.83** Now, at this point, we can turn to Aristotle, because Aristotle gives us the most sophisticated analysis of virtue in the ancient world, I think, and the most detailed. It's going to be different from Socrates's and Plato's. It's also going to be different from Confucius's, although in some ways it's closer to Confucius than to his own Greek predecessors.
- 1.84** He begins the *Nicomachean Ethics* by saying, "Every action, every art, every inquiry aims at some good. Therefore, the good is that at which all things aim." But now, that, by the way, if you isolate it, it looks like a logical fallacy. But he then proceeds in the next several sections to give you the argument for this. He starts with the distinction between intrinsic and instrumental goods. In other words, some things we seek for their own sake. Other things are purely instrumental. We seek them for the sake of something else.
- 1.85** So I have at home screwdrivers, hammers. It's not that I collect screwdrivers and hammers for their own sake. They're instruments, they're tools. I value them for what they can do for me, and so they are useful for the sake of something else. But I also have certain things that I value for their own sake, and those things I like, not because they give me something else. They aren't instruments for something else. I just value them. Music is like this. Art is like this. In my view, philosophy, well, most philosophy books are like this. Maybe not all, some are purely instrumental. But the idea is that there are some things I value for their own sake.
- 1.86** Here's a very simple example: sometimes I'm walking somewhere to get to that place. I park about a mile from my office, and so I have to walk a mile to get to my office or my classroom every day that I teach. That walking is purely instrumental. I need to get there. On the other hand, I might just go for a walk, and that strolling about is done for its own sake. I'm walking for the sake of walking, then, not walking for the sake of getting to work. Even the same type of action, walking, can be done instrumentally or it can be done for its own sake.
- 1.87** Now, there are lots of things we value for their own sake, as well as sometimes at least for the sake of something else. Walking is one of those, but so is health, so is money, so is virtue itself, he thinks. What do we always value purely for its own sake and never for the sake of something else? Now, here he says the answer—and he thinks that everybody would agree with this, by the way—is happiness.
- 1.88** He says that here's one thing that is always desired for its own sake, never for the sake of something else—he calls that a final good—and it is happiness. "Both the general run of men and people of superior refinement say that it's happiness and identify living well and doing well with being happy." His term for happiness—*eudaimonia* in Greek—could be translated as living well, flourishing, thriving. It's a matter of having well-being

in a very broad sense. It isn't just a feeling of pleasure, which some later philosophers that we will look at very soon are going to say is just a matter of pleasure in the absence of pain. That is not the way Aristotle views it.

- 1.89** It is connected to pleasure in the absence of pain, don't get me wrong, but on the other hand, it's much broader than that. I'm flourishing—here, think about a plant that is flourishing, growing well, looking healthy. People can be like that, too, and that's what we want to be like. We want to live well in that sense of really flourishing. What does that require? It requires an internal state and also something external.
- 1.90** He says, unlike Plato, who thinks that actually it's purely virtue that you need to be happy, he says that's not true. I mean, you can be as virtuous as you could be, and nevertheless, if, let's say, all of your family is killed in a war or due to a disease, you're going to be very unhappy. Or suppose you're desperately poor and starving to death, you're not going to be happy. And so it requires a certain amount of external fortune. But in addition to that, it requires virtue.
- 1.91** So if we think: What is it for me to live well? I mean, part of it I can't control. I can't really control whether a natural disaster or a human-made disaster will strike, but I can take care of some of the internal parts. How do I do that? Let's use some simple examples. What makes a knife a good knife? It cuts well. What makes an eye a good eye? It sees well. What makes a teacher a good teacher? Teaches well.
- 1.92** In each case, those things have a function: an eye has the function of seeing. A knife has the function of cutting. A teacher has the function of teaching. Now, I can say, what's the function of a human being? Maybe to do well as a human being is simply to fulfill our function well. But what's our function? In each case, the function seems to stem from what the thing can do that other things can't do. Knives are sharp. The sharpness enables them to cut. Eyes have a sensitivity to light that enables them to see. Teachers have an ability to teach. So what is it that human beings can do that other animals or plants or just material objects can't do? What's special about us?
- 1.93** There are a lot of ways you could fill this in, and throughout history, people have filled it in in many different ways; lots of things that are unique to human beings. We laugh, for one thing. We cry. We write music. We write poetry. We build institutions like universities and hospitals. We do all sorts of things. But Aristotle says, in the end, all of those things come down to this: "We act according to rational plans."
- 1.94** All of those things I just mentioned involve rationality, but they also involve a vision beyond an immediate thing. I can think about what to do now. I can use reason to analyze a problem, but I can also think about the future and actually construct a plan, and really quite a complex plan. Maybe some animals are capable of formulating simple plans, but on the other hand, they don't build universities, they don't build hospitals, they don't write symphonies. So something about complex planning and then acting according to a complex plan, that's something unique about human beings.

- 1.95** So he says, "That's our function: acting according to a rational plan." Then, what is excellence as a human being? It's doing that well. So he says, "If we state the function of man to be a certain life involving that rational activity, and this is to be an activity or actions of the soul applying a rational principle, and the function of a good man to be the good and noble performance of these, and if any action is well-performed when it's performed in accordance with the appropriate excellence," — and here the Greek term for virtue is just the term for excellence, aretē—"human good turns out to be an activity of soul in accordance with virtue."
- 1.96** That's a rather backward way of characterizing the connection between function and virtue. The idea to be virtuous is to actually excel at what is distinctive about us, our function, and that is rational activity. It follows immediately that there are two kinds of virtues because we have the rationality part and the activity part, and we have to excel at both. So there are intellectual virtues: the excellence of rationality. There are also moral virtues: the excellence of activity. Both of those things are required.
- 1.97** Some virtues may be complex. Maybe they involve both of those. But the idea here is that we have to have the excellence of rationality to construct the plan, to know what to do, and also the moral virtue, then, to carry it out. So immediately, you can see, actually, weakness of will is going to be possible because I might have the required intellectual virtue to know what I ought to do, but not the required moral virtue to carry it out and to actually do it. How then am I to become good? I've got to develop the ability to actually carry out those rational plans. To construct them—that's the intellectual virtue part—but also to do them—that is the moral virtue part.
- 1.98** So I've got to become, first, strong-willed. I've got to be able to resist desires, and for that matter, resist sloth, resist laziness. In my own case, it's less a matter of fighting pernicious desires and more a case of motivating myself to get off the couch and do something. Maybe a lot of us are like that. So it involves strength of will, both in the sense of "don't do that," but also in the sense of "do that." In order to do that, I've got to learn to restrain myself and also motivate myself in the right ways. I've got to become virtuous by developing the right habits.
- 1.99** Here he agrees, actually, I think, completely with Confucius. Confucius says, "Follow the rules of propriety." Here, Aristotle is saying, "Act as if you are already a virtuous person." You might not actually have that virtue now, but fake it. Fake it, and eventually it will become a habit.
- 1.100** Personal case—as a student, I hardly ever said anything in class. Hard to believe now, but I was very, very quiet. I sat in the back, I just observed, I wrote a lot of stuff down, I thought about things, but I didn't say anything. At a certain point, I realized, "I'm missing out. I have questions, but I don't have the courage to actually ask them. How do I become the student I would like to be?" I started faking it, just forcing myself to actually respond to a professor's question or to raise my hand and ask a question on my own.

- 1.101** First, it was very difficult, but I forced myself into doing it. Then after a while, it got easier and easier. Eventually, it became a habit that if I didn't understand, I would say, "Wait, could you explain?" After a while, it simply becomes second nature to do that. So it is possible to become good. How do you do it? He says, "You become good by doing good things." You act in the right way. At first, you're going to feel like an imposter. You're going to feel like you're faking it, but that's okay. That's how you get there. You have to develop the right habit.
- 1.102** Develop the habit of, let's say, resisting temptation in this department or in that department. Develop the habit of getting up off the couch and moving. Do these things you want to do. At first, you're going to be pushing yourself into it, but each time it gets a bit easier to do the right thing and avoid the wrong thing. Eventually, it becomes a habit. At some point, that habit becomes second nature. You don't even have to think about it. At that point, you have the virtue.
- 1.103** Now, all of this can sound a little bit too easy, and it's not, he says, too easy. In fact, it's immensely hard to be virtuous. Why? Because the virtuous person does the right thing, but also does it at the right time, in the right way, and for the right reason. It's hard to be right in all those different dimensions at once. He says that there's no rule for becoming good. In that sense, he says that it's not just a matter of doing what's appropriate and following along. He thinks Confucius is making it too easy. There's no rule for becoming good or distinguishing good from bad or right from wrong or just from unjust and so on. Instead, we have to develop practical wisdom, the ability to draw the right distinctions and tell right from wrong.
- 1.104** Confucius would say, "We need knowledge." And in some sense, yes, we need to know where the line is and know how to draw it. But on the other hand, Aristotle is saying, "This is not the knowledge you can articulate. You have to develop a sensitivity to the right kinds of things." Imagine, let's say, a doctor treating patients. You have to recognize what's the right attitude to take toward that particular patient. When to be stern and say, "I've told you you need to take this medication. Stop ignoring me. Take the medication." Or. "Do this!"—the physical therapist, who said, "I told you to do this with your shoulder." If you didn't do that, they're not going to make it better.
- 1.105** But there are patients that need to be coddled and encouraged. There are ones that need a stern talking to and all sorts of things in between. How do you get that right? There's no rule. You have to develop the sensitivity to know what's the right thing to say to that patient. That's in general true of life. What's the right thing to say when a friend seems troubled? What's the right thing to say when your husband or wife or boyfriend or girlfriend gets mad at you? You have to figure that out; there's no simple rule. Developing that sensitivity is a lot of what goes into practical wisdom.
- 1.106** Now, Aristotle does agree with Confucius that virtues are means between extremes. So he does not have the simple common sense view that there's honesty and dishonesty, for example, or courage and cowardice. Instead, again, there are two associated vices.

But he has a reason for that. He says that virtues constrain desires, typically, or in some cases, emotions. But you can constrain them too little or too much. So it's constraining them in the right circumstances, to the right degree, in the right way, for the right reason, and so on.

- 1.107** It's hard to get it right in all of those respects. It's like hitting the center of a target. Many ways to go wrong. Practical wisdom enables us to find that mean. But because we can constrain too little or too much, we end up with, again, a drive, a desire or emotion, and then a too little constraint, the right constraint, and then too much restraint.
- 1.108** Now, his list of virtues—and by the way, he talks about a lot of them. They're not all on this list, but here are some of them. For example, yes, there's a basic drive of fear, and he thinks the positive side of that is confidence. That's complicated. I don't want to go into it right now. But the idea here is that doing that the right amount is courage. Doing it too little, you allow your fear to overwhelm you. That's cowardice. But if you go too far in the other direction, you become rash. There's too much restraint of fear. You ought to be a little more afraid.
- 1.109** What about the drive for pleasure? Well, self-control is getting it right. Constrain it too little, and you're self-indulgent. Too much, you become insensitive. What about a desire for material goods? The right attitude here is generosity. Not enough constraint on your own desires, that's stinginess. But you could also become indulgent or extravagant. What about self-esteem? He says the right amount is being high-minded. The person who has too much self-esteem is vain, but the person with too little, that person becomes, he thinks, small-minded and so on.
- 1.110** Now, the other thing I want to show you about this list is take a look at the things that are on there. Some of them are natural, like how you respond to anger or fear or a desire for pleasure or a desire for material goods. But go down the list and you find things like humor. Being witty is the right virtuous thing. Having too little restraint, you become a clown, a buffoon. But on the other hand, you constrain your desire for humor too much, you become boring.
- 1.111** What about spending? Well, spend too much, you're vulgar. Spend the right amount, and, at least if you're wealthy, you're magnificent. For those of us of lesser means, it's a matter of good taste. Then if you have too much restraint, then you become grudging and you actually end up seeming cheap.
- 1.112** In all these respects, he says it matters. In other words, virtue here isn't just a matter of a few things like sincerity and seriousness and so on. It involves things like humor, friendliness, sociability, being willing to boast about yourself—the person who constraints that too little is boastful. Truthful is, he thinks, getting it just right. Self-deprecating is restraining that too much. We could talk about honesty—dishonesty is

on one side, but then being rude, perhaps, is on the other, where you're a little too honest. In all these respects, you can constrain too little or too much.

- 1.113** I want to close by talking about an alternative to this. Here I've put scribbles that I had on a blackboard because that's what it would look like if you were in a real class of mine at the university, things would look like instead of these neat PowerPoint slides. It's the most interesting, I think, critique of this idea that we find in Confucius and in Aristotle, that virtue is a mean between extremes. Because the common sense view is that that's not the way we talk. You can be courageous, or you can be cowardly. You can be honest or dishonest, generous or stingy, and so on. We think of opposites in a natural way, and a lot of them are built into the language, like sincere-insincere, kind-unkind.
- 1.114** It seems a little weird, you might think, to actually say, "No, it's a mean between extremes, and there are at least these two different vices associated." The person I think who has the most interesting critique of this is a Renaissance thinker, and in general, an anti-Aristotelian, called Lorenzo Valla. He lived in the 15th century in Italy, and he's famous actually for not only his translations and his writing a book on proper Latin usage, but also for showing that a certain person's claim to the papacy was illegitimate.
- 1.115** In any case, he had a view that defends the common-sense view. He says that here's why it looks like it's a mean between extremes, even though it's really not. All of our ordinary—I shouldn't say all—most of our ordinary virtue terms are really complex. For example, courage. There's a matter of overcoming fear, and he calls that bravery. There's a simple divide between being brave and being a coward. But he says that courage is a matter of combining that virtue of bravery with caution. The person who seems rash, it's not that they have too much restraint on fear. They're brave, it's just that they are reckless. They don't have the appropriate level of caution. He takes something that looks like it's got these three parts and says, "No, it's a complex of things with two parts."
- 1.116** What about, for example, honesty? He says that it's a combination of being truthful as opposed to being deceptive, but also being tactful as opposed to being tactless. So honesty is tactful truthfulness. It's a complex. That's why it looks like this, and there are two ways of going wrong. Now, some of these, there are many ways of going wrong. So, for example, here's a little sketch. He actually deals with some that aren't quite this complex, but get into four or five things.
- 1.117** Here's how I tried to analyze being nice. It seems to me now we think of being nice as a really central virtue, even though these ancient thinkers never mention it. But what would niceless look like here? Well, it would look like a complex of many things. There's a divide between being thoughtful and being unthoughtful, being agreeable, being disagreeable, being empathetic and unempathetic or unsympathetic, being genuine as opposed to being artificial, being selfless as opposed to selfish, caring versus uncaring, cooperating versus uncooperative.

- 1.118** In all those cases, you might say, "Here's what it is to be nice. It's to be thoughtful and approachable and empathetic and genuine and agreeable and selfless and caring and cooperative. It's all those things." So it's not as if it's a mean between extremes. As soon as you start analyzing, you might think, "Oh, wow, I need many more dimensions, not just the one; there are all these others." So I could do it in that Aristotelian way.
- 1.119** But Valla's point is that maybe it's just a matter of having a bunch of other associated virtues. So his account says there are certain relatively simple virtues like bravery, overcoming fear, or thoughtfulness, thinking about other people, and so on. They're simple; they have simple opposites. And then the ones we really care most about are combinations of all of those.
- 1.120** That's all I have to say about virtue. So next lecture, I'll talk about moral principles and moral rules and their role in moral thinking.

Lecture 2: On Deontology

At a glance — On deontology — duty-based ethics, from Abelard and natural law to W. D. Ross and moral foundations.

- 2.1 In the second lecture on ethics, I want to change our focus. Instead of talking about questions of character and thinking about virtues and vices, I want to think about moral principles, rules or principles for action. We're going to be focusing not on the question of what person I should be, but instead on the question of what I should do. That is a second fundamental question of ethics.
- 2.2 In the next lecture, we'll move on to the question of how I should decide and take that as fundamental. But for the moment, we're going to focus on that question: What should I do?, as the basic question of ethics. In fact, often people describe the basic questions of philosophy by saying: What is there? How do I know? And what should I do? Which presupposes, really, that the question of how to live centers on the question of what to do.
- 2.3 There is a certain fancy term for theories that take that as fundamental and think in particular about what happens before the action and then the character of the action itself. It's called deontology. A deontological moral theory says that the moral value of a thing, whether it's a motivation, an intention, an action, whatever it is, depends at least in part on something other than the consequences of action.
- 2.4 It's contrasted with a consequentialist theory, which we'll look at next time, which has to do with the consequences of action and tries to judge everything in terms of that. So a deontological theory might be a virtue ethics. It might focus on the agent's character, for example. But typically, deontological theories focus instead on motives, on reasons, on intentions, or just on the nature of the action itself. They don't think in terms of consequences. They focus on questions of what motives we ought to have, what reasons we can act upon, what intentions are good intentions. Then, they look at certain characters of acts and say, "Those are good actions; these are bad actions. These are obligatory; these are prohibited."
- 2.5 Now, one of the motivations for thinking of ethics in these terms is the question we raised briefly last time: Does virtue ethics actually help us make decisions? Here's how you might have envisioned it going. What should I do, faced with this complicated situation? "The virtuous person would do this. So do what a virtuous person would do." Now, if you tell me what a virtuous person would do, that's helpful. But if you simply say, as Aristotle and some other virtue ethicists do, "Do what a virtuous person would do," it doesn't help me much because then I ask, "What would a virtuous person do?"
- 2.6 So what should I do? A virtuous person—follow them. "What would a virtuous person do?" "I don't know. That's my problem." And so sometimes people will fill this in. "Do what Jesus would do, or what the Buddha would do," or whatever. But unless you have

a particular role model in mind, it's hard to see getting a whole lot of content out of this.

- 2.7** So, in any case, that's one motivation for saying that maybe in addition to or in place of a theory of virtue, I need a theory of action. I need to know what I'm supposed to be doing, what I'm supposed to avoid. Just saying, "Do what a virtuous person would do," isn't enough to help me.
- 2.8** We might think of things this way. There's a process that I undergo when I'm making a decision and acting. I approach the problem already having a certain character. But then I have certain motives, certain basic desires as well. I form an intention, and then I act in accordance with that intention. And then there are certain effects of that action, certain consequences. The consequentialist focuses on the consequences, and they say, "That's ultimately what matters: Am I improving the world or not?" But then a deontologist judges by what comes before and up to the action. So looks at motives, intentions, and then the character of the action itself, independently of its consequences.
- 2.9** I want to look at an extreme version of this first. Peter Abelard, a medieval philosopher famous for his love affair with Heloise, and really the greatest 12th-century philosopher. He wrote two works on ethics: one simply called Ethics or Know Yourself, and the other called Conversations. They aren't read very much today, but I think it's too bad because his approach underlies a lot of questions that contemporary philosophers think about and also helps to inspire Immanuel Kant's perspective on ethics.
- 2.10** What is his view? He says that basically, we care about intentions. We care about the state of mind of the person, and we judge whether someone is doing the right thing on the basis of their intentions. In short, he says, I don't care about effects. I don't care about consequences. I care about what you're trying to do. I care about your intention. "Deeds," he says, "are common to good and evil men alike. In themselves, they're indifferent and should only be called good or evil on account of the agent's intention."
- 2.11** That's a really strong position, and to some extent, a counterintuitive one. "I was trying to help you." "Well, in fact, you broke my arm." I think that was the wrong thing to do. But Abelard says, I was trying to do the right thing. I'm not a bad person. What I did wasn't bad because I meant to help you. It is counterintuitive. So why would we think this?
- 2.12** Here's his argument. Any other view makes moral value depend on moral luck, and he thinks there's something really objectionable about that. For example, I go into a courtroom, and a friend of mine is on trial, and I intend to lie to try to get him off. Well, I walk in; I'm there. I'm ready to lie, but in fact, I never get called to the stand. He says, I was prepared to be dishonest. I was prepared, in fact, to commit a crime myself. But luckily, I didn't get called to the stand. Imagine another person who does get called to

the stand and also commits perjury, telling a lie. Are we morally the same or morally different? That person committed perjury. I didn't. But Abelard says, wait a minute, you were ready to. So it was just luck that you didn't get called, and he did.

- 2.13** Or here's another type of example that he discusses. A wealthy person helps the poor. A person of modest means helps the poor. They both give what they can. Now, the person of modest means accomplishes a lot less. They have a lot less to give, so the effects are much less. Nevertheless, do we say that the action of the wealthy person was much better? No, the intention is the same. They're equally as good as actions.
- 2.14** Now, I think it's easy to say they're equally as good as agents, and many people would agree with that. But Abelard wants to say something stronger: they're equally good actions, not merely equally good agents. So he says the addition of the deed adds nothing to alter the moral value.
- 2.15** An example of that some contemporary philosophers have discussed is drunk driving. Two people are at the bar, they get equally drunk, they equally set off and drive themselves home. Bad actions. But one actually hits a child on the way home. The other doesn't. We judge the one as having done something terrible and send them to jail. But the other faces no punishment at all. Abelard would say that that's a matter of moral luck. You were just lucky that there wasn't a child in the roadway. You would have hit them, too, if there were.
- 2.16** So we should judge not only the agents equally well, but also the act of driving drunk equally. The fact that one person got unlucky and did this doesn't make their action any worse. It's not because it's not so bad. It's because the other one is just as bad in that case. He's arguing that the intention really is all that matters. Two actions might be similar. They have the same purposes, the same consequences. But if the person's intention is different, they have a different moral value. "I was trying to hurt somebody"—that makes my action bad. "I was trying to help, but messed it up, or I was defending myself," for example, then my action is a different action, all based on my intention.
- 2.17** Another consideration is that he says that ignorance and coercion change the moral value of an action. Again, we might do the same thing, and we might bring about the same consequence, but one person actually either didn't know what they were doing or was doing it under coercion. So he says to consider two people who steal something. One person intended to steal it. That was their intention, no doubt about it. They had a criminal mind and committed a criminal act.
- 2.18** What about the other person, though? In this case, they do go through with a theft. But in this case, they didn't realize they were stealing. Maybe your briefcase and my briefcase look a lot alike, and I thought I was picking up my own. In fact, I was taking yours. It's just through ignorance. We did the same thing, that is to say, the person who

steals it and the person who just mistakes it. But nevertheless, the moral value of the action is very, very different.

- 2.19** The same thing can be true through coercion. You force me, you point a gun at my head and say, "Go take that briefcase." That action is much less culpable and much less bad than if I had done it freely. So in the end, it all comes down to intention, he thinks.
- 2.20** Now, we don't have to go that far to be a deontologist. I want to look at another medieval theory, Thomas Aquinas's version of natural law theory. The idea here is that God establishes a certain eternal law for the universe by giving creatures, and really all objects in the universe, certain essences, and they give us certain abilities and powers and dispositions. We're able to do certain things because of the way we're constituted. Our human nature also disposes us to act more in one way than another way. We tend to act in certain ways. We have a human essence, a human nature, and it gives me certain abilities, certain potentials, and certain tendencies or dispositions. That, he says, is the key to understanding the natural law.
- 2.21** A Thomist, Germain Grisez, puts it this way, "The requirements of morality which conscience discerns written in our hearts are natural in the sense that they're not humanly enacted, but are objective principles which originate in human nature." These are first principles for our moral and practical reasoning.
- 2.22** Aquinas is building this on Aristotle. Since we've talked a little bit about Aristotle, there's a dimension of his thought that I didn't really bring out. The virtuous person has to do the right thing for the right reason and in the right way and the right circumstances, and so on. He also says, "Has to act according to the right rule," but he has very little to say about what the right rule is or what the right rules are. Aquinas is starting with that and saying that yes, you have to act according to the right rule, but what exactly does that mean?
- 2.23** There are objective moral principles. In fact, he says there are two basic ones, and they're very simple. You can state each of them in two words: seek good, avoid evil. That's all you know. That's all you need to know in ethics. Now, that leaves open a really large question, "What's good? What's evil?" Okay, seek the good, but I need to know what the good is. Avoid evil, but what's evil?
- 2.24** Here's the idea. We have certain tendencies. We already know this, okay? We have some conception, to go back to Aristotle, of human flourishing. We know roughly what promotes human flourishing. Indeed, Thomas says that we have natural dispositions to the things that will enable us to flourish. For example, we have a natural desire to survive, to preserve our own lives. Life is something we recognize as good. It helps us thrive. In fact, it's a necessary condition for our thriving.
- 2.25** But what about marriage? That's also a good thing. And friendship is a good thing. Knowledge is good. Reason is good. Wisdom is. Effectiveness. There are lots of these things, and we can go down to details like food and drink are important, and shelter is

important, and so on. All of these help us thrive as human beings. We have a natural disposition to seek them. They're good things for us.

- 2.26** So when we say, "Seek the good," and you say, "What on earth is that?" He's basically saying, come on, you're a human being. You know what's good for human beings. You have a natural tendency to that, so just do that. Now, it makes it sound like, "Then being moral is super easy. I should just avoid the things I tend to avoid and seek the things I tend to seek. Yay, me." But he says that it's not quite that easy. These things are good for us only up to a point. So food is necessary to our survival, but it doesn't mean the more food, the better. At some point, you have to realize, "I've eaten enough. I've got to restrain myself." And he says that luckily, we also have natural dispositions to indicate that point for us.
- 2.27** So at some point, you start feeling full. And the same thing is true with lots of other natural dispositions. You have a sense after a while, "This is enough. I don't need any more." So he says that there is a natural desire, but there is also a natural limit to that desire. So, in short, how do we find the mean in Aristotle's terms? Luckily, we have a human essence that helps us find it. If we go too far in either direction, we have a natural tendency to head back toward the mean. We know intuitively what promotes human flourishing.
- 2.28** So there is a sense in which, unlike, I think, Abelard, where it's like, "Oh, I've got to be pure in thought because that's what really matters." Here, it's like your natural dispositions are given to you to lead you toward flourishing. So go with them, but also recognize there are limits and recognize the parts that limit you. These natural dispositions are going to aid reason. Reason doesn't have to do it all by itself.
- 2.29** Nor do we have to, as in Confucius, just rely on our social surroundings to cue us in. Confucius is saying, "Do what your society considers appropriate, and you'll develop the right habits." Thomas is saying, "Yeah, your society may or may not promote human flourishing, so I don't want to say that." It's a good place to start because there's a natural tendency toward this.
- 2.30** But on the other hand, the common practice around you may be very different from this. Here we have a basis for recognizing that and actually critiquing it if we want, saying, I don't think this rule actually does successfully promote human flourishing. In one sense, for Aquinas, ethics is easy: seek the good, avoid evil. How do we know what they are? We luckily have not only reason, but these natural tendencies, these natural dispositions that are going to lead us toward what's right for us.
- 2.31** There's a social dimension to this as well. We are social beings. We are meant to be in community with others. So there are certain rules he thinks that come from that. And here he uses biblical rules: love your neighbor as yourself, treat others as you want to be treated. But he doesn't just rely on biblical authority here. He's thinking: What promotes the flourishing of human beings in community? That, too, is a question.

- 2.32** What makes people good friends? What makes them good neighbors? He's thinking these are actually very good rules for allowing us to get along well together. We have a natural tendency to want to be around other people. We should naturally like other people. On the other hand, we should also naturally have enough of other people at certain points. We know when to be in community with others and when to draw back, and so on. At least we have natural dispositions in that.
- 2.33** Now, they differ some. Some people are extroverted, some people are introverted. But nevertheless, we can recognize certain things that do seem to be natural and necessary conditions for people getting along well together. Things like caring about others and treating them well, these things are pretty fundamental to actually having productive and thriving social interactions. So other moral principles are going to follow from those, things like do not kill, do not steal, those are going to follow very directly. It's going to be a bad community if people are constantly killing each other and stealing from each other.
- 2.34** The natural law itself, he says, is universal and exceptionless. Always seek the good, always avoid evil. But most moral principles aren't like that. Aristotle says very early in the Nicomachean Ethics that, in ethics, we have to think about things roughly in an outline, because very rarely do we get absolutely universal rules. Aquinas agrees with that. Seek the good and avoid evil are universal, he says. But beyond that, it's actually difficult.
- 2.35** Most principles—and I'll try to use the term principle here for something that's generally true, but not absolutely universally true—most moral principles are just that. They're principles. They're generally true. They're true for the most part, true all other things being equal. Why? Well, partly because the mean between extremes is very difficult to specify precisely. What is the right level of concern for other people? We don't want to be just utterly indifferent to others, but on the other hand, you don't want to be the village gossip either. So somewhere in between is the right attitude toward others: respecting them, respecting their privacy, but also caring about them.
- 2.36** It's hard to find that. He says, I don't know how to give you a general rule, especially a universal rule that is going to be applicable and tell you when and to what degree you should be concerned with other people. That's something that requires sensitivity. I can say, in general, care for others, but then the limits of that are things that we have to figure out. So there are going to be a lot of ways in which the terms we use in most of our moral principles are vague, and we're going to have to learn the boundaries through experience. We are going to have to have general principles that are true only for the most part, all other things being equal.
- 2.37** Also, here's another complication: the connections between means and ends are contingent and easily interfered with. For example, certain foods are good for certain people, but not so good for others. If you have a shellfish allergy, you may really have your life threatened by eating certain things that would be very healthy things for other

people to eat. That's something that also makes it almost impossible to lay down universal rules. There are just too many contingencies, too many interfering factors.

- 2.38** What that tells us is we do need both theoretical reason, we need to understand these essences, these principles, the tendencies, but also we need practical reason. We need sensitivity. We need to recognize that the world is complicated. There are lots of interfering factors. You might think that something like "do not steal" is absolute and universal. Certainly, we should avoid evil universally. But what about that principle? Could it ever be legitimate to steal? That is a question we can actually investigate because it might be that the answer is that, in certain extreme cases, due to certain interfering factors, yes, it would be okay.
- 2.39** That brings me to a general principle, a general approach to ethics that's become popular and then radically unpopular and then popular again over the last century. This was the view that was very common, and in fact, maybe the dominant view in Anglo-American philosophy for the first half of the 20th century. Then it became so unpopular that people dismissed it in the first pages of their articles or books. I started getting interested in it back in the 1970s as a student, and the consensus then was that this theory is completely hopeless.
- 2.40** But then, over the past, say, 30 years, people have gotten very interested in it again. If you were charting the stock averages of philosophical positions, this would be a highly volatile one. But in any case, it's something that has a lot of affinity with some of the views we've talked about already, but takes them maybe even further. It's known as ethical intuitionism.
- 2.41** The idea is this. First of all, pluralism. There are different sources and different kinds of value. We care about different kinds of things. And so the goods, the values, the basic things we are concerned about in ethics, they differ in kind, and we have to take that into account. It's not all happiness. It's not all pleasure and pain. It's not all just good intentions, according to the intuitionist. It's a bunch of different things.
- 2.42** What makes this difficult is that these things sometimes conflict. So I can pursue this, but only at the cost of not pursuing that. I can't have everything. I can seek this good, but I realize I can't have both this good and that good. I have to make a choice. In some sense, this is a tragic vision. I cannot have everything I want. I've got to make choices, and I've got to make trade-offs. I've got to compromise.
- 2.43** Moreover, there are no universal rules for doing that. These conflicts are complicated, and I can't tell you in advance how you want to resolve them. As an individual, I might be concerned about, for example, success in my career as opposed to just relationships with my family and friends, and I've got a finite amount of time. These things conflict. If I spend more time working, I have less time for family and friends and vice versa, and I just have to find a good balance for myself. Is there a rule that will tell people, "Here's

the right balance"? No. I've got to make some decisions. I've got to trade off one value against the others.

- 2.44** The same thing could happen in simple ways. I think I need a new car. I care about having money, but I also care about having a car. How much money should I be willing to spend on the car? I'd love to have the car and the money. Just give me a free car. But that's not going to happen. So I have to choose. And there's no rule that tells me, "You should spend this much on a car." It's something that I have to actually figure out for myself, balancing these different things I care about. In that sense, it is a tragic theory. You can't have everything.
- 2.45** Moreover, this is something W. D. Ross stresses: every decision is full of moral risk. Why? Because you are making a choice. You're making a compromise, and you have no idea whether it's the right compromise. You could be getting it wrong. There is no rule to tell you that you're doing good, you're getting it right. You've got to see how it works out. There's always the risk that you're going to be making a mistake.
- 2.46** After all, whether this is the right balance or not depends on all sorts of possible interfering factors. It's good, all other things equal. You have no idea whether other things are going to turn out to have been equal. By the end, maybe it will turn out that something unexpected happens. Then all of those decisions that seemed sensible at the time look pretty bad in retrospect. So every decision is full of risk.
- 2.47** W. D. Ross is the 20th century's most famous proponent of this intuitionist moral theory. He says, here are seven basic principles, but it's important to recognize they are principles. They have exceptions, and in fact, they can come into conflict. Here they are: "keep promises, make amends, be thankful, be just, don't hurt people," in fact, "help people and improve yourself."
- 2.48** He has an analysis of these. Sometimes I've done things that give me a moral obligation, like I've made a promise, so I should keep my promises. Sometimes, I've done bad things that now create an obligation, so I should make amends. I should try to fix what I screwed up. Sometimes other people have done kind things, and so I should be thankful. I should be grateful. And by the way, he's one of the few moral philosophers who stresses the importance of gratitude, which I think is a very important thing to have as part of the moral life. And then, I should be just. I should not hurt people. I should help people.
- 2.49** You might think that those are redundant. Why can't I just have one, like, help people? He says, "Well, here's the thing. I can help one person, but at the cost of hurting somebody else, and the primary one there should be avoiding hurt." So don't think of this as just on one scale. Then it looks like the hurts can be balanced by helpings. And he says it's not quite like that. Also, improve yourself. I should seek my own virtue. I should seek to become more knowledgeable and a better person.

- 2.50** Are those all the rules? No. There might be others. Those are the ones that he sees as fundamental. But he says that if you think we need to add to the list, feel free to add to the list. So maybe there are lots of others. When I've raised this with students, some of them are specific, like the golden rule: treat others as you'd want to be treated. Or tell the truth, don't steal, don't kill, don't cheat. He thinks these are all implicit, actually, in what he's already said. But also things like share, be nice, be kind, honor your parents, be true to yourself.
- 2.51** So there are many things we might add. In fact, we could keep going. If you have a large enough class, you can take up 45 minutes by just having people list these things that could be additional moral rules. Sometimes I say: What would you want to tell a class of kindergarteners? There are lots of things like this: do your best, be responsible, beware of strangers, and so on. We could go on and on. Maybe some of these are special cases of his principles, and maybe some of them aren't.
- 2.52** But in any case, he says that that's the heart of the moral life. It's common-sense moral principles like this, the things you would tell your kindergartener, the things you tell your kids as they're growing up. Those are the things that really form the heart of morality. But yes, they're all true only in general, for the most part, and they can come into conflict. So we just have to be sensitive to the ways in which they can be balanced and compromised.
- 2.53** Now, one more theory like this before we turn to the most famous deontological theory of Immanuel Kant. That's one that is part of contemporary psychology, in particular, Jonathan Haidt and a variety of his collaborators have developed this theory. It's an approach to ethics that he considers, by the way, a version of intuitionism. He calls it social intuitionism. Also, it's known as the moral foundations theory.
- 2.54** Here's the central idea. We can focus on morality in two different ways. We can think about the morality of the individual. For example, I think: What person should I be? That is a really important dimension of how to live. But I can also then start thinking about how I get along with others. That's the part he thinks virtue ethics tends to leave out. Yes, I should be a certain person, but now we also need certain principles, certain guidelines for our interactions with other people. Even if we're all good people, it doesn't necessarily follow automatically that the community ends up working well.
- 2.55** So there's a social aspect to this, he thinks, that is really important. Here's one way of thinking about it. I might be concerned with myself and being the right person, so not being the guy who takes a lollipop from a child. But I might also think about a team and what makes a team work well. Those are different questions. As a community, we are something like a large team. So one dimension of ethics, and a really important one, is how we build strong teams, how we build strong communities, how, in general, groups of people ought to interact and get along with each other.

- 2.56** He says that there are really two kinds of focuses that people have in ethics, and it's important to distinguish them. Some of them are individualizing. They're about freedom and respect. They're about individual people and protecting their individuality. Others are about binding people together into teams, into groups, into communities. He says that there are two fundamental things that ethics is doing: it's trying to shape people into the right people, but also shape communities into the right communities and bind them together.
- 2.57** He says that both matter, but it's very hard to actually put them all together and actually to figure out how to integrate them in a way that allows us to resolve conflicts that are bound to emerge between them. He started noticing this, again with some collaborators, thinking about how people on different parts of the political spectrum think about ethics and why they have some opinions that they do. He ended up concluding that liberals and conservatives rely on different sets of moral foundations.
- 2.58** Now, since he did this work, I'm not sure the political landscape is what it was, so I'm not sure the political side of this works quite the way he thought anymore. But I do think the basic idea that people identify these different dimensions of moral reasoning and assign them different weights is an important insight. I don't think there's anybody who just leaves some out and sets them to zero, but people do really differ in how much weight they put on each factor. That, I think, is really interesting.
- 2.59** Let's take a look directly at the dimensions of moral thinking. The first one is harm and care. This is something that reflects the principles in W. D. Ross: "don't hurt people." In fact, "care for them, help them." That is an important dimension, and I think we all recognize that as something that's pretty fundamental in ethics. We are not only to be a certain person; we're also to avoid harming other people, and if we can, helping other people, caring about other people. This involves not just charitable actions or that type of thing, generous actions, but also a general attitude of trying to be thoughtful about other people, being empathetic, sympathizing with others, thinking about what's good for them, and thinking about the effects of our actions on them.
- 2.60** A second one is fairness and reciprocity. This incorporates something like the "be just" part of W. D. Ross's theory, but it also goes beyond that to something like the golden rule: treat others as you would want to be treated. Also, trying to maintain balance in human relationships in such a way that I, for example, do something nice for you, then you are grateful to me or do something nice in return for me. There is a balance in relationships here, and that reciprocity seems important. Yes, we think it's unfair if this gets very far out of balance in a relationship.
- 2.61** He says what many people tend to discount and assign low ranks to, but others very high ranks to, are the next group that he calls the binding foundations. They're about teamwork and about binding communities together. So one is the idea of in-group and loyalty. It seems like an important part of ethics that you are part of certain groups.

- 2.62 Now, some of them you choose. You choose to join a club, for example, or you move to a community. Some of them you don't really choose. You don't choose your own family. But in any case, you're part of some of these groups, whether naturally or by choice, and you should be loyal to that group. The opposite of loyalty here is betrayal. Are you loyal to the group you're part of, or do you betray it? This might be an attitude toward a nation, toward your town, toward your neighbors, toward some group, whatever it is that you're part of.
- 2.63 Another dimension like that is authority and respect. This is something like the vertical relationships in Confucius, where there are hierarchies. Social arrangements are often somewhat hierarchical. That's certainly true in organizations of any kind. It's true in families because there are grandparents, parents, children, grandchildren, and so on. So you can think there is an authority and respect, not just respect in the absolute generalized way that I should respect all other human beings, but actually respecting the decision of those above me in the hierarchy and respecting those below me in the hierarchy, being willing to help them and nurture them to help them rise in that hierarchy.
- 2.64 Then, there's what he calls purity or sanctity. This is one that's maybe the hardest to describe. It's easiest to think about in religious terms, having a sense of the Holy or the spiritual, but it's not just that. The emotion that goes along with its violation is usually disgust. In biblical terms, it's a matter of certain things being unclean. But if you take that seriously, you realize, "Wait, there are a lot of things I think of as disgusting and it has nothing to do with religious reasons or spirituality." He says that that's part of ethics, too. We tend to prefer certain things that we view as pure.
- 2.65 Also, this is where virtue, he says, in general, comes in, because I can look at myself and value purity in myself and see certain things as morally staining me in some way. That's part of ethics, too. The idea is that people do put different weights on these. Everybody cares about these dimensions, I think, to some degree, but a lot of disagreements in ethics and in politics come down to different weights on these different dimensions of moral thinking. If you place a high value, for example, on in-group loyalty, you're going to think one way about things. If you assign a very low value, you're going to see other considerations as far more important. The same will be true in lots of others.
- 2.66 If we look at these in a little more detail—harm and care—that's going to lead, if we take that as fundamental to an ethic of care, I should be concerned about other people. Caring, nurturing, protecting vulnerable people, that's really central maybe to my moral vision. If I give this a higher weight than anything else.
- 2.67 Fairness and reciprocity—that leads to an ethic of justice: fairness, reciprocity, justice, reciprocal, altruism. You scratch my back, I'll scratch your back, all this type of thing. That's something that can be fundamental. Indeed, some thinkers think of that as the foundation for ethics.

- 2.68** In-group loyalty—that gives us an ethic of community. We're parts of a community, and we should sacrifice for the group, be loyal to the group, and we should watch out for traitors, try to protect the group as well as ourselves.
- 2.69** Then, there's the authority, respect. It's also part of the community, but in this case, the hierarchy is involved. There are going to be the virtues of subordinates and the virtues of the authorities or the people who are above others in the hierarchy. There's a lot written on that in evolutionary psychology. It does seem to be fundamental in a lot of the animal kingdoms.
- 2.70** Then, purity and sanctity—Haidt refers to that as giving us an ethic of divinity. It has to do with purity, pollution. There is a social function to all of this. Some things we think of as morally staining us. Other things as morally lifting us up. That can be religious; it can have another function as well. If you want something that isn't, that dramatically illustrates this, think about the ways in which we treat the dead. We speak about the dead, but also treat a dead body. There are ways in which we go about that. We take that as very serious, and there are certain things that would horrify us, disgust us, if they were done. That's just one indicator of the thing that might make you sensitive to this dimension of moral thinking.
- 2.71** Now I want to turn to the most famous and most influential version of deontological moral theory. That's the ethics of Immanuel Kant. It's also the most complicated of all of these. So apologies in advance. Even relatively simple works by Kant, if you feed them into a readability formula of the kind that they use in schools to determine what reading level this is, they come out at an 18th-grade reading level. So that's PhD level. And so he's hard to read.
- 2.72** I once made the mistake of asking students to read Kant the very first week of a course. I never did that again because it's hard. But it starts out seemingly easy. Here is the first sentence of the first part: "Nothing can possibly be conceived in the world or even out of it, which can be called good without qualification, except a good will." This might remind you of Abelard—intentions and good will. That's what's really fundamental.
- 2.73** But there are several things we can notice about this. "Nothing can possibly be conceived in the world or even out of it." Here's what you might be thinking about. He's thinking about what is going to apply, not just in this world. In other words, what's good for humanity, as human beings are constituted. He's after a bigger game.
- 2.74** He's saying, don't talk to me of human nature. Don't talk to me about, in fact, what seems to promote the welfare of human communities or human flourishing. Instead, I want to know what is good in itself. I'm thinking about what could be conceived as good, not just the way things are, but the way you could imagine them to be, and not just for human beings as they are, but for any rational being at all.
- 2.75** We might distinguish things that are good for something in some context, like all these instrumental goods. A hammer is good for some things in some contexts. Then, there

are things that are good for human beings in general, things like health and prosperity and so forth. Those things are good, and they promote human flourishing. But Kant says, I'm after a more special good, something that is good for any rational agent at all. That is good, yes, for human beings, but would be good for Klingons and good for Ferengi and good for any other alien being and would be good for the angels, would be good no matter what.

- 2.76** So that leads him to say, I am interested in a certain core of ethics that is knowable a priori. That's a matter not of what we learn from experience, but instead what we can figure out through reflection or meditation alone. That is a priori, that is to say, independent of experience.
- 2.77** There can be additional parts of ethics that are a posteriori that do depend on experience. So, yes, we're going to learn what promotes human flourishing and so on in various ways. He's not meaning to say to throw away Aristotle, throw away all the rest. But he says that there is going to be a certain core that actually doesn't depend on any of that. You could know nothing about human beings except that they are rational agents and still derive these truths of ethics.
- 2.78** So these things are going to, maybe in some cases, conflict. If we're concerned with happiness, for example, maybe there are going to be times when we have to sacrifice happiness due to that a priori core. We're going to end up saying that we have to respect all rational agents, purely as rational agents, as ends in themselves. And that's sometimes going to be something that actually works against human flourishing. It might actually work against the achievement of happiness, but we have to do it anyway because it's something that is true necessarily, as part of just being a rational agent itself.
- 2.79** Here's the way he starts, and he's going back here to Stoic thinkers who think this way. Instead of distinguishing instrumental goods and intrinsic goods that might overlap because we could care about things both for the sake of something else and for their own sake, like walking, for example, Kant says, I'm interested in a different distinction. Some things are qualified goods. They're good for something under certain conditions. They're good if certain things are fulfilled. But unqualified goods are good unconditionally. They are good no matter what.
- 2.80** So his fundamental question here is: What is good without qualification? He's not asking what's good. Lots of things are good. He's saying: What is good without qualification? Good no matter what, good under all circumstances for any rational being at all. That's the question the Stoics asked, and their answer was virtue. So that's what's in the background here. Kant is really continuing a tradition that goes back not so much to Plato and Aristotle as to the Stoic thinkers that followed them and saying, let's ask that Stoic question: What is good without qualification in all circumstances, no matter what?

- 2.81** There can be, notice, no overlap between these things. If it's a qualified good, it's good only under limited circumstances. If it's good without qualification, it's good in all circumstances. You can't be both. So what is good without qualification? The Stoics had answered virtue, being the right person. Abelard would say having good intentions. Kant says something very much in that tradition, but slightly different: a good will.
- 2.82** Now, is a good will the same as having a good intention? Is it the same as having virtue? Yes and no. Similar? Not exactly. Here is how he goes through his argument. He says: What are some other candidates for this? What about virtues? For example, "Intelligence, wit, judgment, other talents of the mind, however they may be named,"—he's talking about Aristotle's intellectual virtues here—"or courage, resolution, perseverance, his qualities of temperament, moral virtues," according to Aristotle, "are undoubtedly good and desirable in many respects; but these gifts of nature may also become extremely bad and mischievous if the will which is to make use of them, and which, therefore, constitutes what is called character, is not good."
- 2.83** So now we have to think. Yeah, we've got a criminal who is devastating our whole community. Better if he's intelligent or if he's dumb. Ideas, his intelligence is not an improvement. It's not good to have an intelligent criminal who can avoid the police. How about courageous, resolute, persevering? Those are not good qualities for a criminal to have. We actually think that makes the criminal worse. And so those things aren't good if they are not coupled with a good will.
- 2.84** He says, "It's the same with gifts of fortune, power, riches, honor, even health, and the general well-being and contentment with one's condition, which is called happiness, inspire pride and often presumption, if there isn't a good will to correct the influence of these on the mind, and with this, also to rectify the whole principle of acting and adapted to its end."
- 2.85** In other words, he's saying being rich, being powerful, having everybody adore you, being healthy, and being happy—are these morally good things? Not necessarily. They can actually corrupt you. Here, think about almost any childhood star. Achieves fame, wealth, and so on very early in life and seemingly easily. I don't mean they don't work very hard to do it, but still, if, let's say, by the time you're 16, you're already a multimillionaire and already have a huge mansion and so on, you might think: What happens to those people later? All too often, their lives fall apart.
- 2.86** Kant predicts that. He says, that's right. It can corrupt you. It can make you think it's all easy and actually undermine that sense of a good will. Here's his test. "The sight of a being who is not adorned with a single feature of a pure and good will, enjoying unbroken prosperity, can never give pleasure to an impartial rational spectator. Thus, a good will appears to constitute the indispensable condition, even of being worthy of happiness."

- 2.87** Imagine watching a movie where there is somebody who has not one shred of a good will. Nobody likes this person. Nobody admires them. But as the movie goes, everything works out for them. They win all of these struggles. They become very wealthy. They get the girl, and it's a horrible person. There is not one shred of redeeming anything to this person. How does the impartial rational spectator, let's say you, as the moviegoer, feel about that movie?
- 2.88** Kant would say, you should think that's terrible. You don't want that person to be happy. Let's have an alternative history where Hitler ends up winning. It's like, "It's all great." No, that's really bad. That's not something where you end up saying, "That's a morally good situation." Happiness, in other words, he's saying, is not necessarily a good thing. Aristotle said that everybody seeks happiness. We all desire it for its own sake. Well, maybe we do for our ourselves. But do we think that it is actually a good thing without qualification? No, the happiness of somebody who is a terrible person, who has not one vestige of a good will, seems like a very bad thing to us.
- 2.89** This makes us ask the question, then: What is a good will? Here's his answer. It's somewhat surprising. You might think that it's caring about other people. It's being kind, being generous, and so on. But that's not his answer. He says that it acts on the basis of universal considerations. It is not influenced by subjective particular determinations. It "consists just in this the principle of action is free from all influence of contingent grounds."
- 2.90** Now, that is surprising because we might have thought it's a concern for human happiness or caring about other people. But instead, he says that those things are things that are contingent on, for example, the value of the person we care about. If I care deeply about somebody who's a moral monster, that caring might be a bad thing. In the end, here is what I have to think. I've got to say, "I've got to make my decisions on the basis of moral principle."
- 2.91** Think back to Confucius who said, I've got to be conversant, not with gain, not with self-interest, but instead purely with what is right. I think that's the idea here: I've got to focus on what is right. I've got to do the right thing because it is right, or you might say more precisely, for the reasons that make it right. I shouldn't be thinking about how much I care about that particular person. I shouldn't be thinking about these other subjective things: How much do I like that person? Or how good a person do I think they are? Even those things should not be driving my decision.
- 2.92** I should be thinking about what is right in a more general, more universal way. I should be thinking about my duty. I have good will and my actions have moral worth when I act from duty out of respect for the moral law. If I treat you kindly just because that's my natural disposition or because I like you, Kant says that that's fine. I'm not telling you to do something different. But on the other hand, that's not really the ideal of a good will. The good will is going to treat people well out of duty because it's the right thing to do.

- 2.93** In other words, the test isn't whether you treat your friends well; it's whether you treat your enemies well. The test is not going to be whether I do something because I care about this person or that person. Doing it for the person I really don't care about and don't like very much, that's going to be the test of my moral worth.
- 2.94** To formulate his principles, and after all, this is about moral principles, we need to think about imperatives. An imperative is something that says that you should do this or you shouldn't do that. It's going to say, "Do this, don't do that." It expresses a command or an obligation. These could be hypothetical or categorical. A hypothetical one says, "If you're in this circumstance or you have this desire, then you should do this." So it's conditioned. It says, under these circumstances, that's a good thing to do. But a categorical imperative applies across the board. It says, "Do this, don't do that."
- 2.95** So, hypotheticals, notice, are conditional. It's, "If you want that, if you're in this circumstance, if you're hungry and you find yourself in downtown Phoenix, then you should go to this particular place." That's a hypothetical imperative. Often these are imperatives of skill, imperatives that express knowledge of particular situations. "If you are walking by and you find somebody who suddenly falls down to the ground and appears to be having a heart attack, then you should do this." Those can be moral. They can be just things that have to do with knowledge of a particular thing.
- 2.96** Here's the thing that matters to us—they are suited for qualified goods. A qualified good is good under certain conditions. This says that under certain conditions, do that. So these apply to qualified goods. You need to drive in a nail? You should get a hammer. If you're in that circumstance, if you want to achieve that end, then this is what you ought to do. The hammer is a qualified good, and it's a means to an end. So this is appropriate for means and reasoning.
- 2.97** But a categorical imperative would go beyond that. It would just say, "Do this, don't do that," independent of goals, independent of desires, independent of circumstances. And so it would apply universally. Now, the question is: Is there anything like that? Is there anything that applies absolutely universally so I could always tell somebody, no matter who they are, what their circumstances are, "Do this, don't do that."
- 2.98** That would be appropriate, he says, only for unqualified goods. Because after all, qualified goods are good only under certain conditions or if you have certain desires. And so I can't give you a categorical imperative for that. I can't say, "Use a hammer, no matter what." That doesn't make any sense. But I can maybe find some things that are unqualified goods, things that are good without qualification, good no matter what, and say that we always pursue those goods. But there's only one unqualified good, he says: a good will.
- 2.99** Really, there's only one thing I can command, universally in this way, necessarily: you ought to have a good will. "Have a good will" is really the only possible categorical imperative. If there were other unqualified goods, we could have others, but he thinks

there are not. I won't go into his argument for that. It has to be teased from the text, and a lot of people think there isn't an argument for that at all. But whatever you think about that, "you ought to have a good will" is really the only categorical imperative you could have.

2.100 Now, oddly, he never puts it that way. He says, what is a good will? It's one that acts on the basis of these universal considerations. We could frame it that way. You ought to act on universal considerations. Or in other words, act on principle. Don't act because you happen to like the person or you care about this or you want that. Instead, act because it's the right thing to do. Act on the basis of principle.

2.101 That is something that he then goes on to formulate more precisely in five different ways, and I'm only going to talk about a few of those, but the core idea of his Groundwork for the Metaphysics of Morals is to start with the good will, say, given what we've said, there can only be one categorical imperative, really, have a good will, but now we're going to formulate that in several different ways. I'll only talk about a few of them.

2.102 But what he does is say, here's one version. It implies the next version. That implies this version. That implies this one. This brings us back to this one, which implies the first. They all end up being equivalent. They're all equivalent formulations of that basic principle: have a good will.

2.103 Here's the first one. "Act only on that maxim [through which] you can at the same time will to be universal law." In other words, act on principle. Act on the basis of universal considerations. Act as if everyone were going to act on your maxim, that is to say, your principle of action. Don't make an exception for yourself. If I decide I'm going to do something, then I need to think: What if everybody did that? What if everybody acted on the basis of that principle? Here, it's not just looking at consequences. It's something deeper than consequences. We're going to say: Does that even make any sense?

2.104 Here's the test. We identify the principle on which you would be acting if you do this. Then you say, "Could everyone act on the basis of that?" Well, maybe the answer is no, in which case it's right out. Maybe the answer is yes, but we have one more question: "Could a rational being will that everyone act that way?" We've got to be able to answer yes to both of those questions for it to be a morally permissible action. If I say, "No, everyone couldn't act on it," wrong. Also, if I say, "Well, everyone could, but no rational being could want to be in that world," it doesn't work.

2.105 Here's a simple case. Should I steal? I think that maybe I could get away with it. Should I commit this theft? Well, here's my maxim: steal. Maybe more precisely: steal what I want. Could that be a universal law? His answer is no. Could everyone go around stealing from everyone else? No, there would be no such thing as property. But if there were no such thing as property, there'd be no such thing as stealing. So stealing is unjust.

- 2.106** Now, that's a weird form of argument. I can see several of you already going— it feels suspicious. But the idea is, wait a minute, in this situation, we're all going around taking each other's stuff, well, then nobody really owns anything. But if nobody owns anything, then nobody's stealing anything. They're taking. So you might think, wait a minute. It all depends on the word steal. Could we all go around taking everything from everybody else? Well, yeah, we could. There'd be no such thing as property, so there'd be no such thing as stealing.
- 2.107** But then we'd have to ask: Could a rational being want to live in that world where you couldn't rely on having anything around? Somebody else might have taken it? The answer would be no, because it would get in the way of you achieving your goals.
- 2.108** Here is the case he really considers, though. I'm going to skip the first because it's controversial and he makes the mistake of dealing with the hardest case first. Never do that. But anyway, here's what he does that's a bit pure, promising. Somebody finds himself in need of money. He wants to borrow some money. He knows he's never going to be able to repay it. Is it okay to promise to repay knowing he's never going to be able to do it?
- 2.109** Well, here would be his maxim: whenever I need money and need to borrow some, I'll promise to repay even though I know I'll never do it. Okay, maybe that'll work out. Maybe you'll get away with it. But is it right? He says, now we do the key thing. We make that a universal principle. We say, suppose that were a universal law. Everyone in need of money will go around borrowing, claiming they are going to pay it back, but never pay it back. What if that were a universal law?
- 2.110** And he says, "I see it once that it could never hold universally." It would contradict itself. Suppose everybody did that. "The promise itself would become impossible. No one would consider anything was promised to him, but would ridicule all such statements as vain pretenses." So the idea is, if there's a general principle, "Oh, you need money? You promise to repay, but never do it." Who's going to loan anybody any money out of those circumstances? There would be no such thing as borrowing and lending, no such thing as promising. People would laugh at you if promises were broken universally in that way.
- 2.111** Here would be the idea and outline. Here's my maxim: make false promises. What if everybody did that? There'd be no such thing as promising. In short, there couldn't be a situation where everybody did that because promising wouldn't even exist in that world. So making false promises is wrong. In fact, it's unjust.
- 2.112** Here's another one. Imagine that you have talents. You can develop your talents and work hard, but you think, "I'd rather indulge in pleasures rather than do that, and so I'm not going to improve my natural capacities." But is neglecting my natural gifts my duty? He sees that a system of nature could subsist like that. He imagines the South Sea

Islands are like this. I guess he's never watched Survivor. But anyway, he imagines that this would be easy. "Can I just lay on the beach and be—"

- 2.113** He says, I could do that. I could devote my whole life to enjoyment, but I could never want that to be a universal law. It could be, but I, as a rational being, could not want it. Why? Because I necessarily will that my faculties be developed. They've been given to me for all sorts of possible purposes.
- 2.114** Here we're getting to a deep point in Kant, which is that I, as a rational being, necessarily value my own rationality and my own abilities because to be a rational being is to use means to obtain ends. I have to value my own ability to attain my ends. I value getting those ends, but I also have to value my own ability, my own rationality. I can't want my rationality, my abilities not to be developed. Yes, that could be the way people live; it is not the way I could want people to live. I am a rational being. I can't help willing my own survival. I can't help willing my own rationality, my own ability. I couldn't will to be stupid or irrational or ignorant or ineffective because I care about the things I want. I care about getting the things I want. So I necessarily want to be able to get them.
- 2.115** He thinks about that in connection with charity. Could there be a situation where we're all in it for ourselves and nobody tries to help anybody else? The answer is, yes. And maybe it would even be better than the actual world where we do care about people, but we as often hurt them as help them. He says that even though that's possible, a rational being couldn't want it. Why? We couldn't be willing to be part of that because we "need the love and sympathy of others."
- 2.116** This used to puzzle me a lot. Many cases could occur in which one could have the need of the love and sympathy of others. That seems cheap. But then I had a granddaughter, and I realized that we all need the love and sympathy of others when we're young, and then, of course, at various other points in our lives. But how could a child ever grow up if they didn't have the love and sympathy of others? So this gives us an obligation toward the person beaten on the side of the road. It gives us an obligation to other people because we've got to value their happiness as well.
- 2.117** This leads him now, crucially, to the formula that he says that even if you don't buy all the rest of it, this is the part that actually gives me your card to put in your pocket for how to live. The universal law test, that's tricky, complicated, hard to use, but this one's easy to use. He says, "Act so that you treat humanity, whether in your own person or that of another, always as an end and never as a means only." So always treat other people as ends in themselves. Never simply use them as a means to your own end. In other words, you ought to respect moral agents, respect other people, don't use them. Treat people as ends, never merely as means. That, he says, is the key practical test.
- 2.118** It follows, he thinks, because I have to necessarily value my own rationality, my own abilities. But I'm not allowed to discriminate and make exceptions for myself. If I value

my rationality and my abilities, I have to value your rationality and your abilities. But that means if I value my ability to make rational choices for myself, I have to value your ability to make rational choices for yourself. It's that that underlies this thought of the formula of humanity: I have to treat other people with fundamental respect.

- 2.119** Then it's very easy to see why I shouldn't make false promises. I'm using another person to gain an advantage. Why I should develop my talents; otherwise, I'm just using my own life for indulgence and pleasure. Why I should be charitable and generous toward others; otherwise, I'm not giving them full respect as rational agents.
- 2.120** He does go on to other considerations and other versions of this that I won't talk about because we're short on time, but a key factor is, because I value my own rationality and my own autonomy, I have to value your rationality and your autonomy, too. I have to respect your ability to make your own choices. I have to respect you as a rational agent. That means I have to value your ability to make choices for yourself. I cannot use you, manipulate you, exploit you. I have to treat you as equal to myself. In the end, all of this is supposed to be equivalent to, in a complicated philosophical way, the golden rule. I have to treat others as I want to be treated. The end.
- 2.121** You brought up intuitionism. In my opinion, and from what I can tell, it appears to be incredibly dangerous and could quickly dissolve into confusion and possibly even nihilism on a grand scale. What are your thoughts and how do you grapple with that challenge or create a foundational hierarchy of values?
- 2.122** A good question. Intuitionism might be thought to be so reasonable that it actually tells you nothing. It allows you to rule out nothing. Because once you say every principle has exceptions, then you can always say, "Yeah, I know it did that, but that's an exception." That can lead to a cynicism about moral rules. I mentioned that it implies that everything involves a moral risk, but it also involves, you're right, a deeper moral risk, not just the idea that, "Hey, in this case, I might be getting the balancing wrong, or I might be making an exception in the wrong place." It's like, I might think, "Oh, I can always make an exception for myself," to link it to Kant.
- 2.123** That is a scary thought because I, let's say, engage in a bit of violence. You say, "Wait a minute, that's wrong. You should not hurt other people." I say, "Well, that's true in general, but I am doing it in a quest for social justice," or "I'm doing it because I think it's actually helping this person." I say, "Oh, I'm doing it out of loyalty to my group, or I'm doing it—" All of a sudden, you start realizing, "Wait a minute. This is like having a get-it-out-of-jail free card." That is a very dangerous situation because once I start thinking that way about moral rules, maybe I can dispense with them altogether. So I agree with you, there is a danger there.
- 2.124** Now, if you're an intuitionist, how do you fight against that? I think part of it is to say—and this is the scary part, maybe—you have to say that normally, it works out that way. So yes, in this case or that case, there could be an exception. But normally it works this

way. Normally, that would be the right thing to do, or normally, that would be the wrong thing to do, and the others have to be rare. If they start being used too often, you get suspicious and you begin to think, "Wait a minute, you're misinterpreting this."

- 2.125** How rare does it have to get? I don't know. If I say cats like fish, how many exceptions there have to be before you say, "Wait, I don't think that's true"? I don't know. Not every cat has to like fish, but enough do that we endorse that claim. Similarly, if I say that murder is wrong, but then go about justifying it in all sorts of special circumstances, and I do that routinely, you might think, "Wait a minute. I'm not so sure you actually agree anymore that murder is wrong." But that's a very squishy thing. When is that?
- 2.126** I think it's a real challenge. I myself don't feel as if it's impossible to guard against. But on the other hand, I think it's very difficult to guard against it. It can lead you into a situation where you think that there's nothing that will anchor any of this to anything firm. I think there is maybe some of the motivation for people appealing to natural law theory, as in Thomas Aquinas, saying that maybe there are certain things like seek the good and avoid evil that really are universal.
- 2.127** Now, if you're going to claim that your use of violence, let's say, is justified, you have to link that in some way. You have to say, "But look, I am avoiding evil by doing this." I am avoiding, let's say, a greater evil. Or you have to say, "I am achieving some great good." Then we just have to examine those claims. Is there really a greater evil? Are you really achieving this greater good? I think maybe if you go in that direction, you have some anchor. But even if you do, there's still a lot of room for disagreement. We seem to get thrown into facts like, "Hey, is it really doing that?"
- 2.128** It might be that when I think about the history of this, in the 20th century, the appeal of ethical intuitionism was at first something that came along with the decades just before and just after the First World War, where you might say there was starting to be a lot of cynicism. This was introduced as a way of actually combating nihilism and cynicism, but maybe it didn't go far enough. Indeed, after World War II, it lost popularity very quickly. You could argue it's because people saw sheer evil there and realized that it was justified in these kinds of ways. So maybe we really need a firmer anchor.
- 2.129** So I think part of the appeal was like, "Hey, this is reasonable," and a guard against cynicism, but maybe not nearly enough of a guard. I think it's fair enough to say it's the way a lot of moral rules might be, but if they're all that way, maybe we're in real trouble. Anyway, great question. Other questions?
- 2.130** This is maybe more about biographical details about the philosophers we've discussed so far. You'd mentioned earlier that if you're asking: What would a virtuous person do? If you don't have a role model, then who would that be? So look at Confucius, Aristotle. Did they have role models? I see a lot of influence around it, but under really what a

worldview were they going at with saying, "This is my role model. Here's why I think—why I'm asserting what I'm asserting."

- 2.131** A great question. In Confucius, the real role model is something that he finds in The Book of History and The Book of Poetry. He refers constantly to earlier emperors from a long time before, more than a thousand years before, Yao and Shun. The idea is they showed us how to live, and so we have to get back to those old ways. In general, for him, it's very much past-looking, and in that case, the distant past.
- 2.132** It was like people knew how to live once. We've forgotten; we've become corrupted. But look at those earlier models. History has given us examples of people who were truly admirable. So don't just think: What would a virtuous person do? Think, what would Emperor Yao do? And there are these historic figures we can look up to. So for him, it's very much look at your history, learn history, figure out who were the characters in history you want to be like, and others you want to avoid.
- 2.133** In Aristotle, the name of the work is the Nicomachean Ethics, and it's named after his father. Actually, I think in his case, it was like, "I looked to my dad," and that seems to be another way of looking at it. Hey, I've inherited this. I have role models in my own family: in my own parents, maybe my own grandparents. There are people in my family I look up to and I want to be like. For him, I think it's a matter of looking at your elders and specifically those closest to you and saying, "I can ask, what would dad do, and what would grandpa do?" In this situation, "What would grandpa do?" That's how he thinks about it.
- 2.134** As I mentioned, I think if you're in a religious tradition, you can easily enough say: What would Jesus do? Or what would the Buddha do? I think the further away you get from a human or an ordinary human thing, though, model, the harder it is to apply. Because if I ask: What would Jesus do? I sometimes think, "Yeah, my friend's sick. Jesus would heal him. I'm just a philosopher. I can't really do that." Similarly, that's what the ancient emperor would have done. He would have made a law. "I can't make law."
- 2.135** I think that's why Aristotle thinks the closer the person is to you in your situation, the better, because the more directly applicable it is. The further they are from you or from your circumstances or from the human condition itself, the harder it is to apply what they would do because it may be just beyond your ability to do it.
- 2.136** Following up on his question, I was wondering, do you think humans crave religion because it does give them some form of structure or order to the possibilities of what could be considered good?
- 2.137** All right, that's a really deep question, and to some extent, beyond my abilities as a philosopher, since you're asking in part about human psychology and why people feel attracted to religion. But we've looked at enough already to maybe get a sense of that.

- 2.138** If I think there are rules, whether they are universal and necessary rules as Kant, for example, or Aquinas thinks, or whether they are just principles that are true all other things being equal, where do they come from? Now we can say that some of them might be rules about just promoting my flourishing. Some might be about binding communities together. They might have a variety of different sources. But you might think, "Is that really enough?" Here, psychologically, is it enough to motivate me and other people to do this?
- 2.139** Another problem is there's always this temptation to say, "What if I don't?" Sometimes you might get into real trouble, but all too often when we fail at our moral duty, we don't get into trouble. I at least do not have temptations to do things that are going to be getting me into trouble with the criminal law, at least I don't very often. But I do have temptations to not fulfill certain obligations.
- 2.140** In fact, confession time: near the end of my chairmanship, I was chairman of the philosophy department for 10 years. There were times when there were a lot of demands on me, and at times, I started feeling really overloaded. I would have two obligations that conflicted, two meetings I was supposed to be at happening at the same time. This is when I knew it was time to resign from that position. I would think, "I could use obligation A as an excuse for not fulfilling obligation B, and use B as an excuse for not fulfilling obligation A, and not go to either meeting, claiming I was the other. After I did that once or twice, I realized, "This is a bad sign. This is a very bad sign."
- 2.141** But notice there, it's not like I get in trouble in particular if people discovered this. I guess now they're about to. Instead, it's like, what makes me do my duty? What makes me actually put up with things that I'd rather not do. I think if you don't have a larger meaning to your life, you're going to find it very hard to find a reason for that.
- 2.142** Now, the larger meaning doesn't necessarily have to be religious. It might be based on a concern for humanity. But I think you need something higher than yourself. Dostoevsky lays this out very clearly at a certain point. In the end, what's central to your life? Either what is guiding you and giving your life meaning is just purely within you, or it's something you view as above you. That's a stark division. If it's all down here, then you are going to find yourself lost and your life without meaning. It has to be something you view as higher than you.
- 2.143** Dostoevsky thinks it has to be actually higher than humanity as a whole, because what you're going to substitute for humanity, since you don't know everybody else in the world or what would make them happy and make them flourish, it's going to be just you again. You're going to put your own image on humanity. In the end, he would say that if you're really to feel like your life has meaning, it's got to be through religion. But whether you like that conclusion or not, I do think it's compelling to say it has to be something higher than you.

2.144 If it's just about you—that, by the way, is a potential criticism of Socrates and Aristotle, though Aristotle, in other works, does talk about God. So it's not as if he ignores that. But in the Ethics, he doesn't really talk about that. And you could end up thinking that insofar as it's just about my flourishing, if I decide, "Enough flourishing." What do you really have to argue against that? So I like the idea that there must be something higher, or else all of it tends to fall apart.

Lecture 3: On Consequentialism

At a glance — On consequentialism.

- 3.1 In this lecture, I want to talk about an approach to ethical theory that is based on consequences. The idea here is to look at the effects of actions. Broadly speaking, an action is going to turn out to be good if it makes the world a better place, and it's going to be bad if it makes the world a worse place. That's very, very rough, but it gives you the feeling for what these theories are like. It says: forget, at least initially, forget intentions. Forget your motives. Forget the state of character of someone. What we're interested in is whether the action improves things or makes them worse.
- 3.2 Let's look at consequences. The consequences of an action are going to determine the value of the action itself. They're also going to indirectly tell us what the value of an intention is or a motive or a desire, because we're going to be able to say, "Intentions like that tend to lead you to perform actions like that, which tend to have certain consequences." But in the end, it is all driven by the consequences.
- 3.3 So theories like this are called consequentialist theories. They're theories that, as that name suggests, say that the moral value of actions, of motives, of intentions, of whatever, depends on consequences—on consequences in particular for the amount of good. We can be more precise than that. It's rather vague, like, what's good and what do we mean, the amount of good and so on? We're going to have to specify that.
- 3.4 Some of the key figures in this view are Jeremy Bentham and John Stuart Mill, together with his wife, Harriet Taylor, who developed this in the 19th century in England as an approach to ethical theory. It is mentioned in some of the dialogues of Plato, so it's not an altogether new theory, and there were a variety of British philosophers who were working in this general direction in the century before them.
- 3.5 But it was Bentham and Mill who really put this in a precise form, and a form that now has a huge influence, not only in philosophy, but also in politics, in economics. In fact, much of economics really rests on a theory of utility of the kind that they developed. You might see Mill, who was himself a great economist as well as a great philosopher, as giving key ideas for the analysis of social phenomena in general, including economic aspects of those.
- 3.6 Let's take a look at the general form of the theory. I think we could put it most generally this way. X is morally preferable to Y if X tends to lead to better consequences than Y does. What are X and Y? In the classic form: actions. So one action is morally preferable to another if it tends to lead to better consequences. But we could do the same thing with motives, intentions, even states of character, desires, and other things of that kind. We can think about their consequences, and so we could apply this very generally.

- 3.7** There are several things to notice about this. One is that it's about when one thing is preferable to another thing from a moral point of view. It's about better and worse. This makes it very different from most moral theories. The theories that Kant, for example, or Aquinas, or other people give you, are typically ones that say, "This is what you ought to do. These are things you should not do." They aren't about better and worse.
- 3.8** Directly, consequentialist theories aren't about good and bad or right and wrong at all. They have ways of building that in, and we'll talk about those, but fundamentally, they're theories about better and worse. What makes one thing better than another thing? That's something that, strangely, other ethical theorists don't tend to talk about. Look at Kant; you can say, "This violates the categorical imperative. You shouldn't do that. You're using someone else as a means." But if you say, "Here are two bad actions. Which one's worse?" There's no way to really think about that in terms of the theory.
- 3.9** Similarly, in Aristotle, if we say, "Here are two actions. They're both dishonest, but which one's worse?" There's no direct way of answering that question. Bentham and Mill, however, are saying, "Better and worse is the fundamental part of this. We want to know what's better than what." Then the question of what's right and what's wrong or what you have to do, that becomes a question of: How good does the action have to be to be acceptable? They start with a scale. They start with better and worse.
- 3.10** Well, let's talk a little bit about John Stuart Mill, who gives us, I think, the most elaborated version of this theory, though not necessarily, in all cases, the most precise version—Bentham maybe gets credit for that. It is striking, by the way, that all of these people knew each other. This is the house in London where John Milton, Jeremy Bentham, James Mill, the economist, John Stuart Mill, and then, later, William Hazlitt all lived at certain points—a black cap on the back, notice. But that's a striking fact. Those are some of the major figures of British literature and economics and philosophy; all happen to live in the same house.
- 3.11** That's what it looks like today, the white one on the corner. It's just a few blocks from Buckingham Palace, a rather nice location. But still, that's fascinating. James Mill, the economist, was best friends with Jeremy Bentham. The two of them home-schooled John Stuart Mill. There's a sense in which this theory emerged as a very strongly ingrown family affair, nevertheless, hugely significant.
- 3.12** The theory has its most powerful form and most developed form in a particular theory known as utilitarianism. That was a term given to it by Jeremy Bentham, and Mill follows in that. They're both utilitarians. Utilitarianism is a version of consequentialism, but it's not the only version, as we'll see.
- 3.13** What was Bentham doing in developing the theory? He was trying, first of all, to bring the methods of science to moral theory and to political theory. His greatest work was called *The Principles of Morals and Legislation*, and it's meant to be both. This is about

morals. It's about human life, individually and as we live together, but also about legislation, about politics. It's meant to answer the question not only what should I do, but what should we do together as a political community? He thinks those are basically questions that can receive the same answer. Not exactly the same question, but nevertheless, the same thing can answer both of them.

- 3.14** That's part of his motivation. He wants to bring science to this and say that there is a scientific method for answering that question of what I should do. Hence, we could see these theories as focusing on that third question of ethics I talked about, seen as fundamental: How should I decide? They're going to introduce a decision method, and they're going to say: What should you do? What that decision method tells you to do. What person should you be? The person who—well, in Bentham—uses the decision method, and in Mill, who at least acts in a way that corresponds to what that decision method would recommend.
- 3.15** That's a major motivation. What Bentham sees himself as trying to do is get rid of a lot of superstition, get rid of a lot of traditional ideas that may or may not have any foundation. If they have a foundation, he wants to say here's what it is. If they don't have a foundation, he wants to sweep them away. That includes not only views about morality and politics, but also about other things like death.
- 3.16** That is his body encased in the University College Library in London. It is said that he is wheeled out to preside at board meetings whenever they occur, even now, because he was a founder of that college. It is creepy. I agree with you. At one point, we actually had a conference in honor of Jeremy Bentham, and we had a telelink so we could talk directly to his body. I didn't love that part of that conference.
- 3.17** But in any case, Bentham was somebody who devoted his entire life to moral reform, political reform, legal reform. He graduated from Oxford with a law degree at age 19, so he was a child prodigy, but never practiced law. He instead started a group he called the Philosophical Radicals and a publication, The Westminster Review. And then he started writing huge numbers of texts on his own, only a few of which were published in his lifetime. It is thought that it's going to add up to 90 volumes once they're all fully compiled, edited, and published.
- 3.18** His fundamental question is, as I mentioned: How do I decide? I'm faced with decision problems like this all throughout my life, and we, as a political society, face problems like this. We have all sorts of things we might do, problems, and then proposals that are addressed to solving them. How do we make decisions about all of that? He says that, in the end, we care about effects. Sure, indirectly, we care, as Aristotle does and as Confucius does, about character. Yes, of course, we care about motives and intentions, as Abelard and Kant say. Yes, we can give principles and even maybe absolute rules for action. But in the end, what drives all of that, the utilitarian thinks, is effects.

- 3.19** If we're going to pursue a certain character, if that character makes the world a worse place and we're all worse off, then clearly we're doing something wrong. The same thing with motives. If our moral theory says this should be your motive, and in fact, that makes the world worse, something's fundamentally wrong with such an approach. In the end, where do we get these principles? They should be principles that make human life better. In the end, all of the value of our characters, of our motives, of our intentions, of our actions has to depend on effects.
- 3.20** Bentham frames all of this in terms of one principle he refers to as the principle of utility. He says it's "the principle that approves or disapproves of every action whatsoever, according to the tendency it appears to have to augment or diminish the happiness of the party whose interest is in question: or, what is the same thing in other words to promote or oppose that happiness." Bentham always writes like this, so if you find that somewhat unclear, you're not alone.
- 3.21** There are many things in that that are really very interesting, but I'm going to focus on the slightly simpler version that John Stuart Mill gives because it has the same features, and I think is Mill's way of trying to say exactly the same thing. Mill says, "The creed which accepts as the foundation of morals, Utility or the Greatest Happiness Principle, holds that actions are right in proportion as they tend to promote happiness, wrong as they tend to produce the reverse of happiness."
- 3.22** There are several things I want to focus on here. First of all, "in proportion as"—this is a theory of better and worse, as I mentioned. We're talking about proportionality. He is not talking about actions being right, period. Acts are right to a degree. They are "right in proportion as they promote happiness," so the degree of rightness of an action depends on the degree to which it promotes human happiness.
- 3.23** Well, I shouldn't say human because both Bentham and Mill think animal happiness is relevant here, too. Animals have a lesser degree, he thinks, but nevertheless have to be put into the calculation. At one point, Bentham says the key question is not does it reason, but does it suffer? If the answer is yes, then it's deserving of moral consideration. It's the total amount of happiness, period, that we are really talking about. So we've got this scale. As soon as we think about it that way, we realize that we're given here the outline, the core text, as it were, of a theory of better and worse. But now, how is that going to look?
- 3.24** Here's how Bentham and Mill think of it. Imagine a scale from best to worst, and things are in different positions. There should be something like a zero on that scale. That is to say, my action has no effect on happiness of anyone, whatever, and probably a lot of our actions are like that. I move my hand like this. Anybody happier? Anybody more unhappy? No, right? It's pretty much a zero. The action is right there; it does no effect, positive or negative. There are lots of things that are like that.

- 3.25** Imagine then that we've got four possible courses of action that we're facing: one, two, three, and four. Let's say they go on the scale like this. One is best, four is worst. Well, already we know a lot. But let's come back to that and figure out then what we have to do as a result of that.
- 3.26** The second thing I want to focus on in that definition or that principle is the tendency talk. It's there in Bentham, too, "as they tend to promote happiness," or tend to promote unhappiness. That is an interesting way of framing it because Bentham and Mill are thinking about this primarily as a way of reaching decisions. It's a method for reaching decisions. I'm thinking about this before I act.
- 3.27** And now I think: What will the effects of this action be? Do we always know what the effects of our actions are going to be? No, in fact, often we don't. It's a matter of probabilities. And maybe sometimes we don't even have probabilities. We're just making vague guesses, thinking, "maybe this, maybe that." And so he says that we've got to focus on the tendencies of actions, not on their actual effects. We don't know those yet. If we have a method that says: see what it actually will do. Well, I won't know until I do it. That makes it a little tricky here.
- 3.28** Some actions have good tendencies and good effects. They tend to do this, and in this particular case, yes, that's the effect that happens. Good. Others have bad tendencies and indeed, in a particular case, bad effects. That's the normal case. But we can have actions that have a good tendency but produce a bad effect in a particular case. The doctor applies this treatment. It's normally the right treatment to give a patient with these symptoms. But in this particular case, that patient had a very unusual condition, and it was the wrong treatment to assign.
- 3.29** The doctor applying the method goes by the tendency, and that's the right thing to do in making the decision. Now, after the fact, we can say that it didn't work out very well in this case. Maybe it was the wrong thing to do. But we're interested in the before part, the context of deliberation about what to do, less the context of judgment after the fact. And so, as a decision method, we have to go about the tendency.
- 3.30** Similarly, some actions might have a bad tendency but have a good effect. For example, actually a medical example, again, I have for many, many years had high blood pressure and I'm on medication. I'm supposed to eat a low salt diet, but I actually also have low sodium. So I've got to actually consume a fair amount of salt. Now, normally, that would be a bad thing for someone with high blood pressure to consume a lot of salt—bad thing, bad tendency.
- 3.31** But in my weird case, it's actually good because my body gets rid of salt quickly, which is maybe part of my problem. But anyway, I'm a weird guy. I'm weird in that particular respect. If a doctor says, "Don't have much salt," that's the right thing to tell me to do until I pass out from low sodium, and then he says, "Okay, in your case, it's different."

- 3.32** Now, by the context of deliberation, as I mentioned, before the action, we have to go by tendencies. We don't know the actual effects. Once we have enough information after the fact, or maybe because something just like this happened before, or, "Hey, we know about your special medical condition," then we can judge according to the context of judgment. Maybe then we care about the actual effects, but that's after the fact. If we're thinking about how I decide, I have to decide on the basis of tendencies.
- 3.33** Let's go back to our scale. I've got these options ranked, better to worst. Now I think: What should I do? And what must I do? A lot of people think those are the same question, but some hear a difference. What should I do? That would be the best thing to do. But what do I have to do? What must I do? If you're like me, you hear that as a different question because maybe I really ought to do this, but this would be okay. I can do this. I got to do one or the other of these things, something in this range. That's the best one, but this would be okay. That is something that at least certain approaches to utilitarianism open up.
- 3.34** The real question comes down to this: Is there anything that would count as a supererogatory action? That's a fancy term derived from Latin. It means going above and beyond what is asked. Super-above-erogatory, what's asked. Can I go above and beyond the call of duty? If the answer is yes, there are actions that are above and beyond the call of duty, then that suggests I've done more than I really had to do. That suggests that I don't have to do the very best thing.
- 3.35** That brings us to these two different conceptions. I think in Bentham and Mill, there's actually a bit of waffling between them. For example, here, Bentham seems to express what is known as the satisficing concept, which means doing enough. Again, just Latin for doing enough. "An action may be conformable to the principle of utility, meaning with respect to the community at large, when the tendency it has to augment the happiness of the community is greater than it has to diminish it."
- 3.36** In other words, this action makes the world a better place. It makes people overall happier. It's okay. It conforms to my principle. If it makes the world worse, makes people unhappier, it does not conform. Essentially, here on this conception, the principle of utility says: choose the actions that tend to make the world a better place. There might be many such actions, but that's okay. As long as you do it in some way, you're good. You don't have to choose the best of all possible ones.
- 3.37** That would be like saying, "Hey, there, both options 1 and 2 are above zero. They make the world a better place." Now, you could say, "Well, maybe you should do option 1; it's the best. But option 2 is okay; it's acceptable." You have to do something that makes the world better. You certainly shouldn't choose 3 or 4, but it is possible to go above and beyond the call of duty. You're doing enough. You're doing, as it were, the least you can do by doing 2, but you can go above and beyond the call of duty by choosing option 1. That allows us to say that you should choose option 1, but what do you have to do? Choose 1 or 2. That makes utilitarianism fairly permissive. You get lots

of choice about what you can do. You just have to make a positive contribution to the world.

- 3.38** Sometimes, Bentham, however, seems to talk as if you have to choose the best thing. That's a maximizing conception. Here in another work, the Constitutional Code, he's saying "the greatest happiness of the whole community ought to be the end or object of pursuit. The right and proper end of government in every political community is the greatest happiness of the individuals of which it's composed, say, in other words, the greatest happiness of the greatest number."
- 3.39** And there he's saying that our object should be the greatest amount. Actually, I'm not sure that contradicts the satisficing idea because it might be that you ought to aim at the best thing, but it's okay to settle without achieving it. So it's not exactly a contradiction. But on the other hand, he's talking here about the greatest happiness ought to be our goal, the greatest happiness of the greatest number. It certainly suggests, come on, we ought to be doing the best. At least we ought to be aiming at the best. If you have that maximizing idea, then you're going to say, "Oh, I should do option 1, and in fact, I must. I must be maximizing."
- 3.40** And by the way, I should add that even though I find Bentham and Mill ambiguous on this question, or if anything, talking like it's enough to do enough, most utilitarians thought the 20th century assumed everybody meant maximizing. So most people think you have to do the best possible thing. But then it becomes very demanding. I mean, what's the best possible thing for the world I could be doing right now? I don't know. Maybe this is it, but maybe it's not. I mean, maybe I should be out feeding children in Africa or something. I don't know what the best thing is. So it becomes a very difficult theory to apply.
- 3.41** However, if I can be doing something to make the world a better place, I don't have to worry, "Is there something that would make it even better than what I'm doing now?" This theory also, or that approach to the theory, I might say, also makes these supererogatory acts impossible. There's no way to go above and beyond the call of duty because the call of duty is always to do the best possible thing.
- 3.42** Here are some basic thoughts underlying this utilitarian approach, however you interpret it. One is that more is better than less. We want more happiness as opposed to less happiness. Obviously, I don't mean more is better than less of anything. More potato chips are better than fewer potato chips? Not always. But happiness, yes. In fact, the good, according to Bentham and Mill, is happiness. They identified that with pleasure in the absence of pain, but they have a very broad conception of pleasure and pain, so it's not as different from Aristotle as you might initially think.
- 3.43** Also, a very fundamental idea is that everyone counts equally. This is what distinguishes in part utilitarianism from other consequentialism. I could think, "Hey, I'm a consequentialist. I want the best consequences for me. I don't care about anybody

else." That egoism would be a version of consequentialism, but it's not utilitarian. Utilitarianism says that you can't count your own happiness as worth any more than anybody else's happiness. Everybody's happiness counts and counts equally. "All count for one and no one more than one," Bentham says.

- 3.44** In one sense, we've got some very basic things that underlie utility theory in general in economics. This idea of optimizing—more value is better than less, assuming you've got the right value. "Why would any one, whether God or man, desire to make himself worse?" would desire something worse, writes Plato. Russell Hardin, a contemporary thinker, says "the simplest definition of rationality...is the one to choose more rather than less value." Here, value is being interpreted as in the end, happiness, and not just for yourself, but for everyone concerned.
- 3.45** But this is tricky because people choose under various constraints. If we start thinking about these two approaches—satisficing, settling for enough, as opposed to maximizing, insisting on the best—we realize this is a subtler thing to think about than you might initially think. Why? Because we're always choosing under constraints, and maybe what looks like settling for enough is really maximizing under those constraints. At a certain point, I decide, "I don't know if this is the best thing to do, but it seems like a good thing to do, so I'm going to do it."
- 3.46** Why don't I persist in thinking, "But wait, maybe I could think of something better." Partly because of constraints. I don't have an infinite amount of time. I don't have an infinite amount of energy. There are many sources of constraints. I have limited time. A lot of things that I do cost money or cost me something in other ways. I've got a limited amount of resources.
- 3.47** Sometimes it's a question of scope: I can't think about that many things all at once. I've got to focus on certain things. Sometimes it's a matter of quality. Let's say somebody comes in and says, "This is the best automobile you could buy." I might think that there are still many reasons why I'm not going to buy it. Maybe it costs too much.
- 3.48** Maybe, really, I'm willing to settle for lower quality because maybe that one really doesn't satisfy my needs in some other respect. Maybe I need to—I mean, I don't, but maybe I need to haul musical equipment around to lots of gigs, and then I need something that would enable me to do that. The fact that the Porsche is the best possible car, but I can't fit the drums in the back. There are lots of various constraints that I'm going to operate under.
- 3.49** Actually, that has been one of the main motives for people talking about satisficing, saying that once you recognize that our rationality is bounded by all these constraints we have to operate under, all the limitations that face us, then actually trying to do the best we can under those constraints is going to look like satisficing.
- 3.50** Herbert Simon and a variety of other people in economics have introduced that idea as a way of not conflicting with maximizing and choosing the best, but instead saying,

really, in practice, that's what we do. We settle for good enough because in doing that, we're maximizing not the thing we're seeking—and if you're utilitarians, then global happiness—but instead we're maximizing that together, with meeting all of those constraints, saying, "That's the best I can do given these resources, given this time, given this scope," and so forth.

- 3.51** Now, so far, I've been pretty vague about how we figure out these consequences. So how do we really do it? Well, here is what Bentham describes as the moral or the felicific calculus, felicific meaning, having to do with happiness. So think about all the people your action might affect. In a lot of personal cases, this is a relatively small number of people. In some cases, it's more. In some cases, if you're a political agent of some kind, you're a legislator or a president, prime minister, it might be millions of people.
- 3.52** You've got to think about those people and then say, "What is the tendency toward pleasures for that particular person? What is the potential, the tendency for pain?" Think about the difference. I've got to think, "How will this affect you?" Then I realize that I don't know what the outcome is, so I can't really assign a direct number to that. It might benefit you in this way. It might actually cost you something in this way. Now I've got to think, "What's the likelihood of that?" So, I've got to think about the possible range of outcomes and assign them probabilities and think what happens to you under each of those outcomes, and then do a calculation of expected utility.
- 3.53** This is actually a method that businesses use in cost-benefit analysis and that economists use in expected utility theory. This has now been developed into something of an art form, and there's a lot written about it mathematically. But the idea is really just that, and it gets complicated. I'm thinking, just focus on one person. "How does my action affect that person?" Well, it might be to their benefit, but I've got to think this through carefully. What are the possible outcomes of the action?
- 3.54** Let's say there are five of them. I've got to assign each of those outcomes a probability. Then I've got to think, "How does it affect person A under each of those outcomes?" Then I have to do a calculation, taking together the sum of all of those things, figuring out that's the expected pleasure for A. Now, sometimes this is something that's easy to do. Somebody says, "Hey, I'll bet you this coin will end up tails." I think, "What's my expected payoff for doing this?" We bet a certain amount of money. It's 50-50, assuming it's a fair coin. Pretty easy to figure out my expected benefit and my expected loss. In a game like that, it's usually zero. I mean, expected benefit will be the winning, whatever it is. The loss is whatever that is, and they balance out.
- 3.55** But that's a very simple case of what we'd have to do for each person who might be affected and each possible outcome. It becomes really complicated. We have to start by identifying the options we have. We've got a bunch of different options for our decision. Then we think in each case: Who might be affected by my undertaking that action? Those in some parts of the literature are called stakeholders.

- 3.56** Then we think, I've got to compute the expected benefits and the expected costs for each of those stakeholders under each of those possible actions. I've got to think about the probabilities and the outcomes and how it affects that person. Then I've got to assign the costs and benefits to each of the outcomes by doing that expected calculation, summing all these things up. Then I think, let's add it all up. Is there a net benefit to the whole? Is there a net cost? Then I do that for each option. I compare the options to put them on that scale.
- 3.57** All of that makes it sound nightmarishly complicated. It can be. It can be very difficult. If I've got a lot of options facing me and there are a lot of possible outcomes, I've got to assign them probabilities and think through all of this. It's really very difficult. Now, there are advantages to thinking of it this way.
- 3.58** One is objectivity. I've got to think about things from different points of view. If this is going to affect a number of different people, I have to think about how it affects them. And so I have to be empathetic. I have to see it from that person's point of view. What's the likelihood it will benefit them? What's the likelihood it will hurt them? So it forces me to confront externalities. I've got to think about how my actions affect others.
- 3.59** It also makes us think this through at a pretty sophisticated level of depth. I've got to think about the possible outcomes. We're bad at this, by the way. People tend to think about a few possible outcomes, often about the one they intend. They don't think about what if something goes wrong. It's important to think about those different possible outcomes. This theory forces us to do that, or at least strongly suggests that we do it.
- 3.60** Now, it does make certain assumptions in the calculation. We've got to be able to compare these effects. One of the tricky questions is whether pleasures and pains are really comparable in this way. I think Bentham and Mill both tend to assume, and economists, in applying this, tend to assume that pain is something like the opposite of pleasure. It's just the negative part of the scale, so we can put all of these on one scale. But if you doubt that, you start realizing that it becomes complicated.
- 3.61** Actually, at one point, Mill seems to concede that maybe they don't belong on the same scale. But then we have the pleasure scale, in other words, the benefit scale. We have the cost scale. We don't know how to put them together. It's actually rather bad if we can't compare them. If you're an economist and you're thinking it's all money, then they're all comparable. But if you are a moral theorist thinking about benefits and costs in the sense of pleasures and pains, it's not so clear we can do that.
- 3.62** The second assumption is that we've got to be able to compare short-term and long-term pleasures and pains. This is what Socrates thought we're all bad at and why we're often ignorant when we look weak of will. We're bad at calculating how my short-term benefit from eating that bag of cashews is going to compromise my long-term goal of losing weight. In the end, we find it hard to make the comparison.

- 3.63** Bentham and Mill are granting that it's hard, but we have to do it. And so what we have to do in this theory to compare them is to have something like a discount rate. In other words, how much better is it for me to have a pleasure now than to have it a year later? I care more about what happens to me now than a year later, typically. Would you rather have me slap you now or slap you in a year? Well, most of us would say, "I'll wait a year for the slap. I hope it never happens."
- 3.64** Similarly, "I'll give you \$100 now or I'll give it to you a year from now." It's like, "I'll take it now." So there is something about the nearness of these that diminishes over time, and that will enable us to make these comparisons between the short-term and the long-term, but it's not obvious how we choose that discount rate. Bentham and Mill think that you just see what people do. Look at people's real choices. That's what economists tend to say as well: see the choices people really make. We can estimate, through experience, the discount rate.
- 3.65** The third assumption that's really important is interpersonal comparisons. How does the benefit to me compare to the benefit to you? We've said everybody counts for one and nobody counts more than one. But now we have to say: How much do my enjoyments track with yours? In other words, maybe I can bring out the point most clearly this way.
- 3.66** Maybe I care about this thing more than you do, so I'm going to actually be affected by it more. Maybe I'm just an excitable person. My happiness levels go like this. I'm really happy. "Oh, that's fantastic." Or, "Oh, this is terrible," and so on. Whereas you're much more mellow, even keel. Like, "This is nice. It could be better." How do we compare that? Actually, it becomes a tricky practical question to some extent.
- 3.67** We might think, hold on a second. It's the same thing that's happened. In fact, maybe we have similar incomes, similar levels of wealth, and we each lose \$100. It really annoys you, and it doesn't annoy me so much. Well, what do we do? We've both lost \$100, but one person is very upset about it, the other person, not so much. How do we make those comparisons?
- 3.68** Here, the problem is that it's hard enough to compare two things, two pleasures, two pains within my own head. You give me, let's say—I don't know if you have this decision problem, I do—you go into an ice cream place, they offer you to taste various flavors. You think, "Oh, the Dutch chocolate; that's quite good." How about the maple walnut? "Oh, that's really good, too." I've just experienced two pleasures, and now I have to compare them and decide which is better. I have a hard time. Even within myself, it's hard.
- 3.69** But now I'm looking at you and seeing you taste the ice creams. You say, "Oh, that's very good." I don't know how to compare your level of pleasure as a result of eating the ice creams to my level. It seems like it's hard enough to know in my own head. How do I know what's going on in your head? So a lot of economists give up on this. They just

say, "Yeah, we can't do the interpersonal comparisons," and that's going to mean we can't calculate in the way of getting sums and having a simple scale of the kind the utilitarian wants. We can, under certain circumstances, still get some results. It's not like we give up entirely, but it changes and becomes considerably more complicated.

3.70 Now, another consideration is: How do we get to the cardinal numbers this theory requires? You say, "Which ice cream did you like better?" Let's say I say, "Oh, I guess the maple walnut." They say, "Well, how much better?" Give them numbers. On a scale of 0-10. Actually, let's go below zero because maybe an ice cream is terrible. From plus 10 to minus 10, where does this rank? "I don't know."

3.71 In hospitals, they will ask patients, "You're experiencing pain. On a scale of zero to 10, what's your level of pain?" There is something that people can say. People say, "I feel like I'm at a seven." But do people mean the same thing by that? They can probably rank pains pretty clearly according to how they're feeling, but how to put them on some general scale, that seems really hard.

3.72 Finally, something Mill worries about a lot, there are different kinds of pleasures. I come into some money—yay, it makes me feel good. I meet a friend that I haven't seen in a long time—that's good. I have some ice cream at the shop, choose the maple, all that—yummy. It's good. How do I compare those? They're very different pleasures, and it's hard to say how we map them to some scale.

3.73 Here's one way of framing this set of problems, really: utility is subjective. It's happening within your head and within my head. How much pleasure and pain we're getting, how much happiness we're experiencing. That radical subjectivity is something that causes a problem. There might be a lot of interpersonal agreements. Here is Chateau Saint-Michel in France. Almost everyone is going to look at that and say, "Wow, that is beautiful."

3.74 So I don't mean to say that it's so subjective that people are going to radically disagree about everything. You'll probably agree that the bank is really ugly. In fact, that's the contrast between those two buildings. Who's going to say, "Oh, yeah, that's my thing"? I don't know. But nevertheless, there's a huge amount of subjective variation, and that's going to be a problem.

3.75 None of these objections, I think, are fatal, but they all point to ways in which the theory might have to be complicated, and we've got to be careful about how we apply it and where we apply it. But Bentham still would say, I'm telling you, this is the only way we can go about it. Really, in the end, these problems are just ones we have to cope with. He gives us certain arguments for this view.

3.76 One is common sense. He says that our common-sense moral judgments agree with the principle of utility. For example, take a look at some of the things in the Ten Commandments: Thou shalt not murder. What's wrong with murder? It makes people unhappy. Okay, very clear. Wiping out happiness, in general, detracts from the

happiness of the community. What about stealing? The same thing. What about adultery? The same thing.

- 3.77** What about coveting your neighbor's goods? That's just internal. No effects, right? Well, it makes you less happy, and it leads you to do things that make other people unhappy. Honor your father and mother—it'll help you grow up better and give you role models, and so, consequently, make the world a better place. In short, he's going to say all of those things if you say, "Really, why is there such a rule?" The simplest thing to say is that it makes the world better. It promotes human happiness.
- 3.78** Another argument he gives is that any argument for a different theory really presupposes the principle of utility. Because suppose you say to Aristotle, "You think it's good for people to be witty. That's one of your virtues. Who cares about wit? I don't care if people are funny. I suggest that people be serious. Forget humor. There should be no fun in utilitarians."
- 3.79** If we say that, Bentham is going to say that that's going to make the world a worse place. Why is wit a good thing? Because it makes life more enjoyable. Because we laugh and we like to laugh. It adds to the pleasures of human existence. So what's justifying that as a virtue? What would make the person being somber all the time, wrong-headed about this is that you're going to be a lot less happy, and people in general are going to be a lot less happy. The same thing is going to be true with Kant's categorical imperative. Why should I treat other people with respect? Well, look, what happens if I don't? It's going to detract from human happiness.
- 3.80** The last one—and this is, I think, a very powerful argument: we can resolve conflicts. We've got to have a measure of value that allows us to do that. Here, Bentham is looking at other moral theories saying, I don't actually see how they help me make a decision. We talked about virtue theory and said that there's a puzzle. If I'm not already virtuous, I don't know what a virtuous person would do. So if you tell me, "Do what a virtuous person would do," it doesn't help me.
- 3.81** But he says, It's worse than that. Suppose you've got an action that actually is somewhat unkind, but it's honest. So you ask me a question, and I'm thinking of giving you a dishonest answer because I don't want to hurt your feelings. An honest answer will hurt your feelings. So I face a conflict. And I think, well, yes, I should be honest, but I should also be kind. But in this case, I can't really be both. So what should I do?
- 3.82** Aristotle's theory doesn't really help us settle that at all. What would a virtuous person do? Well, they'd be honest, but I can't be both. I don't know. I have no way of ranking or comparing those virtues or how they would apply in this particular case. So I still don't know what to do.
- 3.83** The same thing you might think is true of Kant's theory. I've got two people who are—really, I'm engaged in a conflict between them, and I find myself suddenly in the middle, and I'm thinking, "I want to treat both of you with respect, but you're treating

each other with great disrespect, and I don't know how to do that. You both want me to choose a side. I don't want to choose a side, but that's starting to offend both of you." I don't know what to do.

- 3.84** You might think, "Kant doesn't really help me out there. Treat both of you with respect." Well, I'll try to do that, but on the other hand, I don't know what I should do being pulled in these different directions. So Bentham says, here's a way of doing it. We can calculate. Indeed, medieval thinkers had said that, faced with these moral conflicts, we need to choose the lesser evil. Bentham is, in effect, saying exactly that. I'm giving you a way of computing what is the lesser evil, or if it's a positive conflict, what's the greater good.
- 3.85** Now, there are complications to this. I've already mentioned qualities of pleasures. But since this gets more air time than it's worth, actually, I'll talk about it a little bit more directly here. Thomas Carlyle, a well-known Victorian writer, objected to Mill that he was really ignoring something very important in human existence. He wrote that utilitarianism was a philosophy fit for swine.
- 3.86** Why? Because it identified the good with feeling good. Insofar as the good is just happiness and pleasure in the absence of pain, the good is just feeling good, and evil is just feeling bad. He said: Where's virtue in this? Where's concern? Where's love? Where's thinking? Where's rationality? It looks like you're just saying, "Hey, feel as good as possible. Make other people feel as good as possible." This sounds like a "grab for all the gusto you can" philosophy. He said that maybe that works for pigs in the barnyard, but it doesn't work for human beings.
- 3.87** In the 1830s, there's an exchange of letters between Carlyle and Mill about this. In the 1830s, Mill's response is this: our goal is to maximize the good for all people. In fact, he says that we have to think about that over time because you need to think in terms of future people as well as people who exist right now. We should be thinking about mankind as a species and thinking about this developing over time. But that has a couple of important implications, he says.
- 3.88** First of all, I do, in general, do best at that by promoting my own good. He says that each of us, if we tend to our own self-interest, is actually usually going to be promoting the general welfare. I think he's influenced by Adam Smith here and the arguments in *The Wealth of Nations*, that in general, if I'm looking out for my welfare, you are for yours, we're going to be promoting each other, partly because I gain what I want by making other people around me happy, so that they will give me what I want. So there's going to be a tendency in which I don't have to think about the happiness of others a whole lot. Most of the time, thinking about my own is enough.
- 3.89** But the other aspect of this is that I have reason to develop my capacities, my abilities, my talents, my intellect, because they produce benefits for everyone. The whole idea is to make the world a better place. If I become virtuous, I'm going to be making it a

better place. If I become more knowledgeable, if I become wiser, I'm going to be making the world a better place, and similarly, if I develop my talents.

- 3.90** So the idea here is that I'm going to have obligations to do all those things. I'm not going to be able to live like a pig because I want to make the world a better place. The pig isn't really doing that. The pig may be rolling around in the mud, and cavorting, and so on, but it's not really adding to the happiness of other pigs. It's helping itself. It's not helping anybody else. But as human beings, well, we're not just pigs. So we actually have an obligation to do these things.
- 3.91** Now, in utilitarianism, some 30 to 40 years later, he adds a different argument. He continues to affirm that argument. But he says that there's another point. Pleasure is different in quality as well as in quantity. Here, he doesn't just mean different kinds, like the pleasure of a pasta dish as opposed to the pleasure of ice cream as opposed to the pleasure of walking through the woods on a snowy evening and blah, blah, blah. It's not that. He says that there are things that are distinctively human. It's better to be a human being dissatisfied than a pig satisfied.
- 3.92** Why? Well, it's better to be a human being dissatisfied than a pig satisfied because human beings are capable of better pleasures than pigs are. It's not just that we have more pleasure, we have better pleasure. As soon as you get that idea, you can already maybe see the danger because now we have different pleasures. Some are better than others. We all, in the end, have to map them onto a single scale, though. How is that all going to work? We've got to decide, for one thing, which pleasures are higher.
- 3.93** Mill says, no problem. See what the competent judges prefer. Well, who are the competent judges? Those who have experienced both, he says. You want to find out whether the pleasure of gorging yourself on a delicious meal is better than the pleasure of a good conversation with a friend. Lots of us have experienced both of those things. Which would we prefer? Then whatever we say makes that the better pleasure. If we disagree, that means they're roughly equal. That's the idea.
- 3.94** The way he thinks that goes is that intellectual pleasure is the best. Anybody acquainted with intellectual pleasures as well as the social pleasures of friendship and love, and then purely sensual pleasures like lying on the beach on a beautiful day, drinking a Corona—those things, they're going to say, no, the intellectual pleasure is better.
- 3.95** I mean, would you rather get a great new insight or would you rather drink a beer? He said that, obviously, get a great new insight. Would you rather hang out with friends and have a wonderful time talking together, or would you rather gorge yourself on this meal? You'd rather hang out with friends. So he thinks that people are overwhelmingly going to choose things in a certain direction.
- 3.96** Yeah, I sometimes say he's never met my students. So it worries me a bit. But his answer is, I realize a lot of people would not go along with this, but it's because they

don't truly know the other side of things. They don't truly know. I mean, ask the pig what it prefers. It prefers pigish pleasures. But that's because it hasn't experienced these distinctively human pleasures. So you've got to ask those who are competent with both, who are familiar with both. Really, what it just means, if the students have a different view, that means the students don't really have acquaintance with those higher pleasures.

- 3.97** You may find this convincing. You may find it unconvincing. But in any case, Mill thinks that's how it goes. Bentham, interestingly, rejects this. The standard scholarly line is that Bentham ignores this question of qualities of pleasure. He dumps them all into one barrel. That is totally unfair. He has a chapter in which he discusses the different kinds and subkinds, and it's complicated. So he knows there are many different pleasures, many different qualities of pleasures.
- 3.98** In fact, in one place, he says that, of course, pleasures differ in quality as well as in quantity. In regard to well-being, quality as well as quantity has to be taken into account. But who gets to judge? He says, that you do. Quantity depends on general sensibility. In other words, how much pleasure are you experiencing? He thinks we can make these interpersonal comparisons.
- 3.99** I think in the end, his picture is neurophysiological. He thinks that if we just knew enough, we'd know how much certain brain pathways are being excited, and we'd be able to put a number to your level of pleasure, or conversely, your level of pain. He says, in the end, I think neurophysiology will take care of that problem.
- 3.100** But what about quality? He says that that's a matter of particular sensibility. Some people are more sensitive to pleasures and pains from a certain area. Would you rather read a philosophy book, go to a hockey game, or listen to a symphony? No reason why everybody has to agree. And Bentham is going to say, I'm not saying that that makes them all roughly equal. I'm saying it's absurd to think that people who have done all those things are going to agree or that it matters whether they agree. The point is: do you enjoy hockey? Go to the hockey game. You like the symphony? Go to the symphony. It's all fine.
- 3.101** So he sees this as fundamental to preserving liberty. Why? Because I've got to respect your ability to make these comparisons on your own. He says, I can know the quality for me just by reflecting and by experiencing things, but I can't tell what's a better pleasure for you except by seeing what you actually choose. So in the end, you get to be the judge of what's a better pleasure for you, and you get to be a judge of what's better for you, and so on. I shouldn't be in a position of saying that this one is generally better, because guess what? I and my friends would much rather read the philosophy book than go to the symphony or go to the hockey game.
- 3.102** Mill, on the other hand, says, I want to preserve liberty, too. But now he's going to do it in a different way because he thinks he can actually make judgments about better and

worse in terms of these qualities of pleasures. However, he also has a principle that's often called the harm principle. The idea is that we should restrict liberty only to prevent harm to others.

3.103 So around each individual, there should be a sphere of self-regarding actions, things that either don't affect other people at all or at least do not violate their rights. And then you should be free to act however you want within that sphere. Does that follow from the principle of utility? Well, indirectly, he thinks the answer is yes, because we're all going to be happier if we respect those boundaries.

3.104 Say, if it affects just you, then I'm not going to tell you how to live. You get to make those choices on your own. You think the best possible pleasure for you would be sitting around in a drunken and stoned haze, then I shouldn't interfere with that as long as you don't hurt anybody else. If somebody else thinks, "I just want to go to the library and spend my life in the library." Okay, you go do your thing. Nobody else should tell you that that's okay or that that's required or that that's not okay.

3.105 Now, there are some objections to utilitarians I want to consider. One that Mill brings up himself is time. Am I not going to spend much of my life calculating? I mean, this sounds complicated. So what should I do for dinner? Well, gosh, mostly I'm affected, but other people might be affected, too. And so I've got to think through the possible effects on all those people and so on.

3.106 That sounds difficult. It's going to take me way longer than dinner time to do that. Are there times when we shouldn't, don't have to calculate? How can I tell? Do I have to calculate whether or not to calculate? Maybe I have to calculate about whether or not to calculate about whether or not to calculate. How do we know when we've calculated enough?

3.107 All these sound a little bit silly, but think about politics. When you get into that general framework, you start realizing that it does sometimes feel like we've all agreed for decades that this is a major social problem, and we still have committees and reports and commissions to study the problem. They produce proposals that are viewed by the committees. How can we tell when it's time to just do something? It's not a trivial question.

3.108 Now, Mill says that it's not a severe question as you might think either because the principle of utility is going to judge actions by their effects on happiness, making it better or worse. But it doesn't have to be our motivation. It doesn't even have to be a practical test. We usually apply it by relying on secondary principles.

3.109 I'm thinking, "Should I steal that car?" I don't have to think, "Let me calculate." I can just think, "Yeah, we've had the whole history of the human race to figure out that stealing is bad." I can rely on that. I can use those common-sense principles. They're supported by utility, and they generally give me the right answer. I don't have to do all the calculations ex nihilo.

- 3.110** The same thing is going to be true for a lot of other moral decisions I make, including ones where I just say, "I don't have to do a calculation. I don't have to worry about anybody else. I'm looking at the menu: What do I want? I should just choose what I want. I don't really have to do a calculation about the effects on other people." Those rules are justified by utility, and they let us take shortcuts. Really, we're only going to have to do calculations when we get into a situation of conflict and those moral rules conflict.
- 3.111** Then, I'll realize, other theories, he says, leave us far worse off. We got a conflict, we don't know what to do. Utilitarianism says, "I've got a method. Now we can do the calculation." Things like Ross's principles, they're all going to look like good principles from a utilitarian point of view. They all promote happiness, so it's easy to justify them. Then you say, "Oh, but wait a minute, I've got a situation of conflict. I can help this person only at the cost of hurting that person." Let's do the calculation. How much are you helping? How much are you hurting? If it's something like a tax law, it might be a lot of people; it'll get complicated, but still, that's how we need to think it through. When we get into a situation of conflict, calculate.
- 3.112** We're going to find that all over the place. We've already mentioned that there can be conflicts between various applications of Kant's principle, different virtues in Aristotle or Confucius, and there might be larger ones. Maybe I can get better results by actually disrespecting somebody by using them merely as a means. Or what if I can do something that gets better results by acting in a way that's really not very virtuous? There can be such situations, and we have to decide what we want to do.
- 3.113** In the end, the utilitarian says, "I'm going to do the calculation." I realize undermining that virtue is bad. I realize using someone as a means is bad. On the other hand, maybe sometimes I actually have to do it. And wartime gives us great examples of that: there are civilians there in that town, but we need to bomb the town to eliminate the munitions factory. Using those civilians may be merely as a means to do it, but maybe that's what we have to do.
- 3.114** Similarly, maybe we actually have to be vicious in this connection or in another. It is possible to say that we could be in situations like that. Could we ever know enough to know that we're in one? But I think the answer is that maybe sometimes we do know the consequences well enough.
- 3.115** One last point: many of the objections to utilitarians depend on rights. And Bentham is dismissive. He writes it's nonsense. Natural rights, as in John Locke, he says, that's nonsense on stilts. It's no use for human rights at all. But Mill says that's not right. "When we call something a person's right, all we mean is he has a valid claim on society to protect him in the possession of it, either by the force of law or of education and opinion."

- 3.116** In other words, if you say, "I have a right to property," what that means is society should help me protect my property. Why should it do that? Utility. In the end, we're all better off if society protects your possession of your property, or your possession of your life or your possession of your liberty. To say you have a right isn't some magical thing that comes out of the sky independently of human happiness. We protect certain rights because they make us all happier and make up communities where we protect and promote the happiness of the people in them. In the end, to have a right is to have something society ought to defend me in the possession of. Why? Utility. We'll all be better off if it protects those.
- 3.117** Well, there are many, many conflicts we could go through. I have a long part of the slideshow here that actually discusses this conflict, that conflict, and so on. But it's actually going to be the same answer to all of them. I will talk about one here just to illustrate the general point, one from Plato's Republic. "Suppose a friend in his right mind has deposited arms with me and he asks for them when he's not in his right mind, should I give them back?" So you've borrowed his knife. He wants the knife back when he's furious and angry and going crazy. Do you give him the knife back?
- 3.118** The utilitarian says no because the consequences of giving him the knife back are likely to be very, very bad. So you promised to give it back to him when he needed it. That's a promise you should break. Why? It's going to detract from happiness. Basically, that's going to be the utilitarian response to all of these conflicts. Some people are going to think it's the wrong response, in some cases. The utilitarian will insist that if you take into account the long-term consequences, it's going to be the right one. The end.
- 3.119** With utilitarianism, there's the premise that all people's good or happiness is equal. Do you see that as a weak point? Because there are those that have what would be considered a higher station, a general, perhaps, over a grunt, someone a leader over a standard civilian, where that could become very problematic or someone who employs 500 people compared to one of their employees, where that's not really an equal thing.
- 3.120** All right. A great question. How does this compare to those hierarchical structures I mentioned, where there are authority ranking relationships and subordinates and superiors? How do we think about it in that context? It's interesting what we do, actually, because we tend to think— suppose we're in a lifeboat scenario and we have people of different ages. Let's say it's all members of one family. It's clear that we have one more person than can actually survive in this lifeboat. One person has to go for the others to be able to survive, otherwise the boat sinks. Who do you throw overboard? Horrible question.
- 3.121** You might think, "Oh, well, the person who is superior—do we throw over the baby because it's the least in this social hierarchy?" No, usually we would say—I mean, there are some cultures that would say yes, but I think our culture would tend to say, "No, it has the most—" The utilitarian would say, "We're thinking about the future life wiped out. It has many more life years. It has a much greater potential for happiness. Throw

over the old guy." That makes a certain amount of sense from a utilitarian point of view.

3.122 But now, if we transfer that to a different context, we say that a certain number of people have to be laid off in this company. Who should we lay off? There, we have to think, presumably, about the welfare. Usually, the company thinks about the welfare of the company. But if we think about this from a utilitarian point of view and we think we're concerned with everybody's happiness here. We do want the company to survive, so that's really important. But we have also got to think about the effects on people and who's going to be most vulnerable and so on.

3.123 I think it's unclear where that comes out. Sometimes we think, "We have to lay off the people at the bottom because these people's decisions are going to make the difference." Sometimes we think, "No, that's too awful. We shouldn't do that." I had a friend who was faced with this problem. He had to make a cut in his department's budget. As a result, he simply resigned because his salary was large enough to be the amount they had to cut. He could have cut maybe 10 to 20 people in his area, or he could just resign. He said, "I'd rather preserve those jobs, and I resign."

3.124 I think it's a noble action of his. Was that good for the company or bad for the company? I don't know. Was it overall good for people? Almost certainly, yes. The utilitarian would tend to applaud that. But now, to put it in a military context, and thinking about lives, the utilitarian wants to say that all lives are more important. On the other hand, if you're thinking about the objective, whose life matters more to that? The lives themselves are going to have equal value. But in terms of the larger scale picture, maybe the success of our army is going to save a lot of lives and add tremendously to happiness and avoid a huge negative. How best do we do that?

3.125 Maybe there we say that the general's life is worth more than that private's life simply because that person's decisions are going to make a huge impact on the overall outcome of the war; this person's won't. But it's not because this person's life is worth more than that one. It's because overall, making the decisions on that basis are going to lead to the best outcome.

3.126 I think it's going to be highly sensitive to the nature of this hierarchy, what's at stake, what the overall effects are. But we can't get away from the idea that a life is a life no matter whose it is. However, if one person is going to have a much greater effect on other lives than somebody else, they are going to indirectly, in that way, end up being more valuable as a result. What would be lives in the military can become money in a business context.

3.127 But then, in other contexts, for example, within a family, do you do what the kids want to do or do you do what the parents want to do? It may depend on how loud and obnoxious your kids are, because their decisions then and what they do might have a huge effect on the parents' happiness. The parents may be better able to say, "Yeah,

we'll go to Chuck E. Cheese again for dinner," and be able to deal with that better than the kids will.

3.128 I think it's going to be sensitive to a lot of the things that are details of the situation. But that's exactly what the utilitarian would say. Sure, some people are going to have bigger effects on other people's happiness than other people will, and we need to take all that into account.

Lecture 4: On Realism

At a glance — On realism.

- 4.1 Today, we're going to be talking about realism, and in particular, some of the foundational principles and foundational figures of Western philosophy. Alfred North Whitehead said that all of Western philosophy could be considered a footnote to Plato. I think that's a bit misleading. Really, Plato and Aristotle, in my view, give us two foundations and two traditions developed throughout Western philosophy. Some are footnotes to Plato, others are footnotes to Aristotle.
- 4.2 I had a teacher once who said the more he read Plato and Aristotle, the more he was convinced they were in agreement. I think that's totally wrong. I think they're in fundamental disagreement and that there are two traditions competing, sharing ideas, to be sure, but nevertheless really different in their fundamental assumptions.
- 4.3 For the first half of today, I'm going to talk about the Platonic tradition and its roots in Plato, and then we'll move on to Aristotle and try to get an understanding of how they think it's true that some things are independent of mind, but they're going to focus on different basic things. So it's important to recognize that what Plato takes as fundamental, Aristotle doesn't think exists at all. What Aristotle takes as fundamental, Plato considers merely a shadow. So we're going to see two very different ways of looking at the world. They both agree that there is a world independent of us, a world that's really out there. But their idea of what it consists in, is completely different.
- 4.4 Before we begin, let's think about the question of what there is. I've said that in philosophy, you could think of three basic questions: What is there? How do we know? Then what do we do, or how should we live? Let's focus on that first question: What is there? That question isn't raised in the context of saying that there are cameras and there are lecterns and there are glasses of water and so on. The question is really: What is fundamental?
- 4.5 Willard Van Orman Quine, a philosopher who taught for many years at Harvard, put it this way, "A curious thing about the ontological problem"— that question of what there is—"is its simplicity. It can be put in three Anglo-Saxon monosyllables: 'What is there?' It can be answered, moreover, in a word—'Everything' —and everyone will accept the answer as true. But that's merely to say that there is what there is. There remains room for disagreement over cases, and so the issue has stayed alive down the centuries." Indeed, there is a difference over the cases, the particular things that are fundamental.
- 4.6 In that context, let's go back to ancient Greece and look at Plato and Aristotle, think about the perspectives they have on what reality really is and how they differ. Aristotle is one of the foundational figures of Western philosophy. He was a student of Plato and a teacher of Alexander the Great. He gives us a simple argument for realism. He says,

"In general, if only the sensible exists, there'd be nothing if animate things were not, for there'd be no faculty of sense."

- 4.7 In other words, he says, how do I know that there really is a world independent of my mind? He says, suppose that no sentient creatures existed. Suppose there were no human beings, no animals. It's not that distant a hypothesis to imagine a universe without any life in it at all. But if everything depends on a mind, then such a universe couldn't exist. There wouldn't be anything if there were no minds.
- 4.8 Yet it seems obvious that there could be a universe without any minds. In fact, we tend to think that the history of our own universe for millions of years consisted of things that existed, but there were no minds. And that hypothesis, if we deny realism, seems like a contradiction. He says that here's another way of looking at it. "For sensation isn't just a sensation of itself." It's not just a sensation of nothing. There's got to be something it's the sensation of. There's got to be something beyond that sensation.
- 4.9 If I look at a glass of water, for example, there must be something that actually causes my sense organs to have that sensation of a glass of water. It seems absurd to think that it's just a fantasy and that there's nothing there at all. So the idea is that sensations are sensations of something. Otherwise, they're nothing but dreams, nothing but fantasies or hallucinations. There must be something prior to the sensation itself. That, whatever it is, has to be a mind-independent cause of the sensation. Call it a thing in itself—that's Kant's term for this thing. But whatever you think of it as, it's going to be something that the sensation is actually a sensation of.
- 4.10 In order to understand the difference between Plato and Aristotle on what's really fundamental—on what there is—we need to draw a distinction that both of them would accept, though they have different attitudes about what's fundamental here. It's the distinction between particulars and universals.
- 4.11 What do I mean by a particular? It's a thing that can't have multiple instances. For example, Dan Bonevac. There's one of me. There can't be multiple instances of me. Even if you cloned me somehow and created a bunch of different copies, as in the movie *Multiplicity*, still, we'd be different beings, different particulars. We wouldn't be just a bunch of Dan Bonevacs. The same thing is true for anybody else. At the time, I was thinking of these examples. It was around the time of the beginning of the First World War, and I was teaching that. So, Gavrilo Princip or the Archduke Francis Ferdinand, those two are particular people.
- 4.12 Then, we can talk about various entities like the Empire State Building or the Perry-Castañeda Library, or a particular glass of water, or a beach ball, or a grain of sand. In other words, a particular thing. It can be a place. It could be Austin or Phoenix, Texas, Arizona, Sarajevo. Wherever it is, that's a particular place. It could be a particular time, a particular date. It could be an event. But anyway, these are particular things. There's one of them.

- 4.13 A universal, in contrast, is something that can have multiple instances. A lot of these are properties: red—lots of things are red. Triangular—lots of things are triangular in shape. Large—lots of things are large. And then relations. Between—here are many things that are between other things or things that are sitting on other things. Love is such a universal. It's a relation. But there are many instances of love, many instances of friendship.
- 4.14 And then, we can talk about kinds like tiger. There are lots of individual tigers or human beings, many humans, many buildings, many pencils, many short stops. There are lots of different instances of those particular universals. We can also talk about books this way. The Bible, for example. There are many different instances, many different translations, but they're all particular instances of the Bible. That would be true of any book. You take any novel, any non-fiction work, there can be many copies of it. It would be disappointing if Amazon could sell you only one copy, and once that copy was gone, it's gone. But no, there can be many copies of the same book. The same thing is true of musical works as well.
- 4.15 Artistic works, that's more controversial. If you have the Mona Lisa, the original, and then have many different copies of it, or, in a famous case, Duchamp submitted the Fountain to an artistic exhibit. It was just a urinal, and he wrote "R. Mutt, 1917" on it. Then he took it back to the plumbing supply place. He didn't think it had any particular significance, but it became very famous. And so what did he do? He bought a bunch more urinals, wrote "R. Mutt, 1917," and sold them all.
- 4.16 So maybe there are many copies of the Fountain, or maybe you say that it was the original one, so really, all of these are just duplicates. Well, I can't say duplicates, but maybe they're just imitators. In any case, artistic works are a bit different. However, a musical work or a literary work, those are things you could have multiple instances of.
- 4.17 The question that becomes controversial in philosophy is: Are these universals real? Properties like red or relations like friendship, are they real components of the world? Or are they just a matter of the way we think about or talk about the world? The realist says, "Yes, they are real, and they are independent of the mind." There is such a property as redness. There is such a relation as love or friendship. Those are things that have a real and independent existence.
- 4.18 The conceptualist says, "Yes, they're real, but they're mind-dependent." They're a matter of our concepts, organizing the world in a certain way. Those concepts really are constituents of the world, but on the other hand, they're dependent on a mind. So we classify certain human relationships as relations of love or relations of friendship. We categorize certain objects as red or blue. We think about certain things being between other things. That's a matter of our organizing the world. It's not a matter of things that are in the world independently of our mind.

- 4.19 The nominalist says, "No, they are not real at all." In fact, at one point, a famous nominalist simply said, they are flatus vocis. In other words, winds. Actually, it's rather vulgar in Latin. I will go into the literal translation. But really, they don't have any significance at all. They're just puffs of air. The idea in the nominalist's case is that everything is particular. They're individual red things, individual glasses of water. But some of them are similar to others, and so we group them together in language and apply the same word to them. But there's nothing corresponding to redness or triangularity or friendship. There's just a bunch of relations that we call friendship, or a bunch of objects we call red.
- 4.20 Let's go back to the realist idea here, which has its roots in Plato. He thinks of universals as real entities of the world, real and mind-independent entities. He is the paradigmatic realist in this sense in the entire Western tradition. He thinks there are what he calls Forms, these mind-independent universals. Redness, triangularity, or friendship or love—those things are fundamental constituents of the world, and they're independent of mind. They're not a matter of how we organize the world. They're not a matter of our concepts or our language. They are really in the world.
- 4.21 In fact, he thinks in a deeper sense than you and I are in the world. That's a bit shocking. Here is the analogy he uses, a famous allegory of the cave in *The Republic*. He says, imagine a bunch of people chained into—in a modern sense, this would be like a movie theater. There are no windows. It's all dark, but certain projections are up there on the screen, and you're chained in such a way that you can only look straight ahead, so all you can see are the projections on the screen. He imagines this in a cave with a fire behind and so on, but it's very much like a modern movie theater.
- 4.22 What would you think? Well, you would imagine that you were looking at reality. The only reality you would know is what's up there on that screen. You would think they were the real things, the real people, the real objects. But at some point, imagine that one of these prisoners locked in that theater manages to get loose a bit and starts looking around and realizing, "Wait a minute, there are other people here with me in this cave, and these things are being projected from behind me. Actually, those aren't the realities at all."
- 4.23 You can imagine the confusion. You've been thinking, you live in this world, this world projected on the screen, where those are the realities. And suddenly you start getting the sense, "Wait, this is fake." In his image, "These are the shadows of the things that are real back there." In the movie theater analogy, you think these are somehow representations of something being projected there, but I don't know what the reality is. So you get confused.
- 4.24 And imagine that you manage to get yourself freer and freer to the point where you can get rid of these chains holding you. And now you look around and think, "I want to get out of here. I want to find out what the real things are." So you see in the back an

ascent, some stairs that seem to lead out of this theater. So what do you do? You go over, and you start going up that staircase. But it's difficult.

- 4.25 For one thing, you've been chained, right? Your muscles are atrophied, so it's hard to climb those stairs. Secondly, as you get up further and further, it becomes more and more light. Your eyes aren't used to that. You've been looking at this screen. It's as if you're in a dark theater and suddenly you come out into the sunlight of a summer day. It's painful. So at first, it's hard on your eyes. But finally, you get up above the cave, and you open the door, and it is blinding. At first, you can't see anything. But then your eyes gradually adapt, and you start looking around and you see trees and you see buildings and you see plants and maybe other people. Finally, you get to the point where you can look up, and you actually see the sun.
- 4.26 That's the image. He's thinking that we are like the prisoners in that cave. We are trapped in a world of sense with what Plato calls "the lovers of sights and sounds." We think those are the real things. But at some point, we start realizing, "Wait a minute, there is something more fundamental. What I've been looking at is merely the shadows, the reflections of the true realities." So what I have to do is force myself to think about what these true realities are. I've got to turn away from the objects of sense and think about the real things.
- 4.27 What are the real things? That he tries to explain. Because Socrates is giving this analogy in *The Republic*, and he's talking to someone who says, "How could they see anything but the shadows if they were never allowed to move their heads"—inside this theater or this cave—"and of the objects which are being carried in like manner, they would only see the shadows?" Yes, all we see in the world of sense are these shadows.
- 4.28 But now, "If they were able to converse with one another, wouldn't they suppose they were naming the things"—that were up there on the screen, the mere shadows? Yes, that's all they'd know. But imagine there was an echo. They'd hear these things, too, and they'd think that was reality. Yes. And so "the truth would be literally nothing but the shadows of the images." And he thinks in our ordinary experience of the world, that's what it's like.
- 4.29 What we call the truth is nothing but the shadows of the images. So if we can get out of this cave, if we can get out of the theater, we start realizing there's something more. Now, how do we do it? Well, in my analogy here, it's a matter of leaving the theater. But he says that in reality, it's philosophy that can do this. Philosophy forces us to ask what there is, and in particular, what there really is.
- 4.30 We think about the world around us. It seems to be divided up into objects. We think they're the real things. But Plato says that they're just the shadows of the images. Instead, we have to see the true nature of the world, the true realities. They're not simply the things we see. There are deeper things. So the prisoner released is going to

finally be able to look, maybe initially at just shadows and reflections of the real things up above, but then at the actual objects, and finally at the sun.

- 4.31** That, he says, is the progression of the mind as it begins to think more and more deeply about the world. We start with the objects around us, looking at what we see and what we hear, and then we begin to progress to more abstract things. He thinks the best way to do this is mathematics. Because when you're doing geometry, for example, you're thinking about triangles. You're not thinking about this particular triangle or that one. You're thinking about triangles in general, and it's not just the thing on the page.
- 4.32** When I was teaching my daughter geometry—and by the way, she ended up as a math major, so it worked out okay in the end. But initially, she was given a problem. There was an angle drawn there on the page and labeled with things and so on. There was a triangle, and she was asked to show that it was a right triangle. She took out a protractor, measured, and said, "See, 90 degrees!" Well, that's not a geometric proof. That reveals something about that particular triangle drawn on the page. But of course, that's not what you do in geometry. You have to take that as merely a representation, a shadow of the thing you're really trying to make the proof about. I had to explain that.
- 4.33** That's why Plato actually thinks math, and in particular, geometry, is really helpful because you have, in a sense, something that is sensible, but you are led to think not about that particular triangle, but about any triangle that fits a certain specification, about the nature of triangularity itself. So it leads you to abstract Forms. But now he thinks once you've done that, the ones that are directly linked to sense, like triangle or circle or something like that, you can then begin to progress to more and more abstract Forms, things like the good or the just.
- 4.34** So, he says, think of the world as divided up into realms like this. On the left of this diagram is the visible world. It consists partly of shadows and reflections and perceptions of shadows and reflections. There are the real objects of perception: the actual trees and buildings and animals, plants, human beings that we see. That is the realm, he says, of opinion.
- 4.35** But then we can move to this intellectual world. That's what you do when you stop thinking about that particular triangle on the page and start thinking about triangularity as such. You begin to move on to these Forms, at first, the Forms that correspond to shapes and number and other things like that in mathematics, and then you move on to the more abstract ones. That's really the realm of reason.
- 4.36** He says that gradually, as you learn, as you progress through school, you start out with the basic things, the things around you, the objects of sense, but then you move more and more in the direction of abstraction until you're thinking about things that are actually highly abstract and aren't found directly in the world at all. The visible world, he says, is a reflection of the intellectual world. It's the intellectual world that consists of the real realities.

- 4.37 So Socrates says, "This entire allegory,"—of the cave, that is—"you may now append to the previous argument: the prison house is the world of sight, the light of the fire is the sun"—in my version, it's the theater and the projector—"you won't misapprehend me if you apprehend the journey upwards to be the ascent of the soul into the intellectual world, according to my poor belief, which at your desire I've expressed, whether rightly or wrongly God knows."
- 4.38 So Socrates, from one point of view, is humble here. He's saying, I don't know if I'm right. Maybe only God knows that. But here is the way I see it. The things around us aren't the ultimate realities. They're the shadows of the ultimate realities. So here is a way of thinking about Plato's philosophy of mind. These diagrams I learned from my teacher, Wilfrid Sellars. This is the way he understood Plato, and I think it's very revealing.
- 4.39 I have a thought. I'm looking at the thing on the page, as my daughter did, saying, "Okay, that's a triangle." There's a particular object, in this case, drawn on the page that I'm thinking about, but I also recognize it as a triangle. I recognize this as an instance of triangularity. My mind is focused both on that thing I'm perceiving, the actual triangle on the page, but also on triangularity, the form. I'm thinking about the universal at the same time I'm thinking about the particular when I classify the object as a triangle and say, "That's a triangle."
- 4.40 Now, here I think it's important to recognize that for Plato, I am seeing it as a triangle by seeing it as an instance of that more general form. I'm recognizing this is a particular case of something that actually has multiple instances. This is a triangle, meaning this is an instance of triangularity, or in his language, it participates in triangularity.
- 4.41 Now, why should we think these Forms exist at all? Why should we think they're the ultimate realities? Plato does give us some arguments for this, and I'm not sure they all work, but I think it's valuable to look at them and understand why he thinks this. Because at first glance, you might think, "What a weird view to think that you and I aren't the ultimate realities. We're just shadows of humanity. That's odd." But why would you think that? Well, he gives us, I think, five arguments.
- 4.42 Let's look at the first: general thoughts. I can think about triangles as such. I can think about horses. I can think about saguaro cacti. I can think about all sorts of things, and in doing that and thinking about these general thoughts, there must be something that the particular instances have in common that I'm really thinking about.
- 4.43 Let's say I think about horses. I'm thinking about horses as such, not just this particular horse or that particular horse. I'm thinking about horses and what horses are like. So there must be something I'm thinking about. That is the thing that all those particular horses have in common: their horsiness, I guess. That's something that is the character of being a horse that I'm reflecting on when I think about horses in general.

- 4.44 It seems possible to have those thoughts. I can think about triangles in general, circles in general, but then more abstract things like horses. Here I mean the kind, horses, the things that horses have in common. I can think about justice. I can think about all sorts of things that involve abstractions that aren't found directly in things themselves but are exemplified in the things themselves. A particular horse is an example of this. But insofar as I'm thinking about horses in general, having a general thought about horses, it seems as if I'm focusing on something that isn't just this or that particular horse.
- 4.45 Let's take the example of trees. I look at trees in various parts of the country, and in the past week, I've been in North Carolina and Texas and Arizona. Very different instances of trees in those three places, and yet I recognize them all as trees. I can talk about trees and what trees are like. It seems as if there must be something like being a tree that I'm able to reflect on. All these individual trees are instances of being a tree.
- 4.46 We're thinking in geometry, but in all of those cases, not of the particular trees or the particular horses or the particular triangles. We're thinking not of those, but of the ideals they resemble. That's Plato's point. We're thinking about triangularity or circularity or being a tree or being a horse as such. It seems possible to do that. In fact, it seems as if when I think about a particular horse or a particular triangle or a particular tree, I'm actually using that knowledge of what it is to be a tree or a triangle or a horse, and that's being activated, as it were, when I recognize that thing as a triangle or a tree or a horse.
- 4.47 He says that it looks as if those particulars are really something like reflections of the general thing: being a horse, being a triangle, and so on. Those are things that can only be seen by the eye of the mind. And that idea, that there's something like an eye of the mind that is capable of thinking about triangularity as such, or being a tree, or being a horse as such, is fundamental to the way Plato is thinking about this. I see individual trees; I don't see the abstraction of being a tree. Nevertheless, I got to be able to think about it. I must be able to perceive it with something like the eye of the mind.
- 4.48 Secondly, regularities. I can recognize regularities. Last night, there was lots of lightning that could be seen in the sky, occasionally, thunder along with it, and I might recognize that lightning seems to be followed by thunder. I'm not just thinking about that particular flash of lightning and that particular crash of thunder. I'm talking about a general pattern. But that means I'm linking being lightning to being thunder in a way that, to be fully general and to be a regularity, must involve thinking about the abstractions, not just the particular cases.
- 4.49 Third, the same thing is true in the case of laws. I have all sorts of things I call laws in science, and it looks as if in doing that, I'm not just talking about particular instances of mass or acceleration or motion or force or whatever it happens to be. I'm thinking about those as abstractions. I'm thinking about acceleration in general or velocity in general. Those things involve thinking not about the particular cases, but the things that have multiple instances. I can have a law, like force is mass times acceleration, and

that's something that's about force as such, mass as such, acceleration as such. And then I have lots of instances of it when I look at things accelerated by the application of a force.

4.50 Fourth, we can think about communication or meaning. I'm able to use the word triangle, and you are too, and somehow we communicate with each other. If there's not something that anchors both of our ideas of triangularity, how is that even possible? I would have an idea, maybe of triangularity in my head, you'd have one in your head. How is it possible to actually have any confidence that the idea in your head is anything like the idea in my head?

4.51 I've got to be able to actually latch on to something that is going to represent something like the content of the word or the content of the thought. Those contents can't be just in your mind or my mind. Then it looks like we have different contents for every person. There must be something those contents actually link up to that gives our thoughts content outside of any individual mind.

4.52 One way of looking at it is to say that you and I communicate. I have an idea in my head. I manage to have confidence that that idea is being conveyed into your head. But why should I have that confidence? Or it doesn't even involve interpersonal things. What about me earlier and me later? I think about this yesterday, then I talk about it today. Why should I have any confidence that what I'm talking about today is what I was thinking about yesterday? Maybe it turns out I have totally different ideas yesterday and today.

4.53 The only reason I have for being confident that I'm thinking the same thought is that there's something outside of my head at a particular time that can be a content that I can somehow attach to on both occasions. Of course, it's not just at different times; it might be in different circumstances. Suppose instead of having a white background here, I had some other background. Would the entire content of what I'm saying be different? Well, of course not. But that means it isn't tied to a particular context, a particular surrounding, or anything like that. It's got to be attached to something independent of the particular circumstances.

4.54 Finally, I want to say that some thoughts are accurate, that sometimes I'm describing the world correctly, that I'm saying something true, for example, that my thought is veridical, meaning it matches the world. I want to think sometimes I'm stating the truth objectively. But how is that possible? How can we distinguish truth from falsehood, or correctness from incorrectness, or accuracy from inaccuracy?

4.55 There must be something that relates the content of what I say. Like, "That's a triangle"— that has a content, and somehow that content has to relate to the individual thing I'm describing. He refers to that relation as participation. We might call it simply being an instance of triangularity. But whatever term we use, we've got to have some relationship between the universal and the particular thing such that the

particular really is an instance of that universal. Then I can say, good, my thought is true when I'm saying "this is a triangle," for example, and it really does exemplify triangularity. It gives me a way of accounting for the difference between truth and falsehood, accuracy and inaccuracy.

- 4.56 But now we face a serious problem. We don't perceive the Forms. I mean, I see individual triangles, I don't perceive triangularity. I see maybe instances of just and unjust behavior, but I don't see justice and injustice as such. So how is it possible to know anything about them? In the physics lab, I might accelerate a variety of objects, so I see particular instances of acceleration. Nevertheless, I draw conclusions about acceleration as such. But I don't see acceleration as such. I see particular instances. So how can I know anything about these universals?
- 4.57 Plato gives us some answers that aren't entirely satisfactory. In the Meno, he says, "I recollect them. Before I was born, my mind was united with the Forms. And then, being born, I was washed with something that caused me to forget them. And so I have to gradually remember them." Well, that's a pretty metaphorical account. I'm not saying there isn't some core there that we can resurrect, but by itself, that seems like a fable, not an account.
- 4.58 In The Republic, he says, "It's the Form of the Good." Just as the sun illumines the objects outside of the theater, so the Form of the Good illumines my mind and enables me to perceive the other Forms. But that, too, isn't a great account. After all, if the other Forms don't seem to have this power, why does the Form of the Good have that power? It looks as if that's an unsatisfying answer. Indeed, within a generation, most people in Plato's Academy, the school he founded, became skeptics. They decided, "Phooey, I don't see how we can know these Forms," and they gave up on the whole idea. It wasn't until much later that the idea got resurrected.
- 4.59 Because in Plato, the picture is something like this. I perceive the object, and that's a particular object, so I can talk about that in an ordinary way about causal relationships and my faculties of perception. But then what is this relation to the Form? Well, I somehow recollect it, maybe. The good serves as something like the sun to light this whole thing up and make it possible. That seems weird. There are three parts to that.
- 4.60 First of all, there is this metaphysical aspect having to do with the relation between the Form and the object and the role of the sun here or the good. That seems odd. Then, there is the semantic question of my idea or my sentence, my thought, having a relation to this abstract Form. So there's something about content or meaning there. Then, I've got to have something I say about the theory of knowledge. How is it that I recollect or know these Forms? There are a lot of parts here that are remaining to be explained.
- 4.61 There are different strategies. The realist says, "I take for granted that there really are these things that serve as our contents and that objects really do exemplify them. So I

now have to give you a theory of knowledge. I have to explain how we can know the Forms." That's one way of trying to solve this problem. A second way that the conceptualist uses is say, "Let's stick those Forms inside your mind, and then they're just concepts. So now it's not complicated to say how you know them. They're right there in your mind." Then, the nominalist says, "I'm going to erase them altogether. All I need now is to explain a theory of meaning in such a way that I don't need to have these contents outside of anybody's head."

- 4.62 That is a set of problems that we're going to come back to. But on the other hand, it was enough to make people give up on Platonism for hundreds of years. Really, it wasn't until Jewish and Christian thinkers came along and said, "The Form of the Good—it does all this? I don't see how that's possible, but God could do it." If you replace the Form of the Good with God, then, aha, problem solved. God can do anything. That's actually a pretty stable solution, and it lasts for about a thousand years, as we'll see. But that's a story for a little bit in the future.
- 4.63 Let's turn to that other tradition I was talking about in Aristotle. Aristotle starts out with a purely grammatical account. He says, I want to account for what there is, but let's look at language. Let's see what language actually commits us to and what we actually think about and talk about. Well, he says, "Expressions that aren't composite,"—so aren't complex, simple expressions, signify the following things. They "signify substance, quantity, quality, relation, place, time, position, state, action, or affection."
- 4.64 Here's an example. Substance: things like man or horse or Socrates. Quantity: like 6 feet tall or 235 square miles. Quality: like white, tall, angry, wise, red, triangular. Relations: like double or greater than or loves or is a friend of. Then, there are places: at the market or in Austin. Times: today, at noon, for a week. Position: like lying, sitting, standing, talking. States: like being armed or puzzled or impressed. Actions: like hit, smile, do, walk, thank. Then affection, passive forms of those: like to be hit or to be thanked.
- 4.65 Anyway, you can see that they look very grammatical. We've got nouns, we've got adjectives, we've got prepositional phrases of various kinds. Then we've got gerunds and gerundives and verbs in active and passive forms. At first glance, it seems likethis is just grammar, really. And in one sense, that's where he's starting. He's saying, you want to know what's in the world? We talk about the world all the time. Let's see how we talk about it. What are we talking about? Let's turn to language.
- 4.66 That's not the only way of thinking about categories. There is a tradition in India, the Vaisheshika tradition, that says there are only three basic categories, really. We can simplify that picture. There are substances like a pot or a cloth or Socrates. There are qualities, and there are motions, actions like moving, eating, throwing. Those are things that Aristotle would recognize.

- 4.67 But then, the Indian thinkers in the Vaisheshika tradition say that that's really all we need. Those are the existent things. Then, relations and places and times, we can put them into one of those three categories. Maybe we can simplify Aristotle's scheme. As that tradition in India progresses, people begin to think, wait, what about other things?
- 4.68 I want to mention this just to indicate Aristotle is making choices, and they're not necessarily the obvious choices. One thing is something Plato would insist on: What about universality? What about, in other words, triangularity or friendship as such? Plato would add those as fundamental. In fact, they're thinking they're more fundamental than the others. But what about things like "the pots being blue"? What the thinkers in this tradition call the inherence. That's something like Plato's relation of participation. So maybe we need that, and Plato would agree, yeah, we need that. But then what about individualizers?
- 4.69 Let's say you go to visit the Dixie Cup factory. Not sure anybody's ever done that. But if you did that, you'd see all these Dixie Cups being produced. They all look alike. Nevertheless, they're all different. They all exemplify Dixie Cupness. But there's this one, this one, this one. What makes them different? Well, there must be something that makes them different. So the Vaisheshika tradition evolves to the point where people say, "I need an individualizer, something that makes this one different from that one, even though their shapes are exactly the same, the matter in them is exactly the same and so on."
- 4.70 And then, what about absences, like the elephant right here? There's no elephant right here. But if I say, "There is no elephant here." What makes that true? You might think I need absences or lacks. And by the way, there's a very funny paper by David and Stephanie Lewis called Holes, about whether holes are real constituents of the world. It's entertaining, but it's addressing this issue. Do we have to talk not only about what's here, but what's missing? And maybe to give a full account of reality we do.
- 4.71 In any case, I want to mention those to indicate that Aristotle's way isn't the only way of setting it up like this. What are these categories, categories of? You might think, "It's a matter of grammar. He's just listing the parts of speech." Or you might think, "I don't know, there are these different things that we talk about, so maybe there are different constituents of reality."
- 4.72 Here's how he thinks of it. He says, "There's a science that investigates being as being and the attributes that belong to this in virtue of its own nature." In other words, he's thinking of metaphysics, this part of philosophy that answers the question, what is there, as being the science of being, qua being. That's an odd phrase, but the idea is that when we think about what there is, we're thinking about what is being and what is being as such. In other words, what is it to be something? He thinks that's really the fundamental question.

- 4.73 Because I could say, "What is there?" and start listing a bunch of things. I could think, "What are the basic things?" and then start listing things like substances, qualities, quantities, relations. But I could also say, "What is it to be?" You're asking me what there is. I want to know more about "what this is" business is involving. What is it to be something? And he thinks that's the most fundamental question in metaphysics.
- 4.74 The moment he raises that, he says that here's why it's complicated. There are many different ways in which things are said to be, but all of them are related to one central point. So what are the categories? There are ways in which a thing can be said to be. You can be a horse, you can be brown, you can be in Austin, you can be between this thing and that thing, you can be lying down, you can be running, and so on. All of those are ways in which something can be something.
- 4.75 He says they're all related to one central sense. From one point of view, the categories are just the ways you can be something, the ways in which you can be, but they all relate to one thing, namely, substance. Because what we have are quantities of substance, relations between substances, qualities of substance, places where a substance can be, times at which a substance can be, things a substance can do or have done to it, and so on. They all relate to substance in the end. So all the other categories depend on substance. Everything is really a quantity-quality relation, et cetera, of a substance or of substances.
- 4.76 That means, yes, there are many senses in which a thing can be said to be, but in the end, there is one thing that is really fundamental. He calls it—well, he doesn't call it; scholars call it a focal meaning of being. The central meaning of being is substance. So the best answer to what there is is that there is substance. Or maybe we should say there are substances.
- 4.77 Now, what is a substance? He says it's of a kind, so it has a species, and that species is a specific kind that falls under a certain genus. So I, for example, am a substance. I am of a certain kind. I am a human being, and that falls under a more general kind: I am an animal, and so on and so forth. So all substances are of a kind, but moreover, I'm a particular instance of that kind.
- 4.78 So one way Aristotle puts it is, "I am a this such," and that's to say, I am a particular instance of a kind. I am this particular instance of humanity. And that's true of any substance. That particular horse is a particular horse of a kind. It's a horse, so it's this horse or that triangle. Notice here: there is a difference from Plato because he's saying that the fundamental things aren't things like triangularity or being a horse or being a human being or humanity. The fundamental things are substances: that horse, this human being, and so on. Now, those are the primary substances.
- 4.79 There are secondary substances, kinds, because I can also talk about horses, human beings, triangles in general. That's true. But I don't need any abstraction like triangularity or humanity to be able to do that because I can focus on kinds of things. If

I say, "Cats meow," I'm not referring necessarily to each individual cat. There might be cats that don't meow, but I'm talking about the kind and predicating something of the kind. In this secondary way, we also have to recognize these substances as being kinds of things.

- 4.80** But the primary substances are the particular instances of those kinds, the individual cats. Then I can generalize about the kind cat. But that's not an abstract form as in Plato, because it exists only in the individual cats. We see this in what linguists call bear plurals, things like cat's meow or tigers are striped, philosophy majors are smart, whatever—these are things that talk about a kind, and there can be exceptions. Not every cat has to meow, not every tiger has to be striped, not every philosophy major is smart.
- 4.81** Now, let's go back to that core idea: a substance is a this such. It's this particular thing of a certain kind. How do we tell that something is a substance? First of all, there are no degrees of it. Think about hot and cold. Those are qualities, and there are degrees of that: something could be hotter or colder. But there aren't degrees of substance. If you're a horse, there's no such thing as being more of a horse or less of a horse. You're just a horse, period. Similarly, you're a triangle. You're a triangle or you're not. There's no, well, it's a little bit more of a triangle. No.
- 4.82** Secondly, there's no contrary. We can have contraries like hot and cold or black and white, but we don't have contraries like being human versus what exactly? I mean, we can make one up: nonhuman. But the fact is, there's no natural contrary. There's no natural opposite to being a human or being a horse or being a tree.
- 4.83** Then, substances can admit contrary qualities. I can be asleep at one time and awake at another time. I can be speaking at one time and silent at another time. The same thing is true of that individual horse or that tree. The tree might have leaves on it now, but later in winter might lose its leaves. Contrary qualities can be had by the same substance. That's not going to be true of other kinds of things, like qualities themselves. It's not as if being hot, let's say, can sometimes be cold. No, it's being hot.
- 4.84** I've said that ontology is the science of what there is. It is really the central part, you might say, of metaphysics. It's the examination of that question, what there is. Aristotle says that now we know how to answer that question. In the primary sense, what is there? Substance. The basic question then, if you ask what is being, what is it to be? In that primary sense, it's just to ask: What is substance? We've already said that in a sense. We've said it's to be a particular instance of a kind, to be that particular human being or that particular triangle or that particular horse.
- 4.85** But now, in the most difficult book of the Metaphysics, Book Zeta, he starts examining this question more carefully, and I tread on it now nervously because it's difficult and because it represents the only incomplete I ever took in graduate school. I thought I was going to come up with a grand explanation of what Aristotle had in mind in

Metaphysics Zeta. After working on it all summer, I realized I got nothing, and so I changed my topic entirely. But I now think I understand it better.

- 4.86** What he's doing there is he says, I want to understand what it is to be a this such. A particular human being, that's a primary substance. But let's dig a little deeper. What is that? Because after all, Plato is going to insist that I'm merely a shadow. I'm merely a shadow of humanity. I'm a reflection of this more general thing, this abstract concept or this abstract Form— I shouldn't say concept because it's really supposed to be independent of mind in Plato.
- 4.87** He's thinking, what could a substance then really be? He's concerned to not say that it's a Form. Here, he says that there are four things we could describe as substance. There is the essence and the universal. In other words, we could say, as Plato does, that humanity is the ultimate substance; I'm just a particular instance participating in it. Or we could say it's the genus. We could say the substratum. We could say the individual thing, just me, individual human beings, for example. We'll get to what he means by the substratum.
- 4.88** Let's start with this idea that substances are individual things. I think that's what Aristotle thinks is closest to our idea of substance. It's particular people, particular pens, particular horses and trees. Here are some of the criteria he mentions. These aren't things that are predicable of anything else. I can talk about red, and many things are red, but I can't talk about many things being Socrates or many things being Sarajevo. These are particular things.
- 4.89** Being a particular, not predicable of anything else, well, individual things are like that, so good. Substances underlie everything else. It does seem as if everything in the world is a particular this or that, so that seems good. A substance is supposed to be an individual thing. Well, individual things are individual, so that's good. They shouldn't have contraries, and individual things have no contraries. There's no opposite to being Dan Bonevac. They don't have degrees. There's no more or less of being me. They admit contrary qualities. Yes, I can be speaking, I can be silenced.
- 4.90** But now, am I really primary? Here, Aristotle starts to worry because he thinks that we can distinguish matter from form. That's a pretty fundamental divide in Aristotle. He thinks everything has matter. I am flesh and blood, as Aquinas later describes it, but I'm also that in a particular form. So I can distinguish the matter, the things that make me up from the particular form they take in me. That suggests that maybe substance isn't really primary. Maybe I have to distinguish it into matter and form. That worries him. That's a strike against thinking of individual things as substances.
- 4.91** What about compounds in general? For example, matter and shape. Let's get away from an individual human being, partly because I don't want to imagine the same matter in a different form, like toss me in a blender and see what happens. Let's get away from that thought and think about a statue instead.

- 4.92 I've got a particular statue. Somebody makes up a statue of Hercules, and it looks like it's got a matter in it, let's say we've made it of bronze. And it's also got a particular shape, so I can distinguish the matter of the statue from the form of the statue. They are separable. I could melt it down and make that bronze into something else, or I could make the same form out of something else. I could maybe make a cast of it and then do it in clay or something else. So I can distinguish the matter from the shape of that compound, that statue.
- 4.93 But that makes me think, then, that it's not really primary, is it? I don't want to say the statue is really a fundamental thing. It looks like there's the bronze of which it's made, then it's in a particular shape. But it seems like if anything's fundamental there, it's the bronze. That could lead me to think, "What if substances just matter?" It's the bronze of the statue, or it's the flesh and blood of the human being, or it's the, I don't know, the various parts out of which the piano is made. Take an individual object and start thinking it's the matter that is involved in it.
- 4.94 Well, he says, here's the worry. It's obscure what matter really is. If matter isn't substance, it's hard to say what else is. But if we strip everything off, evidently nothing but matter remains. Here's what worries him. We start taking away qualities. What is it that is in this shape? Well, the bronze. We could stop there and just say it's the bronze.
- 4.95 Or we could push further in science and say, ultimately, maybe it's microparticles, or it's a string, or it's an electromagnetic field. Or whatever our favorite theory of physics is, we say, ultimately, it's really that. Or we could do what John Locke does and keep saying, what is it that is the bronze? What is it that is an electron? What is it that is a particular field? In the end, we're going to end up saying, "I have no idea what it is," and we'll talk about that a bit later.
- 4.96 He says, here's part of the problem. If it's this matter that's substance, that seems bizarre because, first of all, we want substances to be separable. I want to be able to talk about this substance and that substance. If we end up with just matter, it looks like it doesn't have a natural separation in that way.
- 4.97 We just talked about the matter comprising the universe, but it's hard to divide it. Maybe there are particles, and we could think what particle physics tells us, that in the end, those things are divided. But what if it's something like a field or a string? Then we have something that isn't separable at all. He says that separability, thisness, we attach that to our idea of substance, and matter isn't going to give us that. So it seems like matter can't really be substance.
- 4.98 Well, then what about the shape or the form or the universal? What about the shape of the statue? Maybe that's fundamental, but that doesn't really seem fundamental either. I mean, it's a universal that might make Plato happy. But on the other hand, that can't be the name of a substance. The substance is individual. And so the name of the substance should indicate what's unique about it. But to just say it's something bronze

doesn't indicate anything unique about it. The universal is what things have in common. All of those individual horses are instances of being a horse, maybe, but you don't want to say being a horse is the substance. That doesn't seem right.

- 4.99** No universal attribute can be a substance. Here really is part of his argument against Plato, because we think of substances as the things that I can say, "this substance or that substance," that I refer to in my speech and that I think about. It really isn't primarily these abstract universals. That just gives us the such part, not the this. Matter would give us maybe the this, maybe not even if it's not separable, but it's not going to give us the such. So they can't be right. So universals are going to flunk several of these tests. They are predicable over a variety of things. They're not individual, they're not primary, they don't admit contrary qualities. So it looks like that's a problem.
- 4.100** What about the substratum? What even is the substratum? It's maybe just what everything else could be predicated of. It's not predicated of anything else. That seems to work in some ways, but on the other hand, that looks like in the end, if you really think about what's that root, it's going to end up being either matter or form or some compound. So it just throws us back into the circle at some other part. Consequently, it looks like at best that's going to be something that doesn't give us universality.
- 4.101** What about a kind? Those are supposed to be secondary substances, he says. They are predicable of other things. There can be many human beings or many tigers, many trees, so kinds can't be the fundamental thing. They're not individual.
- 4.102** Here is now, I think, the moral of that book, Zeta. He says, in the end, nothing really satisfies all the criteria for being a substance. When we think intuitively about what a substance is, what would be fundamental in the world, there are a number of criteria we have, a number of things we associate with that. The thing that comes closest is the individual object of a certain kind: you, me, a particular horse, a particular tree. Those are the things that come closest to our idea of substance.
- 4.103** But I think in the end, what he's saying there is nothing exactly satisfies it. Maybe our intuitive idea of a substance is actually not entirely coherent. That could be. It may be that we start with language and start with the way we think. We say, "What's really fundamental to our thinking? What's primary in our thinking and talking about things?" It looks like, well, individual objects.
- 4.104** But then, when we examine carefully what we think about that, we realize that the idea is actually a little bit confused. We've got to clean it up a bit. When we clean it up, we realize the closest thing we have to a substance is, in a sense, a compound. It does consist of matter and form. It is "a this" and "a such." That makes it sound compound and therefore derivative and not fundamental. But he says that actually, that's the closest we can come to reflecting this idea of what's basic in the world. The moment we say that it's just the such part or it's just the this part, that leads us into big trouble.

- 4.105** I now think he's basically saying, "I wish I could have it all. I wish substance could be all of these things." It turns out there's nothing that's really like all of those things, but the closest thing we have, and the thing we most naturally talk about, are the particular things around us. So, where Plato starts and says, in the end, reflections or shadows, Aristotle says that maybe it doesn't satisfy everything we would like as a foundational object, that is what the world really consists in, but it's the closest thing we have. That is really what we have to think of the world as consisting of.
- 4.106** Now, he does admit that in a certain sense, you could use substance in two ways then. You could talk about each individual thing: the this, such, that horse, that tree. Or you could mean the ultimate substratum, the thing not predicated of anything else, just the stuff out of which everything is made. They both might be legitimate uses of the word substance. Neither one gives you all the criteria, but nevertheless, they come as close as anything else. They come closer, really, than all the competitors.
- 4.107** We think about the statue and we think, there's that particular statue, and then there's the stuff out of which it's made. You could call either one of them substance. But I think he prefers to think of substance in the primary sense as the statue, the this such, that particular thing.
- 4.108** Now, one more important distinction in Aristotle. We can distinguish essential from accidental properties. Things are said to be in an accidental sense or by their own nature. So you have certain properties, essentially. Without them, you wouldn't be you. Other things are accidental. You could change them and you'd still be you. So the essence of a thing is what it is said to be, *propter se*—in the Greek, it's *kath' auto*, "by virtue of itself." There are things you have inherently by virtue of being you. So what are things like that?
- 4.109** Consider these candles. They can be solid or they can melt under heat, but it's still the same candle. Being liquid or being solid is not an essential property of the candle. It could be either one. They are contingent. The object might or might not have them. I could be awake, I could be asleep. I could be lying down, I could be standing up. Those are accidental properties of me. I can change those properties; I'm still me.
- 4.110** On the other hand, essential properties, they're different. Without an essential property, the thing would not be what it is. That candle wouldn't be that candle. Maybe it wouldn't be a candle at all if it didn't have those properties. They're necessary to being the thing. They have them by virtue of what they are. So maybe what is essential to the candle is being made of wax. What's essential to me as a human being, maybe it's to have a certain DNA, it's to have a certain biological property.
- 4.111** Being musical is an example he uses. Is being musical something that is essential to someone? Well, no. You could stop being musical or start being musical—you're still you. You could learn to play the piano or play the drums. It's something that doesn't change who you are. It's only things by your nature that you are essentially.

- 4.112 One way of thinking about this is to say, suppose we could define something, then that definition would give you the essence. It's the formula of the essence. Now, the essence then is precisely what something is, and that means we have essences only of things we could define.
- 4.113 So he says, really, you can define kinds. I can't define individual people. I could define human being, maybe if I knew enough biology, but I can't define Dan Bonevac. I can't define Socrates in the same way because the such part I could give a definition of, but the this part can't really be defined.
- 4.114 The essential property—what is it? It's what it is to be the thing, what it is by virtue of itself, what it is by its very nature, what would be expressed by a definition of it. Those are all ways of thinking about what the essential properties of a thing are. Those are things that are necessary for being a thing of that kind. Particulars? He thinks about whether there is an essence of a particular thing. It's complicated, but in the end, not really, because I can't define the this part.
- 4.115 Now, one last thought. There are natural kinds, and those natural kinds push us in a certain direction. What's the essence of water? Well, it's what it is to be water, what's necessary for being water. In a modern sense, we say that's being H₂O. But of course, that's something we learned only around 1750. Before that, we were still talking about water, what was essential to it.
- 4.116 That's going to be something that motivates later philosophers to think, actually, there are two ways of talking about essence. There's the nominal essence, the set of properties we ordinarily associate with the kind, and then there's the real essence, the scientific account of what that kind is. It's going to apply only to these natural kinds like water or gold. It won't apply to things like philosopher or writing implement or something like that. Those are artificial kinds. But a natural kind, we're going to see that the concept of the essence starts dividing in two. But that's for a later part of the story. Thank you. Questions?
- 4.117 Hopefully, I can express this. Based on what we were just talking about, it seems like a lot of the difficulty in defining everything does come down to a lot of grammar and a lot of linguistic subtleties, especially between the implicit and the explicit. I'm wondering, are you able to comment on, linguistically, some of the different philosophy, the evolution of philosophy between, say, Aristotle and Plato with more of a Greek, the original Greek, and then, say, Confucius with Chinese, and I forget the one from India, just how the linguistics plays into the evolution of these philosophical ideas?
- 4.118 That's a great question. Yes, conceptual schemes are expressed in language, and so differences between languages are really going to lead people to have different ideas about what's fundamental in this way. In some sense, every language has something like a noun, or at least those languages have something like a noun. So the idea of

substance is something that persists across all of those different cultures and all those philosophical traditions.

- 4.119** But you're right to say that language differences matter. For example, in India, part of the reason things go in a slightly different direction is that Sanskrit is even more highly inflected and more complex a language than Greek. Greek is much more complicated than English. In English, we're happy to say, yeah, there are things. Everything exists. Just focus on what nouns refer to, and you're good, really.
- 4.120** In Greek, you've got all sorts of grammatical cases and verb conjugations and so on that are much more complex, even than in Latin. Those of us who started learning Latin and then learn Greek, it's like, "Oh, Greek is miserable." The people who start out with Greek, then turn to Latin and say, "Oh, all this stuff is missing."
- 4.121** Greek is complicated, but Sanskrit is even more complex. There's a lot of subtlety that some of the Indian thinkers conceive of that is missing from Greek philosophy, like this idea of absences. It's something that's natural to express in Sanskrit, not so much in Greek or English. We don't tend to think about holes or the absence of elephants as things we have to worry about. But in Sanskrit, that's a pretty natural thing to think.
- 4.122** Now, in Chinese, here, classical Chinese has so few case markings or connectives that it's highly ambiguous. For example, there is a verse in The Analects that simply says—it's usually translated as something like, "If Confucius's mat was not straight, he would not sit on it," or "If the seat isn't right for you, don't sit in it." But Chinese is literally just, "Seat no right, no sit." That's it. We have to figure out, how do we express that? What does that mean?
- 4.123** In particular, in classical Chinese, there is no word for "if." There is no "and." There's a big difference between "If that's a cat, it might scratch you," and "That's a cat, and it might scratch you." It's just "cat might scratch." That means that what we think of as logical structure—something that is investigated a lot in Indian philosophy and in Greek philosophy—is missing from Chinese philosophy. There just isn't the language to express those distinctions.
- 4.124** So I think you're right. If we started with a language that actually was agglomerative or in some way didn't have something like a noun, suppose that it basically took adjectives or verbs as its foundational thing, and there really weren't any nouns.
- 4.125** Jorge Luis Borges thinks about a language like this in one of his stories, *Tlön, Uqbar, Orbis Tertius*, that we'll refer to later. Then we'd say, "Oh, then it's going to look like maybe events or qualities are fundamental and not substances." So I agree with you. Language is intimately tied up with these questions.

Lecture 5: On Skepticism

At a glance — On skepticism.

- 5.1 In this lecture, I'm going to talk about skepticism. I'm going to try to convince you you know nothing at all. In fact, not only that you know nothing, it's not even reasonable to have any beliefs. So I intend to reduce you to intellectual rubble—or at least I will give you the arguments that people have used to try to reduce people to intellectual rubble.
- 5.2 I mentioned last time that within a generation, Plato's students in the Academy had given up on his idea because they saw no way to explain how it was possible for us to know the Forms. So they became skeptics. And skepticism remained throughout the entire Hellenistic period— and really up until about the year 500, say—a major influence, one of the three main schools of Western philosophy.
- 5.3 Then, throughout the medieval period, it went into the background. Many of the texts were lost, but they were rediscovered during the Renaissance. So skepticism became very powerful again back in the, say, 15th and 16th centuries. Throughout the early modern period, philosophers are constantly battling the skeptics, trying to show how it's possible for us to have some knowledge.
- 5.4 Throughout the whole history of philosophy, whether you're talking about Western philosophy or Indian philosophy, Chinese philosophy, there have been skeptics. They've always been a small minority, but on the other hand, they bother everyone else rather intensely because they realize, "If I'm to convince you that I know anything and that you have any reason to believe anything, I have to in some way refute the skeptics." It's a challenge that most people see merely as a challenge. They're not convinced, but they also have a hard time explaining what's wrong with this view.
- 5.5 Modern skeptics usually have the view that knowledge is impossible. In fact, they define skepticism in many ways as the view that knowledge is impossible. But ancient skepticism tended to be more sweeping. It's not just that you know nothing. There is no reason to believe anything. Many of the ancient skeptics say, "Take any proposition, there is every bit as much reason to believe it as to disbelieve it." You're always in this balance of reasons. There's always evidence on one side, evidence against. There is ultimately no reason to believe anything.
- 5.6 So the skeptic holds, if you take that modern view about knowledge, you think that beliefs are unjustified or unreliable, depending on how you view knowledge, whether it requires justification, as Plato, for example, tended to think, or whether it requires reliability, as people in the Indian tradition and some more modern philosophers have thought. But in either case, knowledge is impossible.
- 5.7 Now, if you have skepticism about a particular area, that's not so shocking. People argue considerably in physics and in popular culture about whether there's life on other

planets, somewhere else in the universe. Well, you might be a skeptic about that. You might say, "I don't think there's any reason to believe that there is. I don't see any reason to believe that there isn't. It's just an open question. So I suspend judgment." And that's not a shocking thing. Nobody thinks, "Oh, my, this is Earth-shattering." You could just say, "Yeah, I don't think that." And there are people who are skeptics like that about, let's say, what is really fundamental in the universe, or about the existence of God, or all sorts of questions. You might be a skeptic about this or that.

- 5.8** But what's interesting from a philosophical point of view is mostly an extreme form—a global skepticism. What if all of our beliefs are unjustified or unreliable? What if there's never any reason to believe anything? What if all knowledge about anything at all is impossible? Socrates is reported to have said, "All I know is that I know nothing." If you reflect on that a minute, you can think, "That's a very strange thing to have said"—if he said it. Plato doesn't report him as saying that. Diogenes Laërtius does, and Diogenes is not entirely reliable himself. But anyway, he says, Socrates said, "All I know is that I know nothing."
- 5.9** Now, this is taken to be characteristic of a view known as Academic skepticism, the skepticism that emerges in Plato's Academy after Plato's death. You might think it's self-refuting. "I know only that I know nothing." Well, if you know nothing, how do you know that you know nothing? It seems like a self-contradictory. Now, maybe there's a way of patching it up. Suppose Socrates meant, "I know only this." What, Socrates? "Well, what I just said, this is all I know, period."
- 5.10** Now, that's a bizarre thing to think. I mean, maybe it's self-consistent, but on the other hand, how would you know that? You couldn't deduce it from something else that you knew, because then it wouldn't be true that you knew only this. It couldn't follow from anything because then you'd presumably have to know that it followed, and you don't know anything else. There's something that would be very strange about that view, even if it could be made consistent.
- 5.11** There's a deeper problem that Gisela Striker has talked about. If I say, "I know nothing or I know only this," so what? I can say, "Well, okay, you're not very smart, are you?" The skeptic usually doesn't just say knowledge is impossible or there's no reason to believe anything; they then draw a certain conclusion, they make a recommendation. For example, "It's impossible to know anything, so suspend judgment." Or, "It's impossible to have knowledge, so make room for faith." Or, "You can't have any knowledge, so just pursue peace of mind. Try for tranquility, whatever that takes." In other words, they usually tell you to do something or draw some conclusion from their skepticism.
- 5.12** But that's very strange, too. Where does that recommendation come from? After all, you would have to follow from this idea that you don't know anything, but they claim you don't know anything. So how could you know that's the right response? If you have no reasonable beliefs, there's no reason to believe in their recommendation or take it

seriously. So it's not so clear that one can really express skepticism in an entirely coherent way. At least that seems to be true of Academic Skepticism.

- 5.13** Now, that became part of the motivation for a deeper kind of skepticism known as Pyrrhonian skepticism. Pyrrho was the first to really take things this far. He went so far, in fact, as to conclude that the evidence of his senses gave him no reason to believe anything. And his students had to lead him around because he would just walk out on the street in front of chariots and so on. And they would say, "Pyrrho, what are you doing?" And his answer was, "That I perceive a chariot racing toward me is no reason to believe it's really there." He got to the point where he decided, "There's no reason to believe that I understand what anyone is saying at all." So he simply refused to speak. And when he wouldn't speak and wouldn't answer, the students began to think, "He's gone deaf." So they started shouting things, thinking he's hard of hearing now. And so he had to start wiggling his finger to indicate, "I hear you."
- 5.14** In any event, the Pyrrhonian skeptic says, "I don't know anything. I don't even know whether I know anything. Okay? So don't get trapped in this Socratic idea of, 'I know that I know nothing.' No, no, no—I don't even know that." So typically the Pyrrhonian skeptic argues, but they deny knowing whether skepticism follows, and they make no recommendations. They essentially just attack other people's views. So you claim you know something, the Pyrrhonian will say, "I bet you don't know it," and they'll start challenging you and trying to convince you you don't know it. But if you say, "Well, what about you, Pyrrho? What do you know?" "I don't know."
- 5.15** That's one way of looking at the difference between these two branches of ancient skepticism. If I say, "What do you know?" The Academic skeptic says, "Nothing." And the Pyrrhonian skeptic says, "I don't know"—which does seem consistent, if entirely unhelpful.
- 5.16** Now, what kinds of arguments could you have for skepticism? How could you be convinced there's no reason to believe anything? Well, Cicero writes a work on Academic skepticism. Cicero, in fact, is our source for a great deal of information about ancient Stoicism, ancient skepticism. He himself says, "I'm contributing only a few original ideas of my own, mostly I'm reporting the ideas of others." And many of those texts he's reporting on have since been lost. So he's our best source for what some of these people were thinking.
- 5.17** In any case, he divides things into five arguments. And then Descartes, as we'll next time, adds a new argument that's quite dramatic. But in Cicero, they're what he refers to as "inapprehensibility"—or might be referred to as just the argument from illusion. There's the argument from "comparison," from "variability." There is what's now known as the "problem of the criterion," and then there are "paradoxes." I want to talk about each of those five in turn and try to understand what those arguments are like. They all have a certain amount of modern appeal as well. I don't think there's anyone

here that we can just discard and say, "Oh, well, now we know there's some problem with this." They're all to be taken quite seriously.

- 5.18** They start with maybe the most primitive and earliest version of an argument from illusion. It's found in Zeno's paradoxes. They date from the fifth century BC, and they're arguments against the possibility of motion. Aristotle gives us an account of what this is. "The first argument asserts the non-existence of motion on the ground that that which is in locomotion must arrive at the half-way stage before it arrives at the goal." I say, "I think I can move. I think I can move across this room." Zeno says, "No, you can't."
- 5.19** Why not? Well, before you'd get to the other side, you'd have to go halfway. Before you could get to the other side now, you'd have to go halfway again. And halfway again. And halfway again. You'll never get there. Because in each case, you can only get there by first going halfway, it would require infinite number of motions to actually get to the other side of the room. Surely it would take you forever to get to the other side of the room. You could never achieve it.
- 5.20** Now, it certainly looks as if I can walk over, I say, "Aha, I refute you, Zeno!" But Zeno is going to say, "What does that show me? It does look like you've refuted me, but I've proved that motion is impossible. Conclusion is: motion is an illusion. What you've just done is perform an illusion. You didn't really move at all. Somehow, you tricked me into thinking you did." Okay, that's wild.
- 5.21** Here's a second argument Zeno gives: Achilles and the Tortoise. In a race, the quickest runner can never overtake the slowest since the pursuer must first reach the point where the pursuit started. Okay, so here's the idea. Tortoise challenges Achilles to a race. Achilles says, "Yeah, sure. I'll give you a head start." Here's Achilles, and the tortoise is starting from there. Well, in order to overtake the tortoise, Achilles first has to go to where the tortoise was. But by now, the tortoise has moved forward a little bit. Well, to overtake him, he's got to get to that point. But by then, the tortoise has moved a little further. He's got to then get to that point. But the tortoise has moved on. He can never catch the tortoise. So the tortoise, of course, will win the race.
- 5.22** Now, that's absurd, right? You could, again, give that turtle a little bit of a head start; you can clearly run past it. Zeno's conclusion, "But I proved to you that it would take you an infinite amount of time to catch the tortoise." Actually, sorry, what you just did: an illusion. It couldn't possibly have happened.
- 5.23** Now, he takes it further than this. Some of these arguments are really pretty amusing. So one is from unity. It seems like there are different things in the universe. But he says, "Look, that can't be right because I might think I have two hands—right hand, left hand. Well, then, there must be something in between, separating them. Anytime you've got two objects, there must be something in between that divides them. Okay, so there's stuff in between. But now, what's between the hand and the stuff in between? There

must be something in there that divides them. But then, take whatever that is, there must be something between it and the hand that divides it from the hand. And so there have to be infinitely many things between my two hands. But that's absurd.

5.24 Okay, so what that shows us: there can't be different things in the universe. There's got to be only one thing in the universe. But it sure seems like they're different things. It's an illusion. Now, my joke is: a friend once said about my house—which didn't look as bad as what's pictured there, but nevertheless, I did at one point have 30 cats. And it really did seem as if between any two cats in my house, there's another cat. But of course, that would imply that there are infinitely many cats, and there are not infinitely many cats in my house or anywhere else. So it follows that, well, what? All these cats are an illusion. I wish that were—well, I don't wish that were true. But litter boxes would have been easier to deal with if it were true.

5.25 Now, those arguments go on to other things. He considers whether: if there can't be more than one thing in the universe, it must be very, very big. But no, there would have to be something dividing its sides. If there's anything in between that divides the sides, there would have to be infinitely many, so the sides can't be divided; so the universe consists of one thing, and it's actually just a point. That, too, is bizarre. It certainly doesn't seem like that's the way things are, so the world is an illusion. Well, that's one form of the argument from illusion.

5.26 There are other somewhat more convincing forms. And by the way, before putting down Zeno, I should say it was not until the 19th century—when we had a theory of infinite sequences and infinite limits, and the modern reconstruction of the calculus—that we could really say what's wrong with Zeno's arguments. So these were things that were puzzling to people for a very, very long time.

5.27 Now, some of the ancient arguments are expressed nicely by Philo of Alexandria, who was the first person to try to reconcile Jewish religion with Greek philosophy. And he writes a number of works on biblical passages and then begins to reflect on philosophical themes in them. So he's somebody who is often ignored in philosophy because it seems as if he's talking just about Noah or about Lot or about whoever it is. You don't realize after a while that this is really a work of philosophy introduced with a certain interpretation of a biblical story.

5.28 But anyway, he talks a lot about skeptical arguments in a work called *On Drunkenness*, where the idea is, well, the world looks pretty different when you're really drunk. Now, here's the argument from illusion as he presents it. We often misperceive things. We think we usually get the world right, but often we do suffer illusions. We get things wrong. But here's the thing: there's no way to tell in a particular case whether we are misperceiving things or not. So on any given occasion, we might be misperceiving things. We could always be subject to an illusion.

- 5.29 Descartes says, "Hey, to be sure, 'Whatever I've so far admitted as most true I've learned either from the senses or through the senses. But sometimes I've caught them deceiving me. It's prudent never to trust fully anything that's once deceived me.' Sometimes I fall prey to illusions, and sometimes maybe I can see through them, but sometimes it's really due to the nature of my perceptual system. I can't see it any other way.
- 5.30 Here's a classic case discussed a lot in cognitive psychology: the Müller-Lyer illusion. You can look at a line like that, and it looks to anyone as if the left part is longer than the right-hand part. And yet, you can see in terms of the measurements, they're exactly the same length. And yet even knowing they are the same length, I can't see them as the same length. I see the one on the left as longer. Our visual systems are simply set up to see it that way, and we can't see it any other way. Even though we know that the left-hand part and the right-hand part are the same length. I cannot force myself to see it that way.
- 5.31 Take a look at this. Which is larger of those two orange dots? They're exactly the same size. But even knowing that, I cannot make myself see it as the same size. I'm comparing it to what's around it in each case. And so the one around big things I see as smaller, the one around smaller things I see as larger, and I can't unsee that. The same thing is true no matter what the background is here.
- 5.32 What about that? I tend to see that as weird things spiraling in, but in fact, it's just squares embedded within one another. Or here, those lines are all parallel. But even knowing that, I can't make myself see it that way. How about this café? It's the same thing. Those lines are actually parallel, but the bricks are arranged in such a way as to trick your sense organs and make you think it's jumbled and actually almost Escher-like. Confusing visually. Here, line AC and AB, which looks longer? AC, right? But in fact, they're exactly the same length.
- 5.33 We're used to seeing things in perspective, and we discount for that. But it's easy to trick our visual apparatus by relying on that. The same thing is true of the two blue lines. The one on the left looks longer than the one on the right, but it is not. They are the same length. Here, A and B, they look— well, they don't look the same size, but actually they are. What about that shape in the middle? It looks distorted, but in fact, it's a perfect circle. This looks like a spiral, but it's not. It's actually just a bunch of ellipses embedded within one another. Same thing is true of that. In fact, that one, even knowing that—and if I can trace them around and see that that's true— but even so, I can't believe it.
- 5.34 That, too, a bunch of perfect circles. But it doesn't look like that. There, it looks like that part in the middle is larger, it's magnified in some way, but it's not. Now, look at squares A and B. They're the same color, exactly the same shade. But that doesn't look like it's true at all. Again, even knowing that, I can't make myself see it that way. The same thing is true of the gray column on the left and on the right. They are the same

color. You can look at this without the interference. It looks like that gets darker on one side. But if I put it against a solid background, you see, no, it's all the same color. It's the background that makes us perceive it differently. That looks like it's in motion, but it's not. It's stationary. Same thing is true of this, or of that. Now, there: count the white dots.

- 5.35** Well, all of those are cases where we suffer illusions, but there are also cases of ambiguity where you can just see it in different ways. This is Wittgenstein's famous duck-rabbit. You can see it as a duck or you can see it as a rabbit. Usually there, it's not very hard to switch from one view to the other view. The Necker cube is another example. You might see one side as projected out toward the front, but you could also flip your perception and see it the other way. I tend to see first that lower square as the one facing me, but if I think about it, I can switch it so that it's in the back and the top one is actually the one facing me.
- 5.36** Now, people have thought a lot in the tradition of skepticism about those sorts of arguments from illusion. It looks like we're often able to be misled, and we can't really trust our perceptions on certain things. And that's a serious matter, by the way; a serious matter in courts of law, for example, we rely a lot on eyewitness testimony. But eyewitness testimony is not very reliable, and it's somewhat depressing that it's not. Can you recognize a face that you had never seen before, and now several days, or weeks, or even months, or years later, you're asked to identify that person? People are actually pretty unreliable about doing that, which should disturb us if we're ever accused of a criminal offense. But it's not just things like that.
- 5.37** If you look at the interviews of the witnesses in Dealey Plaza on November 22nd, 1963, of the assassination of President Kennedy, and you ask people, as the FBI did, "How many shots were fired? How many shots did you hear?" The answers range from 3 to 17. Now, that's an astounding range. The vast majority of people say either 3 or 4 or 5. But then you have a few people reporting these, and one guy was convinced there were 17 shots. How you would even count 17 shots in a short time, I don't know. Maybe that's really his way of just saying, "Well, a lot."
- 5.38** They might not be totally wrong. It might have been echoes and other things that made people confused about how many shots were fired. But that seems like a very fundamental thing. How many shots were there? And yet, eyewitnesses are all over the place in answering that sort of question. And so really, that argument from illusion—that we can't trust our perceptions very well—is a serious matter.
- 5.39** Now, there is an additional problem that I think philosophers haven't thought nearly enough about, but psychologists are beginning to examine. We're capable of missing a great deal if we're paying attention to something else. This is called the problem of inattention. Our brains have limited capacity. They ignore most of the evidence we receive through the senses. Actually, our optic nerves only transmit to the brain a small subset of what's there on the retina, and most of that the brain discards as irrelevant.

- 5.40 That's why we're astounded when we read, let's say, the Sherlock Holmes stories, or Agatha Christie's stories about Hercule Poirot, because we look at it and we think, "How does he notice all this?" Well, it's unimaginable to most of us because we're discarding most of the information we receive, and we need to. If we kept all that information around, our heads would have to be the size of dump trucks in order to process all of that. It's important that we do that, but it means we can miss a great deal.
- 5.41 Let me talk a little bit about some of the experiments. It started with things that were taking place in a university setting. Students would come in—they were the subjects of the experiments— and they would ask for a certain form in an office. Someone would say, "Oh, I'll get you the form." They would bend down like this to get the form. Another person would pop up and hand them the form. The students never noticed. Now, you might say, "Well, one bureaucrat is like another bureaucrat. It doesn't matter who hands you the form."
- 5.42 Then people began to do this in more extreme ways. There are some famous instances of this. A bunch of students are around bouncing basketballs and passing basketballs to one another. You're asked to count the number of times they pass. And as that happens, something comes into the scene. In one instance, it's someone with an umbrella, in another case, it's someone dressed in a gorilla costume. But if you're counting the basketballs, you don't notice. Most people do not notice. I know the first time I saw one of these, I didn't see this.
- 5.43 Then we were told, "All right, forget about the counting. Now—" and a few people laughed halfway through this video. "What are you laughing at?" But then you're reshown the video without the distraction of counting, and you realize, "Oh, yes, this guy comes in in a gorilla costume, stares right at the camera, goes [grunts], and then walks off." Almost no one saw it. Astounding.
- 5.44 You can change things in the background. You're watching people sitting there at a café —and it happens slowly—you see nothing change beyond they're drinking their coffee. But then, if you speed it up or just show you the beginning and the end, you realize, wait, the color of the café wall behind them went from red to blue, and no one noticed. There are a variety of these things that have been taking place.
- 5.45 Derren Brown has done some experiments showing that people can mistake even radical changes. For example, he started with him asking for directions, then someone coming in with a large poster—of him, by the way—interrupting this, and then someone else popping up, and then receiving the directions. But okay, if it's people who look kind of alike, you might think, "Sure, people aren't paying attention." But then he was replaced by a very tall Jamaican fellow, and a very short Asian woman, and so on.

- 5.46 Again, almost no one notices. A few people do, but almost no one sees the difference. It's astounding. We just ignore this. You can replace people in the scene, and nobody seems to notice, or at least very few do. That's disturbing, too. Because you might think it relates to the absence of the elephant in the room. "Did you see such and such happen? Was there a gorilla in that video?" 90% are going to say no, because they were paying attention to something else, even though there was.
- 5.47 Now, a form that this can take is to talk about the possibility of dreaming. How do I know that right now I am not asleep and dreaming this? Maybe I fell asleep. I'm supposed to be lecturing on skepticism, but instead, my alarm didn't go off, and I am sleeping, but somewhere my brain is saying, "Aren't you supposed to be discussing skepticism?" And so I'm dreaming that I'm giving this lecture when I'm really not. Or maybe somebody in my morning coffee slipped in some LSD, and I'm hallucinating that I'm giving this lecture, even though I'm really not. Well, how do I know that's not the case?
- 5.48 Descartes is worried about this. He says, "In my sleep, I experience the same things as madmen do when they're awake, sometimes even less probable things. How often have I been persuaded in the quiet of the night of familiar things that I was here in my robe sitting near the fire, when in fact I was lying disrobed beneath the sheets." He says, "It seems to me now I'm looking at the paper with waking eyes. My head, I can move it—it's not asleep. I deliberately and knowingly extend my hand and feel it. What happens in sleep isn't so distinct, no doubt. But as if I don't remember being tricked while asleep by similar things on other occasions." In other words, it seems to me when I'm awake, that when I'm dreaming, yeah, things are funny and they're vague and weird things happen. But when I'm asleep, I totally believe in them. And so the fact that I totally believe right now that I'm awake isn't actually very good evidence that I'm awake.
- 5.49 He says, "When I think about this more carefully, I see so plainly that there are no certain indications by which we may clearly distinguish being awake from being asleep that I'm dumbfounded. My astonishment almost persuades me that I'm asleep." Now, I want to focus on that phrase, "There are no certain indications to allow us to distinguish that we're awake here." That in other words, we're perceiving things accurately instead of misperceiving.
- 5.50 This is why Cicero calls this inapprehensibility. What he means is there's no mark, there's no sign, there's nothing in the perception itself that says, "I'm a veridical perception. I'm depicting the world accurately. You are awake. This is really happening. You are perceiving it accurately." There's nothing like that. When we are in a certain perceptual state, there is nothing that marks that state as accurate or inaccurate.
- 5.51 Indeed, if I showed you most of those illusions in a different context—and wasn't talking about illusions, just giving you a test of visual perception, for example, saying, "Which line do you perceive to be longer?"—you would have said, "Oh, AB is longer

than AC." It would never have occurred to you that maybe you were misperceiving. There was nothing in the experience itself that cried out and told you, "You're being tricked. You're being tricked." Or, "No, you're getting things right."

5.52 Now, Zhuangzi was an ancient Chinese Daoist philosopher who was a skeptic and puts these kinds of arguments in a really memorable way. He says, "Those who dream at the banquet, wake to lamentation and sorrow. Those who dream of lamentation and sorrow, wake to join the hunt. While they dream, they don't know that they dream. Some will even interpret the very dream they're dreaming. And only when they're awake, do they know it was a dream." Indeed, I think he's observing something interesting here. Sometimes, maybe in a slightly—a state that's somewhere between being awake and being asleep, you start being aware of this.

5.53 I had the sensation, for example, last night in a dream that I had opened an email and clicked yes when I meant to click no, and I realized that was a fishing attempt. I'm in big trouble, okay? I dreamt that. But then later I started feeling terrible like, "Oh, my gosh, I've got to do this. I've got to do that. I better call the university and blah, blah, blah, blah, blah." Then I started—but still within this dreaming state— thinking, "But I dreamt that. I don't really have to do that." But then my brain starts to say, "But yes, you do. You're in big trouble." And then I said, "No, it was just a dream." But I was still dreaming. So sometimes you can be dreaming that you're dreaming and have dreams within dreams. Maybe that doesn't happen very often, but it does happen sometimes, and clearly it happened to Zhuangzi.

5.54 Now, I think his most memorable instance of this, and it's really beautifully done, is about Zhuangzi and the Butterfly. It inspires art like the one you're seeing there because it's a story that people can remember for years. My own daughter took my intro philosophy class many, many years ago, and she later told me there was only one thing she really remembered clearly—which depresses me. But anyway, it was this. It was Zhuangzi and the Butterfly.

5.55 Here's the passage. "Once upon a time, I, Zhuangzi, dreamt I was a butterfly, fluttering hither and thither to all intents and purposes a butterfly. I was conscious only of following my fancies as a butterfly, and was unconscious of my individuality as a man. Suddenly, I awaked, and there I lay, myself again. Now I don't know whether I was then a man dreaming I was a butterfly, or whether I am now a butterfly dreaming I'm a man." That's a creepy thought, in a way, but it's a very powerful thought.

5.56 There is, incidentally, a Star Trek: The Next Generation episode that's a bit like this involving Commander Riker, who is being held by aliens and being convinced he's in an insane asylum. It's like, "Wait, am I mad? Is this reality? What is happening?" It's very much like the dreaming thing. They're giving him drugs to simulate psychotic episodes, but it's the same kind of thing. "Am I a madman dreaming of a commander of a spaceship? Or on the other hand, am I a commander of a spaceship who is enduring

some weird psychological state?" He goes back and forth and really has no idea which is the accurate one.

- 5.57** Well, let's move on to the argument from comparison. This is an argument advanced especially by Philo of Alexandria, but also by Sextus Empiricus. It's in a way a very deep argument that inspires quite a few developments in early modern philosophy. Here's the way it goes. We know not things in themselves, but things in relation to other things, and in particular in relation to us.
- 5.58** Now, that's a bit nerve-wracking in a way, because how do we distinguish what's really in the object itself, from what is being supplied by our own faculties? After all, I've got perceptual faculties, I've got cognitive faculties that are taking place in my brain, so I'm processing this information. Here, it seems like I've got a clicker in my hand, but what is the clicker really like? What are its true properties? What about my experiences is really there in reality, and what is being supplied by my own perceptual faculties, by my own cognition in the way my brain is organizing the information it receives from my sense organs?
- 5.59** Something, presumably in the world, is causing me to have these sensations—let's go with Aristotle on that. But still, how much of what I perceive here—that it's gray and black, for example, that it has a certain shape and a certain feel to it—how much of that is being supplied by my own brain, and how much of that is truly in the thing in itself, the ultimate cause of those sensations?
- 5.60** The fact is, I have no way of knowing. I can't step outside of my own brain, my own sense organs, and see what it's really like in reality. It's as if I'm in the matrix and I can't take the pill that takes me out of the matrix and see what's really going on. By definition, I've got to rely on my sense organs and my brain to understand the world. As a result, there's no way to distinguish what's really in the object itself from what I'm contributing. But if that's right, I look at an object and I think, "Oh, I know all sorts of things about it. But do I really? There's nothing I know for sure is about the object itself rather than just being supplied by my own sense organs, by my own brain." And that's a rather frightening thought.
- 5.61** Zhuangzi, I think, has this idea, too. He says, "Intellectual distinctions in general correspond to nothing in reality." Or at least it might be safer to say, we have no idea which of them might correspond to things in reality. It looks to me like parts of this are gray and parts of this are black. Well, I draw a distinction between the gray parts and the black parts. But does that correspond to a difference in reality? How would I know?
- 5.62** Now, Zhuangzi, it said, took this to an extreme. He said, "Well, then there's no reason to believe anything. There's no point to doing anything." Zhu Xi, a Neo-Confucian philosopher, said, "Laozi still wanted to do something—he's the founder of Daoism—but Zhuangzi didn't want to do anything at all." Well, maybe. One thing he does say is that subjectivity and objectivity are all wrapped up together.

- 5.63** I think it's his way of expressing the argument from comparison. He says, "I don't know which of my perceptions of this, which of my thoughts about it, are objectively true of the thing itself, and which are really subjective reactions based on my own cognitive apparatus. I can't tell. Objectivity and subjectivity are all intertwined. They depend on each other. After all, I've got to rely on my own perceptions, on my own subjectivity to determine what this thing is like, which means that any distinction I make that I claim to be objective, really relies on my own subjective reactions.
- 5.64** And yet subjectivity also seems to be something I could describe objectively. I can say, "Well, it seems to me that parts of this are gray. It seems to me that parts of this are black." And there I seem to be objective. And yet I'm not being objective about the thing in itself; I'm being objective about my own subjective states of mind. So he says, in the end, "I don't see how we achieve true objectivity and know anything for sure about the way the world really is. So knowledge seems to be impossible. Even a reasonable belief about the way the world truly is independently of our cognitive apparatus, that seems impossible."
- 5.65** So he concludes, "That means I can't trust any distinctions I draw, any distinctions I perceive, any conclusions I reach. I should just reject this. At most, I can say how things seem to me. There, I'm on pretty safe ground. But how things are, I can't say anything." So he says, "Just place yourself in subjective relation to things." Meaning: just say how things seem to you. There's nothing more you can say. Don't pretend to know how things are.
- 5.66** And he tells some stories about subjectivity. This is another memorable one. "A keeper of monkeys said with regard to the ration of chestnuts that each monkey was to have three in the morning and four at night. At this the monkeys were very angry, so the keeper said they might have four in the morning and three at night, with which arrangement they were all well-pleased." It was the same number of chestnuts, the same thing in reality, but subjectively it seemed really different to them. And so the point is, in a way, that it's the subjectivity that ultimately matters. Forget about the claims to objectivity. It doesn't matter to the monkeys that it was really just seven chestnuts a day.
- 5.67** Okay, this brings us to the argument from variability. Really, I think you could see the argument from illusion and maybe even the argument from comparison as special cases of this. Here's the idea, and again, I'll stay with Zhuangzi because he does such a beautiful job of expressing these arguments. "Men admire Mao Ch'iang and Li Chi, at the sight of whom fishes plunge deep down the water, birds soar high in the air, and deer hurry away. Who shall say what's the correct standard of beauty?"
- 5.68** Well, here's the general mode, as Sextus puts it. "We find that undecidable dissension about a matter proposed has come about in ordinary life and among philosophers." In other words, people disagree all over the place. They perceive things differently. They don't see things the same way. They disagree about things. They have different

opinions. Here's the problem: we can't choose or rule out anything on any neutral grounds, so we have to suspend judgment.

- 5.69** Here's the way we might frame the argument in general: Things are perceived differently by different beings at different times. Now there are a bunch of different versions in Sextus—for example, as I recall, you have six different modes, all of which have this form. Different people see things different ways. Beings of different species perceive things different ways. Bats see things very differently from cats, and they see things differently from the way we perceive them and so on.
- 5.70** Here's the problem: there's no neutral way to determine which perceptions are right. There's no way to say, "All right, now I'm imagining that I'm not a bat or a cat or a human being. I want to see what the world is really like." There's no way to do that. We can't step outside. There is no neutral way to determine this. So, conclusion: knowledge is impossible. Or even more radically, in the ancient world: there's no reason to believe that any perception is trustworthy. There's always another alternative, and there's no neutral way to tell that this is likely to be better than that one.
- 5.71** Consequently, given the differences and no way of telling, what should we do? Well, the best we can do is suspend judgment. We have no reason to trust any of them. Sometimes this is a matter of different species. Sometimes it's a matter of different people. It can even be me at different times. I may feel differently about something or have a different opinion at different times. How do I know which portrays reality accurately, which should be trusted?
- 5.72** There's an example like this in Dostoevsky of a young man who realizes, "I'm going to inherit a great fortune. I'm undoubtedly at age 50, going to see things very differently from the way I see things at age 20. But what should I trust? My 20-year-old self or my 50-year-old self? And how would we tell? What's a neutral way? If only we had a way of not being any particular age at all." Well, there's no way to do that. We can't tell which of those is more reliable.
- 5.73** Now, the problem of the criterion, our fourth argument. You might think, "Hey, wait a minute. I know how to solve this problem. Let's have a neutral arbiter. Let's have a fact checker. Let's have somebody come in who's neutral, who can tell us what is really trustworthy." Okay, let's have an arbiter between us. Now, Sextus says, "That's not going to work. If we get somebody who agrees with me, he'll side with me. If we get somebody who is on your side, he'll side with you. How could anybody like that arbitrate between us? If I employ somebody who differs from both of us, who doesn't agree with either, he's not going to be able to decide between us."
- 5.74** In short, there's no such thing as a neutral arbiter. There's no way of going to neutral arbitration. If that's right, well, we seem to face this problem of finding a criterion. If only we had a criterion that would tell us which perception was accurate, or at least

which perceptions were more reliable than others. But there's no such neutral criterion.

- 5.75** Now, suppose you propose one. Suppose you say, "I think there is a criterion. Here it is." I can say, "How do you know that's the right criterion?" There could be other criteria that would do this. Why is that the right one? Say, "Well, I don't know. I guess I need a criterion of criteria." Well, but okay, you propose one. That's the right criterion. How do you know that's the right one? Okay, there could be multiple criteria of criteria, and it looks like we get led into an infinite regress.
- 5.76** So either we can't find a neutral one at all, or somebody proposes a neutral one, and then I say, "How do you know that's neutral?" We need a criterion for neutrality, and we get led up into this infinite regress. A suspension of judgment, he says, is the only thing that's rational in response to that. There is no neutral ground to stand on. So that's the problem. There's no neutral way to tell which perceptions ought to be trusted or which opinions ought to be trusted. It would be nice to have a criterion for doing that, but we'd need a criterion for telling us which perceptions to trust, and then a criterion of the possible criteria for doing that. In the end, we could never justify a criterion.
- 5.77** We would end up either arguing circularly, like, "Here's my criterion. Why is it the right one? It says it's the right one." That's not very convincing. Or I'd get led into this infinite regress. This is the right criterion because—How do you know that's the right and neutral fact checker? Well, this guy says he is. How do you know that guy's neutral? Well, that person says he is, and so on. We would face an infinite regress. We get into trouble.
- 5.78** Now, this isn't just, I think, a philosophical curiosity, as you might think Zeno's paradoxes are. What do you mean? There aren't things in the universe that take up any space and that nothing moves, etc. Here, they're real problems. People worry a lot about gerrymandering, for example, dividing up political districts in a way to advantage one party or another. Often people will say, "We need a neutral way to do that." But what would be the neutral way? People say, "We need a neutral bipartisan commission." But the moment it makes a recommendation, people will say, "Well, that commission was biased!" You would need a criterion of determining what are neutral arbiters for doing the gerrymandering and dividing up the areas into districts. And it looks like the moment you do that, you face this infinite regress, or you just have circularity. You have the commission saying, "We're trustworthy." Well, why should you believe them? That's a problem.
- 5.79** Similarly, with a political debate, people often complain, "I don't like the moderator of that debate. I think they were on this side or on that side. We need a neutral moderator." But where do we find a neutral moderator? Maybe these people propose that moderator, these propose that one. We need a criterion for determining who would be neutral. But the moment I propose a criterion, somebody on the other side is

going to say, "No, no. no. That would be my favorite criterion." Now we need a criterion of criteria, and we go up into the infinite regress.

5.80 Or finally, something that's been talked about a lot over the last few years, the problem of bad information—misinformation, disinformation, whatever you want to call it. Yeah, it would be great if we had a neutral way of deciding what's true, and hence the fact checker and so on. But the problem is there's no neutral ground on which to stand to do that. Really, who could tell you what's accurate information, what's inaccurate information? Now, if God were to pronounce, let's say God knows all, and God says, "I'll tell you, okay, I've just read the New York Times this morning, and here's what you could trust, here's what you can't," or something, then great.

5.81 But how would we know that anybody trying to tell us this is themselves neutral? There's no way to do it. There is no neutral way. The moment somebody says, "Here would be a neutral way," somebody else would say, "No, this is a better neutral way." Again, we get laid into the infinite regress. This, in short, isn't just a philosophical problem. It's a real practical problem.

5.82 Now, the last problem. What if the whole thing is completely misleading? That is to say, what if there is no way to trust anything in our surroundings and say, "This is reality." I've been assuming that there is a real thing in itself underlying, for example, my perception of this clicker. And I perceive parts of it as gray, parts of it is black, I perceive it as having a certain shape. But the skeptic says, "Well, what is it really like, independently of your faculty of perception, independently of the cognitive processing of your brain, what is the thing in itself truly like?" We've worried that, well, we're not sure.

5.83 But now, what if it's worse than that? Because we've been assuming something like realism and the difficulty of reaching out and actually talking about the underlying reality. But what if there isn't one, or at least isn't one on anything like our plane of existence? What if this is all a computer simulation? What if we're all just avatars—we're all just characters in a video game? Elon Musk is reported to have said the chance we're not living in a computer simulation is one in billions. He's convinced the world is a matrix-like world. There's no way to get out of that. There's no way to actually break the simulation, take the red pill, and somehow get to the true reality. Well, what then?

5.84 Now, different people disagree about this, right? Here, again, we have an instance of variability. Here's one report, "There's only a 20% chance that we're all sims." That's not really that reassuring to me. Bank of America—why they're discussing this, I'm not sure—but they say, "There's a 20% to 50% chance we're inside the matrix and reality is just a simulation." That seems puzzling. Here's another article, "Elon Musk is wrong. We aren't living in a simulation." How would we possibly know?

5.85 Now, here is a good case then of people seeing this differently. Some say, "Actually, I think we are living inside some computer simulation. But that too is puzzling because

who simulated us?" Even if I'm just a sim, even if I'm just an avatar, I'm some beings avatar, aren't I? So there must be some other plane of existence in which people are just playing this as a video game. I don't know, but we can't access that. What would that be like? Is there any likelihood at all that we're actually in such a simulation? How would we know?

- 5.86** When we face a question like this, that problem of variability and the problem of finding neutral grounds becomes really acute. How would I tell whether Elon Musk is right that there's a 99.999% chance that we're in a simulation or other people saying, no, it's very remote. Some people saying 20%, 50%. On what basis? How could we possibly be in a position to neutrally decide a question like that? If we can't, what does that mean?
- 5.87** The skeptic says, it means not that we should be terribly worried in our personal lives about a simulation. Like, "Oh, sure, I'm going to walk in front of that car because it's just a simulation. The guy will just press the button, reset, and I'll be back to being alive." No, it's not like that. It doesn't really make any difference to me one way or another from one point of view. But from another point of view, you could say, "That's a pretty deep question. Is there anything like a reality of the form we think there is—and we have no way to tell?" Scary.
- 5.88** Now, let me talk about the problem that Cicero focuses on. Interestingly, Zhuangzi, Sextus, and a variety of other skeptics tend to ignore this problem, but Cicero takes it quite seriously, and I think there's good reason to take it seriously. Here is the classic liar paradox. The reason Cicero is interested is that he thinks this implies we don't even understand what truth is. We've been talking about, do we know anything? Is it reasonable to believe anything? Should we ever think our states of mind correspond to reality and are actually true? But what if we don't even know what truth means? Then there's a deeper puzzle. We don't even know what it means for something to be true.
- 5.89** Here, from the New Testament, Paul's letter to Titus, "One of them,"—Epimenides—"a prophet of their own, said, 'Cretans are always liars, evil beasts, lazy gluttons.'" So someone from Crete says, "Cretans are always liars." Well, it seems to imply that they're lying in saying that, right, if they're always liars? Now, that itself is not a paradox because if the person is telling the truth, well, then it looks like they're lying, they're saying something false. So suppose what they're saying is false, that Cretans are always liars, well, then some Cretans don't lie. And so actually, that's not a paradox.
- 5.90** But we can put it into a more paradoxical form. If we imagine the Cretan saying, "I am lying right now," or a purer form, just, "This sentence is false." Suppose it's true, then it's false. But suppose it's false. Well, it says it's false, so it must be true. I mean, that can seem odd. Maybe there's something wrong with such sentences like, "I am lying," or, "This sentence is false." But there is one simple way out, which is to say, well, it can't be true, it can't be false. Maybe it's just neither true nor false. We might think

that's a way to solve it. Maybe other sentences are neither true nor false. But we can fix that problem.

5.91 The strong liar paradox says, "This sentence isn't true." Suppose it's true, then it's not true. Suppose it's not true, then it's true. Now it doesn't seem so easy to get out of. We can't really say it's neither true nor not true. It looks like now we're really trapped. Maybe it's both true and not true. Some people have said that, but that's disturbing. Otherwise, what do we do? How do we deal with that? Now, you might think it's because there's this weird self-reference, "I am lying," or, "This sentence is false, this sentence is not true."

5.92 But we can get rid of that problem. For example, John says, "Everything Bill says is false." Bill says, "Everything John says is true." Neither sentence actually is by itself self-referential. On the other hand, we put them together and we realize, oh, we're led into a paradox. John says everything Bill says is false. Bill says everything John says is true. It looks like Bill is saying everything John says is true. One of those things is what Bill says is false. That implies what Bill says is false. But then, well, it's false that everything John says is true. So something Bill says must be true. But if we imagine Bill saying only that one thing, we have a paradox. We can make that as big as we want. "What Mary tells you is true. What Carol tells you is true. Carol says what Alice tells you is false." We can make these loops big and get paradoxes as long as people just say this.

5.93 Here's another paradox like this, and it's about knowledge itself. "This sentence isn't known by anyone." Well, that's a weird thing, but suppose I say it's false. Well, then somebody must know it, right? But if they know it, it must be true because you can't know what isn't true. But we've just shown that if it's false, it would have to be true. So it's true. But now we know it, so it's false. Okay, that's actually a pretty deep paradox, and it's hard to get out of that one. It seems to suggest that it's not just truth and falsehood we don't understand. We don't understand even the basics of the logic of knowledge.

5.94 This one is related; it's called Fitch's paradox, because Frederic Fitch, a logician, thought of this. Suppose you think every true sentence can be known. It's knowable. But some true sentences aren't known—surely there are things we don't know. Now, his argument is those can't both be true. That sounds a little surprising. Suppose P is true but isn't known. Well, then it's possible to know that P is true but unknown. I just told you that. But then we'd know P, but also know we didn't know it. But if we know we don't know it, we don't know it, so we'd know it and not know it. He takes that as an argument that you cannot say every true sentence can be known. So he thinks that means there are some unknowable truths. And so this isn't exactly a paradox. It might be that we can prove, logically, there are truths you cannot possibly know. But it seems surprising that we could just prove that outright.

5.95 So far, whatever you think about those logical paradoxes, let's come to the question of recommendations, because we've heard all these arguments on the basis of which

we're supposed to conclude we can't have any reasonable beliefs, and we can't know anything. So what? So what do we do? The skeptic gives us all these arguments, and we might, like David Hume, say, "Yeah, yeah, yeah, I'm going to go back and have my dinner. So forget about it." Interesting for the philosophy classroom, but I'm not interested in taking this any further. I'm going to go on and live my life. So who cares?

- 5.96** Well, here's what Sextus Empiricus says, "The result of all this should be suspension of judgment, and suspending judgment leads me to peace of mind." So I might worry about increasing political polarization and the collapse of bipartisanship. I might think some people are arguing this very vehemently, and others disagree and argue that very vehemently. If I get torn between these partisan battles, I get all upset. I'll tell you what I'm going to do. I'm going to suspend judgment. I'm going to say, "These guys say that, these guys say that. I don't know. I suspend judgment." Who knows? Who knows who's right? In that way, I can attain peace of mind.
- 5.97** Here is the idea: give up your claims to knowledge. Give up your fervent beliefs. Just admit, "I don't know. It seems to me this way, but who knows?" If you do that, you can be tranquil. You can have peace of mind. You can say, "Am I going to watch the news? Am I going to read the paper? Am I going to follow that particular person? No, I don't care. I just log on for pictures of cats, and that gives me peace of mind. That's enough for me."
- 5.98** Now, you could take this as an argument. Here's Gisela Striker's worry: Wait a minute, it doesn't follow that you should suspend judgment—or, for that matter, that suspending judgment will lead you to peace of mind. After all, you've said you can't know anything. You have no reason to believe anything. So you have no reason to believe that this is a reasonable recommendation.
- 5.99** But now, Sextus says, "You're right. I can't actually assert that." I can't say this follows. I can't claim that if you suspend judgment, you will have peace of mind. But let me tell you, it just happens. And so here is his response, "The skeptic had the same experience, which is said to have befallen the painter Apelles. Once, they say, when he was painting a horse and wished to represent in the painting the horse's foam [after running really hard], he was so unsuccessful that he gave up the attempt and flung at the picture the sponge he used to wipe the paints off the brush."
- 5.100** Imagine him, he's been trying this, keeps getting rid of it, can't do it. Finally, he says, "I give up," throws the sponge, and poof. What happened? "The mar of the sponge produced the effect of the horse's foam. So too," he says, "the skeptics were in hopes of gaining quietude," peace of mind, in other words, "by means of a decision regarding the disparity of the objects of sense and of thought." In other words, don't worry about whether the way it seems to you is really the way it is. Give up on worrying about that.
- 5.101** "And being unable to effect this they suspended judgment; they found the quietude, as if by chance, followed on their suspense, even as a shadow follows its substance." So

he's saying, "Am I in a position to claim that if you suspend judgment, you will have peace of mind? No, that would be an assertion. I realize I can't defend an assertion. I've just told you there's no reason to believe anything. But try it and see what happens. It'll happen." There's the effect of the horse's foam, done by just throwing the sponge. You don't make any claims, it just happens.

- 5.102** In the end, what can I say about these recommendations? Can I assert that they follow? No. Can I say this is a reasonable thing to do in response to your worry that maybe your perception of the world is really off base? No. I'm just telling you, relax. Suspend judgment. Don't insist that you're getting the world right. And you'll just, by surprise, find that you're way happier. Will I claim this is the way to happiness? No. Just try it. See what happens. The end.
- 5.103** You mentioned at the outset that skepticism disappeared from like 500 to the Middle Ages. Why? Do we know?
- 5.104** That's a great question. Why does skepticism disappear for about a thousand years? Partly, it's just that the texts are lost. And so people aren't reading Sextus or Philo; and certainly in the West, they were never reading Zhuangzi or some other skeptics. There is a fascinating report, however, of a meeting between Greek philosophers and Indian philosophers after Alexander's conquest, because Alexander conquered most of what is today the Middle East, bringing Greek and Greek culture all the way to the boundaries of India. But there he stopped. And so there were Greek philosophers who came and actually met with Indian philosophers. They described them as the naked philosophers because they just wore loin cloths, I guess. But in any event—
- 5.105** There was a very strong tradition in India of skepticism that I didn't actually talk about here. But Madhyamaka Buddhism is heavily skeptical and is similarly quietistic about what the skeptic can say. The skeptic argues against others, but makes no propositions himself. And so simply says, "You claim to know, you don't." But otherwise, puts forward no recommendations, no theses. It's after that that Greek philosophers start taking these skeptical arguments seriously. So it may well be an Indian influence.
- 5.106** But in any case, it becomes a really important school that lasts all the way from about 300 BC up to the time of Augustine. Now, Augustine wrote a work called *Against the Academics*, where he is trying to say skeptical arguments can be refuted. What it amounts to is that in Western philosophy, his refutations were actually thought to be devastating. I think the real reason it starts in Greece was due to the Indian, and specifically Buddhist, influence.
- 5.107** But I think the reason it dies out for a thousand years is not only that the texts are lost, it's because Augustine seems to give the right answer. It's an answer, by the way, that just gets copied by Descartes. Now, Descartes does add some dimensions to it. I don't want to say there's no originality, but the, "I think, I am," that we're going to be discussing next time, he's just ripping that off from Augustine in *Against the Skeptics*.

5.108 I think what it amounts to is that Augustine was able to take Platonism and express it in a form by replacing the Form of the Good with God that people actually found compelling. They thought, "Okay, wait a minute. There are things I know. As long as I'm convinced that I know even one thing, then the skeptical arguments have to be wrong." And so now the question becomes: What's wrong with them? So as long as I've got anything— I would like to say I know a lot about the world—but as long as I know anything, I know these arguments can't be right.

5.109 And so then for a thousand years, people proceed merrily thinking, "All right, that's settled. We don't have to worry about this." And it's not until Descartes comes along that he realizes, "Wait a minute, that Augustinian solution has an instability built into it," and that begins to worry him. It's when he puts the skeptical arguments in a much more powerful form than even the ancient skeptics did, that he realizes, "We'll start with Augustine's solution, but we have to do something better than that."

Lecture 6: On Rationalism

At a glance — On rationalism.

- 6.1 I've mentioned that there are two grand traditions in the Western philosophical heritage, one of them stemming from Plato, that is, in some sense, a series of footnotes to Plato, the other stemming from Aristotle, that we could describe as a bunch of footnotes to Aristotle. I want to talk today about the rationalist tradition.
- 6.2 Rationalism is a specific philosophical view. You find it in Plato. I think throughout the rationalist tradition, Plato remains the chief inspiration. Really, this is a lecture on footnotes to Plato. But in the modern context, as we'll see, this also becomes a battle against the skeptic because the skeptics were thought to be submerged for many years, for reasons I'll mention.
- 6.3 Then it reemerges in the Renaissance and early modern period and presents a new challenge. The rationalists of that period have a different problem from the one Plato faced, and therefore advanced things, in some ways, considerably beyond where Plato left them. From another point of view, you could say, they actually stage that revival by also staging a retreat.
- 6.4 The key figure here is René Descartes. Descartes was famous as a philosopher, but also as a physicist, as a mathematician. He himself was mostly a private tutor, and he carried on a long correspondence with Princess Elizabeth of Bohemia, who was really the leading classicist of her age—we'll talk a little bit more about that later. But Descartes, in short, was accomplished in a variety of intellectual areas. The fact that we still talk about Cartesian products and Cartesian graphs, and representations of all sorts of things, indicates that he really was of fundamental significance in the development of mathematics.
- 6.5 In the context of skepticism and rationalism more generally, he does make a significant contribution. He repeats arguments from dreaming, arguments from illusion, arguments of various kinds that we've looked at in the skeptical tradition. But he adds one of his own that's similar to the argument I considered about the possibility of living in a simulation. But if anything, it's even more radical than that.
- 6.6 He says, imagine that there is not a good God, but an evil deceiver who is out to trick us. He says, "I shall suppose not that God who is supremely good and is the fountain of truth, but some evil genius of the greatest power and cunning who has employed all his energies to deceive me." Why is that so devastating? He imagines an all-powerful but evil being out to trick all of us.
- 6.7 Imagine that this being makes our mind skip every time we have a thought, every time we try to draw an inference, every time we reach a conclusion. So anytime I'm about to think anything, the evil deceiver goes [makes a popping sound], and my mind skips a

beat, and I come to the wrong conclusion; I think the wrong thing. In other words, this being is all-powerful but is not good as God on the classical conception; instead is evil and sets up the universe to deceive us.

6.8 Here is why that is such a shocking contribution and makes an advance over the ancient skeptical arguments. They may apply to things we perceive by our senses, but they don't really apply to logic. They don't apply to mathematics. You could think $2 + 2 = 4$. That's true even in my dreams. That's true even if I'm suffering illusions; still, $2 + 2 = 4$. But if the evil deceiver is tricking me, then maybe my mind is making some mistake when I do that. Maybe $2 + 2 = 3.9999$ something. Maybe something else is going wrong.

6.9 In other words, every time I try to draw a logical inference, every time I think I know something in math, no matter how basic it is, maybe it's all an illusion. My mind might be getting everything wrong. That would be true even in the matrix. Even in the matrix or even if this world is a simulation, it seems like that doesn't affect logic, that doesn't affect mathematics. But if there's an evil being controlling my mind, then, actually, everything is in question, not just the things I learn through my senses, not just things that I hear from someone else or derive in some other way from experience—no, this challenges all my knowledge, even what's independent of experience. That challenges the classical rationalist conception that ended up submerging skeptical arguments for a while.

6.10 Here's the idea. The classic rationalist—here's someone like Philo of Alexandria. Even though he reports all these skeptical arguments, in the end, he's not on the side of the skeptics. He is on the side of the rationalists. He thinks it is possible to have knowledge of the world independently of experience. That really is the definition of rationalism. I can have knowledge of the world even apart from my experience of it. I can do that just through meditation or reflection alone. Why is that even possible? His answer is that the structure of the mind matches the structure of the world.

6.11 The empiricist, which we'll study next time, thinks, "I learn about the world through experience. That's why I think what's in my mind matches the world. It's caused by the world. I experience the things in the world. So I'm hoping there's enough of a match as a result of that." An idealist that we'll look at later says, "Actually, my mind is constituting the world. So of course, there's a match between my mind and the world because my mind is constructing the world."

6.12 But the rationalist has to give a more sophisticated account. "I think I know some things," says the rationalist, "that I'm not relying just on experience for. But how could I be sure I know them? How could I be sure I'm getting them right? I must think that there's some match." Here is how Philo explains it. This is the answer given later by Origen and then by Augustine. For a long time, it presides as dominant throughout Jewish and Christian philosophy, at least.

- 6.13** The idea is that these Forms that Plato had talked about seem puzzling. How could I know about them? They seem to be in some ghostly realm. They're not in space and time. It's not clear how I could causally interact with them. How could I possibly know about them? But Philo says, "Wait a minute. My concept, for example, of triangularity, is supposed to be grounded in this form of triangularity. Well, what could an idea actually match or be grounded in? It would be simplest if it was another idea?"
- 6.14** We can talk about ideas matching other ideas. If I say an idea matches something I know not what, it's not clear how I would explain that or justify it. So what if the Forms are just ideas in the mind of God? Then, instead of talking about the Form of the Good and its mystical power to shed light on the realm of the Forms in my mind, what if I just say that God has these ideas that he uses in creating the world, and both my mind and the world are stamped with the word of God? There is the logos in the world, there is the logos in my mind, and so the structure matches. They both reflect the logos, that basic order or structure that applies to the world and applies to my mind.
- 6.15** Here is why Descartes's thought experiment about the evil deceiver is so challenging and changes things fundamentally. He says that a good God would stamp my mind and your mind and the world with the same stamp. But what if we have an evil deceiver? Then that deceiver might stamp your mind or my mind with a different stamp from the one he uses to create the world: "Here's how I structure the world. Here's how I structure your mind. So there's a complete mismatch. Your mind consists of square pegs and the world consists of round holes, and none of them match." You think you have knowledge of the world after experience or before experience? Ha, you don't. Your mind is systematically mismatched to the world."
- 6.16** In that case, there is the logos, let's say, that informs the structure of the world. Your mind has the pseudo logos, this cheap imitation that doesn't match at all. "Haha, you can't know anything." It's one thing if it's just maybe intertranslatable, but if they're radically different stamps that can't even be translated into one another, like the square pegs and round holes, then what happens? Maybe everything we think is wrong.
- 6.17** Well, that challenge is a very serious challenge, and it really disrupts not only Plato's picture of the good, happily shedding light over the entire thing and making it possible for us to know the Forms. If we go the way of Philo and Augustine, we say, "No, don't talk about the good there. Talk about God." God can do anything. It's not clear the Form of the Good can do anything at all, but God can do anything.
- 6.18** God can illuminate our mind. Augustine has this theory of illumination, that God sheds light. He turns the light of the mind, as it were, and allows for us to have access to at least some of the ideas of God. That would help to explain how we can know things about humanity or justice or triangularity or the good.

- 6.19** But now, if we have an evil deceiver, we've got, in effect, a fake form. It's not the Form in which objects participate. It's not the Form that structures the world. Our minds are structured with a different set of things, and there is just a fundamental mismatch. In this case, the evil deceiver, instead of shedding a light on the mind—actually, I don't know what the right analogy is—keeps it in darkness, or maybe even better, puts you in a fun house so that nothing looks the way it really is.
- 6.20** The result of that would seem to be, yes, radical skepticism, more radical actually than we find in Zhuangzi, or in Sextus or in Philo or in any other ancient thinker, because it affects logic, it affects mathematics, it affects absolutely everything. We are utterly lost in a forest where we're convinced that nothing we think is right.
- 6.21** It's in the face of that that Descartes goes back to Augustine. Augustine had defeated the skeptic by saying, wait a minute. First of all, I may not know how the world is, but I know how it seems to me. I know that the clicker looks gray to me and looks black to me, different parts being different colors. He says, "Is it really that way? I don't know, but at least I know it seems that way to me." He says, "But there's something more that I know: I know that I am. I know that I think."
- 6.22** Because after all, suppose I were wrong, that I am. Well, who's wrong? I have to be, I have to exist in order to even be wrong about that. "I think"—well, that gives me some basis for knowledge. I know that I think. How can I be sure? Well, suppose I doubt it. Who's doubting it? Doubting is a form of thinking. And so Descartes goes back to Augustine and says, good. He's right about that. "I think"—that's something I can know. Every time it's thought or uttered, it has to be true. The same thing with the "I am."
- 6.23** So here is Descartes' solution. He says, I'm going to start with Augustine's starting point, and I'm going to prove that God exists. Now, actually, Augustine tried to do the same thing. He went from "I am, I think," to "there is a God," and then "I have knowledge of all these things." But how does he do it? It's something known as the argument from truth. I actually think it's a really good and interesting argument, but no one throughout the medieval period thought that. I have been trying to dig it out after 1,500 years and say, "Hey, this argument is worth taking seriously."
- 6.24** But Descartes doesn't really do it quite that way. He is going to try to prove that God is responsible for the ideas in my mind, that God did create the world and gave it a structure, and that God is good and would not deceive us. In a way, he's trying to resurrect that Augustinian solution, the solution of Philo of Alexandria, and he's going to do it with what he calls the new way of ideas. He's going to put the Forms inside us.
- 6.25** So instead of having this independent realm as Plato did, that we have to access, he's going to say, look at Philo's solution, in a way. He's putting the logos both in the mind and in the world. I don't have to talk about some otherworldly area, the realm of Forms. My mind is structured that way. The Forms are in us. They are these innate ideas, the ideas I'm born with. So think about that platonic image. Instead of having an

independent realm of Forms and then creating the puzzle that I have to solve through illumination or recollection or something, how do I know this independent realm? Put the ideas in our own minds.

- 6.26** But then, wait a minute: What if my idea is very different from yours? Don't talk about directly the ideas that are coming from experience. You and I might have different experiences and have different ideas there. Let's talk about the ideas that we're born with. We're all human. We're born with the same set of ideas. Then we have different experiences and learn things, so we get different ideas, different experiences. But we start with the same body of things that are innate. They're inborn. So focus on those, those innate ideas or an aspect of the logos that God gives us. They match the world because God is good. God is not an evil deceiver.
- 6.27** Now, this way out, of course, means I've got to get from the "I am" to "God is." That's a bit of heavy philosophical lifting, so it's not going to be easy to do that. But that's the idea. If there's an evil deceiver, I could be wrong about everything. However, if God is good, if God created me, if God created the world, if God wouldn't, being good, want to deceive me, then, hey, maybe there are some things I cannot reasonably doubt. There are some things I know for sure.
- 6.28** So the first one is "I am." And here he goes back to Augustine. He says, "But let's say there is some deceiver or other, very powerful, very cunning, who ever employs his ingenuity in deceiving me, then without doubt, I exist also if he deceives me. I have to be in order to be deceived. And let him deceive me as much as he will. He can never cause me to be nothing so long as I think that I am something." In order to be deceived, I have to be. I have to exist. So I can know that I exist.
- 6.29** "We come to the definite conclusion that this proposition: I am, I exist, is necessarily true each time I pronounce it or mentally conceive it." Every time I say, I exist or think I am, I've got to be right. Who else is thinking it? Now, incidentally, Buddhist logicians would disagree with this. They would say, "At most, I'm entitled to 'there is thinking.'" But I think ultimately, it's not going to matter because as long as there's something that is definitely true, every time it's thought or uttered, whatever that is, it's going to be enough to defeat the skeptic.
- 6.30** The same thing he says is true of "I think." "What of thinking? I find here that thought is an attribute that belongs to me; it can't be separated from me." I think, and I realize, suppose I'm wrong about that. But wait, I'm thinking that I might be wrong. So I'm thinking. So I've got to be thinking. I've got to exist even in order to think.
- 6.31** So he says, "To speak accurately, I'm not more than a thing that thinks. That is to say, a mind or a soul or an understanding or a reason,"—which are terms whose significance was formerly unknown to me. "But I'm a real thing. I really exist."—I couldn't be wrong about that—"And what thing? I've answered a thing that thinks." Why? Because as

soon as I say, "I think," I've got to be right about that because thinking, I think, is thinking.

6.32 If I say, "I think, I think," well, then I think. I'm thinking. That's a thinking. So I can't be wrong. If I say, "Oh, I don't know. I doubt whether I think." Doubting is thinking. So I'm good. I'm thinking. That has to be right. Now, again, even if we say, "What do you mean this I?" As long as I say there is thinking, as long as I say something exists, and I know those things for sure, then there is something the skeptic is undermined by. There is something I know, something I not only find reason to believe, I find no reason at all to reject.

6.33 So he says, "I think, I am." They're true every time they thought or uttered. That means they are things I can know. So the skeptic cannot be right. It is possible to have knowledge. Not only can I have knowledge, now I know some things that could belong in the foundation of knowledge. He starts out with a method of doubt.

6.34 He says, "I'm going to try to doubt everything I can doubt." Can I doubt that I'm actually speaking right now? Yes, I could be dreaming. Can I doubt that I am actually wearing a blue jacket? Yeah, I might be in a mental hospital in a straitjacket. Can I doubt that I'm a human being? Well, yeah, maybe I'm a butterfly dreaming I'm a human being. Can I doubt that I am? No. Why? Because doubting that I am—who's doubting? I must exist in order to even doubt something. Can I doubt whether I think? Doubting is thinking. So I cannot doubt those things.

6.35 So there we have some foundation for the rest of the knowledge. Not only do I know them, I couldn't be wrong about them. Anytime I think them, they have to be true. But now, is there anything else? Here's the trap. You might think he's painted himself into a corner. He said, I'm going to doubt everything. And now he says, the "I am," the "I think." I've got this little corner on which I can stand. But what if that's all?

6.36 He says, "I'm certain that I'm a thinking thing." I couldn't be wrong about that. But now, don't I know what's required to make me certain of something? Here, he gives us a fancy argument. It's about the possibility of something. It's known as a transcendental argument. It's about the possibility of things and the necessary conditions for the very possibility of something. So he says, "I am certain that I am. I am certain that I think. What would have to be true in order for it even to be possible for me to be certain?"

6.37 Well, something must be true. And moreover, that thing has to necessarily be true. It is a necessary condition for the very possibility of my knowing that I think and knowing that I am. So he says, here is what it is. "In this first knowledge"—that I think that I am—"there is nothing that assures me of its truth except the clear and distinct perception of what I state." In other words, it seems to me clearly and distinctly that I am, that I think, and that I couldn't be wrong about that.

6.38 He says, that's enough to guarantee the truth of these things, but "it seems to me now I can also establish a general rule." For me to be, for it even to be possible for me to

know with certainty that I think and that I am, it must be that "all things that I perceive very clearly and very distinctly are true."

- 6.39** He's generalizing in a way, but he says, I'm not just saying I know these two things, so on the basis of two instances, I suppose all. That would be a terrible argument. I know this, I know that. I happen to clearly and distinctly perceive them. So yay, I can know everything I clearly and distinctly perceive. That would seem like a terrible argument. And some people interpret him that way and think, Yeah, it's a terrible argument.
- 6.40** But here's what I think is going on. He's saying, somehow, it is possible for me to have certainty. Under what conditions could I possibly be certain about anything? The answer is, what makes me certain of those things? There's a clear and distinct perception. I try to imagine doubting them, and I find I'm led right back into affirming them. So think of that as a clear and distinct perception. I start to doubt, and I realize I can't even doubt it. Then, I can conclude that the method must be right. That must work for it even to be possible for me to have certainty here.
- 6.41** So that tells him he can necessarily trust what he clearly and distinctly perceives. That's going to get him out of that little corner he's painted himself into. You might worry about that argument, even if we say it's not some inductive argument, two cases to everything. It's this sophisticated argument about the necessary conditions for the possibility of certainty, which is what I think he's doing.
- 6.42** But now you might still worry: Can't I doubt the premises? Well, I can't doubt that I think, and I can't doubt that I am. But what about the fact that the path to that is a clear and distinct perception? Couldn't I doubt that? Now, it is interesting that in the Latin version here, he says "seems" instead of just "is." That's a hint that maybe he realizes, "You could doubt what I'm doing here." But still, he thinks he's got a necessary condition for the possibility of being certain about anything. That jump, at least, he's willing to make.
- 6.43** Now, notice this does lead him to a certain conception of what is essential to me. When I was talking about Aristotle, I distinguished essential from accidental properties. I said the essence is what a thing is of its very nature, the thing that is necessary to being it. Well, notice I've concluded that I exist and that I think, and I couldn't be wrong about those things. In other words, those things are necessary. For me to be at all, I have to be. That's trivial. But for me to be at all, I have to think—that's not trivial.
- 6.44** So he says, "What am I? A thing that thinks. What's a thing that thinks?" His conception of thinking is very broad. "It's a thing that doubts, understands, [conceives], affirms, denies, wills, refuses, that also imagines and feels." You'll notice there I've got "conceives" in brackets. The reason is that he publishes this work, the *Meditations*, in both Latin and French.
- 6.45** There are a few interesting differences: in the French version, he adds conceives; it's not there in the Latin. There are a few other interesting divergences, by the way, that

I'll note as we go along, but that's one of them. He adds that in. Imagining, but also just thinking of something, conceiving of something, is something that counts as thinking.

- 6.46** Here is what he concludes. "What am I? I'm a thing that thinks." Moreover, I'm essentially a thing that thinks. That's necessary to me. Now he makes a bit of a leap. He says, "I think I can know my own mind more securely than I can know anything else." Why? Because I can't doubt my own existence. I can doubt your existence. I can doubt your existence. I can doubt the existence of this clicker. I can even doubt, in some sense, the whole of this perceptible universe. I could imagine that I'm living in a simulation. But can I doubt my own existence or that I think? No.
- 6.47** So there is something about my mind that I can know with certainty in a way I can't know anything else with absolute certainty. I see clearly that there's nothing easier for me to know than my mind. Now, this leads him to some radical conclusions. If I'm essentially a thing that thinks, well, what about my body? Is my body something that is essentially a thing that thinks? His answer is no. It's easy for my body to stop thinking. I fall asleep, maybe, and I'm in deep sleep, I'm not thinking at all. My body isn't essentially a thing that thinks, but my mind is. So I am a thing that thinks, essentially. My body isn't. So I am not to be identified with my body.
- 6.48** That means my mind and my body are distinct things. This makes him a dualist. He thinks there are two fundamental kinds of things. There are physical bodies, and there are minds, and those are independent. Still, they're intermingled. He says, I feel hunger, I feel thirst, I feel pain. That tells me there's some relationship between my mind and my body. There is a union and apparent intermingling. So if I'm going to say they're distinct and possibly separate, I've got to explain how they actually communicate, how they're intermingled.
- 6.49** So he says, "I am lodged in my body as a pilot in a vessel"—here, that's what the French says. In Latin, it says "as a sailor in a ship." I find that a really interesting difference. What's the difference between being the pilot of a vessel and being a sailor in a ship? Well, imagine yourself on a boat or on an airplane. There's a difference between flying it and just being a passenger. That's the difference between being the pilot of the ship and being a sailor on the ship. It's an interesting difference.
- 6.50** But now, "I'm very closely united to it and intermingled with it, so I seem to compose one whole." So he says, I have a clear and distinct idea of myself as a thinking being and as an extended being. My thoughts don't seem to be in space in the way that my body is in space. But I've got a distinct idea of my body as an extended and unthinking thing, or at least potentially unthinking. It's not necessarily thinking.
- 6.51** So I'm entirely and absolutely distinct from my body, and I can exist without it. Consequently, my mind, my soul, can exist without my body. This is, he thinks, a very important conclusion. I've got a clear and distinct idea of my mind as being this thing, a

clear and distinct idea, actually, just a distinct idea of my body as being another thing, so they can't be the same. They've got to be distinct and separable.

- 6.52** Saul Kripke, a contemporary philosopher who just died recently, gives us a version of this: suppose I've got a pain and then a brain state, which might be a good example of a bodily correlate to that. Being in pain is essential to a state of pain, a mental state. But is being in pain essential to a certain state of my brain? He thinks the answer is no. So you can't identify the pain with a certain state of my brain.
- 6.53** However you think about that, I want to focus on Princess Elizabeth's criticisms. I've mentioned that she had a long correspondence with Descartes, and in her letters, she raises some problems. One is already, in a sense, admitted because he's saying they're distinct, but there is a union and apparent intermingling. And she says, wait a minute. I want to know more about the apparent intermingling. I'm a thing that thinks, but I also have a body. How does my mind relate to my body? How is this union and apparent intermingling possible?
- 6.54** Now, it goes in two ways. There is an effect of my body on my mind through sensation. I am aware of things. I see things, for example, it affects the state of my mind. Something might happen to my body, and I feel pain or feel pleasure. That affects my mind. But also, my mind can affect my body through what is known as mental causation. I can say, "I will now raise my hand," and my body obeys. Amazing. I mean, my children don't obey me, but my body obeys me. It looks like my mind can affect my body.
- 6.55** So how is that possible? If they're the same, I don't really have much to say. Sure, it's all just physical processes. But if they're distinct, I've got to give an account. So she says to Descartes, "I ask you to tell me how man's soul, being only a thinking substance, can determine animal spirits so as to cause voluntary actions." How is it possible for this mind, which is not really located in space, to actually have effects in space? It seems at first rather puzzling.
- 6.56** For one thing, the causes of bodily motions must be in space. They must contact the object to move it. If I say, "I'm going to move my hand," and I do it, well, something in space must have done that. But my mental acts aren't in space. They aren't extended in space. They're acts of a mind. So how does something outside of space affect something in space? She says, "I don't see how that's possible. You owe us an account of how that causation is even possible."
- 6.57** There's another problem she raises. It seems like physics is, at least, it pretends to be, complete. You want to know something about the motions of physical objects, about their causes and effects? Ultimately, science is what tells you that, natural science. Presumably, ultimately, physics tells you how various things move and how energy levels are set and so on. So physics already explains this.

- 6.58** Now she says, there's a problem of too many causes. You're saying something mental affects something physical. But actually, physics says it's a self-contained system. The physical moves in the way that it does on the basis of physical law due to physical causes. So you're going to say there's a physical cause, but also a mental cause that's in some way distinct. It seems like now we have too many causes.
- 6.59** So what's going on with the motion of my hand? You could say that there's this nervous impulse that proceeds from my brain. You give me a neurophysiological account of all that happening. Now, you say, "But it was your intention to do it. That also causes it." She says, now I've got not only the firing of certain neurons as the ultimate cause, but also an intention. You could identify the firing of the neurons with the intention. But then they seem to be different in these ways that you've just explained. You don't want to identify them. So now we have two things causing it. That's too many. We only need one thing causing it. The neurons are enough. You don't need this additional mental intention.
- 6.60** Descartes's answer, I've got to confess, is really disappointing. He just says, "We perceive the interaction of mind and body." It's known very clearly by the senses. I intend to raise my hand, and I do it. Yay me. But it seems like that utterly misses the point. She's not saying, "I don't think they interact." She's saying, of course, they interact. The question is how they do it.
- 6.61** This thing you're claiming is the cause—first of all, it seems superfluous because we already have an account of the causes. Secondly, it's outside of space and time. Well, at least it's outside of space. How is it affecting things in space? Descartes really has no answer.
- 6.62** At one point, later, he says that maybe there's a gland in the body where it happens. But that's like saying, it happens somehow in the brain. That would be our modern version of that. But I now want to know how. I mean, stuff's already happening in the brain. That's purely physical stuff. Where does this mental intention come in? It seems like saying that it does is no answer at all.
- 6.63** So Descartes leaves us in a position that, in a way, is very encouraging. He says, you might be worried about the skeptical arguments, and in fact, I'll take them, and I'll put them in an even more powerful form. Looks like we have reason to doubt absolutely everything. But then he says, not really. I can't doubt that I think. I can't doubt that I am. In fact, I end up concluding everything I clearly and distinctly perceive as true.
- 6.64** But now I end up also in the position of saying that minds are different from bodies. They're separable from bodies. They're quite distinct. But I can't really tell you how they connect, how they have this apparent intermingling. And so in the end, I've got to say that God somehow makes it all work out.
- 6.65** I'm not going to talk here about his arguments for God's existence, but to put it in a quick nutshell: "I've got this idea of God, didn't come from the world. It must have

come from God." That's the third meditation argument in a very cheap and reduced form. But then I've got to argue that God is good because God has all perfections, and all of that takes me pretty far away from the "I think, I am." Many people think that path doesn't quite work.

- 6.66** In any case, I want to turn now to a different version of rationalism, a version you find in Leibniz. Leibniz wasn't really a professional philosopher at all. He was a diplomat and also a very deep thinker in logic and mathematics, a co-inventor of the calculus with Isaac Newton. Leibniz, too, like Descartes, was a first-rate mathematician and also had this career as a diplomat on the side, as it were.
- 6.67** He gives us a version of rationalism that is maybe closer to things we want to think about today. Here's the distinction that I think he begins to draw very clearly for the first time between rationalism and empiricism, as I've been putting it between that Platonic tradition and the Aristotelian tradition. The empiricist stemming from Aristotle says, "All of our knowledge of the world comes from experience. We have no other source than experience."
- 6.68** The rationalist says, "I grant that most of our knowledge of the world comes from experience, but some of it is independent of experience. Some of it is inborn. It is innate." So there are certain things that our mind is just structured know. It might be part of our biological heritage. I could give an evolutionary account, maybe—we've evolved in such a way that certain things are simply built into the mind from the beginning. We don't have to learn it afresh from experience. But however you try to understand that, we're born with our mind having a certain structure that gives us some basic knowledge independently of experience, and that's true both at the level of concepts and at the level of judgments.
- 6.69** Avicenna was an Islamic philosopher who was also in the rationalist tradition, and he draws that distinction between the knowledge of concepts and the acquisition of concepts, and then the acquisition of knowledge and judgments of the world. He says that, really, the rationalists and the empiricists can disagree about both. There are two forms of rationalism, two forms of empiricism, but almost all rationalists advocate both forms. Almost all empiricists also advocate both forms of empiricism. They go together.
- 6.70** The empiricist says, "All my concepts come from experience, and all my knowledge comes from experience. After all, my knowledge is based on my concepts, but I'm getting all my ideas from experience. None of them are really built into the mind from the start." So my building blocks—this is Locke's idea—the building blocks of knowledge are all coming from experience, and then the ways in which I can put them together to get knowledge also come from experience.
- 6.71** The rationalist denies both of these. At the level of concepts, says some concepts don't come from experience. They are innate. Those are ideas that are simply built into the structure of the mind. And then judgment, too. There are things we can know about

the world that don't come from experience. They are, in philosophical terms, a priori. They are independent of experience. Prior to experience, not so much in the sense that they come first, but in the sense that they are independent. They could come first. That's rationalism as Leibniz understands it. There are innate ideas or concepts, and there is a priori knowledge of the world—knowledge of the world independently of experience.

- 6.72** What are these innate concepts? What do you think we're born knowing? And what do you think we're born having as our conceptual apparatus? Leibniz says, "Can it be denied that there's much that's innate in our mind since we are, so to speak, innate to ourselves, and since in ourselves, there are being, unity, substance, duration, change, activity, perception, pleasure, and a thousand other objects of our intellectual ideas?" In other words, he thinks all of these are built in. Being—notice, I can think, I am. That is something that doesn't, in his view, really depend on experience.
- 6.73** Avicenna, in fact, has this thought of the flying man. He has a thought experiment. Imagine somebody who is born and immediately has all their sense organs plugged up or is in a sensory deprivation tank. He imagines this person just flying through the air, incapable of learning anything from experience. Could that person nevertheless be aware that they exist? And his answer is yes. They could think "I am" even without any experience of the world.
- 6.74** So Leibniz here is saying things like existence or being, things like unity, in other words, the concept of an object, substance, and unification of something, the idea of dividing the world up into things, he says that's just built into the structure of our minds.
- 6.75** Here, there are two views. You watch a child, and at first, they don't really seem to divide up the world into distinct objects, but at a certain point, they do. Then they start seeing causal relations and recognizing the continuity of objects. And by the time they're nine months old, let's say, they've got all of that. The empiricist says that they're learning all that from experience. If they were in a situation where there were nothing but swirling colors and no objects of any distinct kind, they wouldn't come to those ideas.
- 6.76** But the rationalist says, no, no, no. They're built into the structure of the mind. It may be that the mind has to develop and has to acquire a certain amount of experience for these structures to become fully there and to become triggered and relevant. But nevertheless, those structures are part of the structure of the brain. We divide the world up into objects.
- 6.77** Even if you imagine an experience of swirling colors, we're going to start thinking of the swirls as things, the idea of dividing the world into objects, substances, and thinking of them as unified in some way and as existing and as enduring through time, and then one enduring object changing or doing things or having things done to them. Notice the

Aristotelian category is in the background here. He's saying all of that is built into the structure of the mind.

- 6.78** There are modern rationalists who have a very similar view. Noam Chomsky, for example, in his approach to linguistics, is thoroughly rationalist. He says that there is a universal grammar and these basic structures of subject and predicate, substance and quality and relation and so on—basically, the Aristotelian categories are built into the structure of the mind, the innate grammar that we all have. Then, when we learn language, we're figuring out how that grammar gets expressed in English or French or Spanish or Swahili or some other language. But the basic grammar is already there in the mind at birth.
- 6.79** Leibniz is giving us a view something like that. Those basic categories, he says, are just part of the structure of the mind. They are built in, and yes, they might take time to develop, maybe only at nine months does the child fully have these, but they're not being all derived from experience. The child is taking experience and actually using these to organize it, and the ability to do that is already there.
- 6.80** Here is how he frames the issue between himself and Locke. This is from his *New Essays Concerning Human Understanding*, which is a response to Locke's empiricist essay, *Concerning Human Understanding*. He says, "There's a question whether the soul in itself is entirely empty, like a writing tablet on which nothing has been written, a *tabula rasa*, which is the opinion of Aristotle and the author of the *Essay*,"—namely John Locke—"and whether everything that's inscribed upon it comes solely from the senses and experience,"—that's the empiricist position—"or whether the soul originally contains the principles of several notions and doctrines, which are merely roused on certain occasions by external objects, as I hold, along with Plato and even with the Schoolmen."
- 6.81** The schoolmen, in other words, medieval philosophers, Aquinas is clearly in the Aristotelian empiricist tradition, but most of the other medieval philosophers are on Leibniz's side, certainly, Anselm is, Bonaventure is, a variety of others. Leibniz is saying here that the mind can either be viewed as this blank slate, this purely white sheet of paper on which experience writes, and everything written on it is coming from experience, or you can see it as something that has a built-in structure, and then it organizes experience according to that structure.
- 6.82** So either you've got this blank sheet of paper, nothing on it, nothing yet organized, or you've got something like marble, where there is already a structure there, and the sculptor approaching the marble has to recognize the structure of the marble and has to carve it in the right way. That already organizes, you might think, what then the sculptor can produce out of that block of marble.
- 6.83** Leibniz thinks the brain, the mind, is more like marble than it is like a blank sheet of paper. It's already got a structure. So he says, now we can move from that idea about

concepts, notions, ideas, to the question of whether all truths are dependent on experience, on induction and instances, or whether there's some that have yet another foundation, a foundation independent of experience, where, again, knowledge of these truths is simply built into the structure of the mind itself.

- 6.84** Here is one way of framing the issue. Philosophers have distinguished analytic from synthetic judgments. Kant is maybe the first person to do that explicitly, but the idea is already there in several earlier philosophers. The idea is that an analytic judgment is true just by virtue of the meanings of its terms. An example from Locke: "a soul is a soul." You don't have to know what a soul is to know that's a true sentence. It's just logically true. Or if I say, "Bachelors are unmarried," it's true by virtue of the meanings of the terms.
- 6.85** A synthetic statement actually says something about the world. It is not true just by virtue of the meanings of the terms. If I say, "The floor on which I'm standing is white," that's something that actually is about the world. It's not just that I can think "this floor, white"—think about the meanings of the terms and conclude just from that, independently of experience, that it is true.
- 6.86** A posteriori judgments come from experience; they depend on experience. A priori ones don't. Can we have analytic and a priori judgments, like bachelors are unmarried or a soul is a soul? Sure. Can we have a posteriori and synthetic judgments, ones that say something about the world and depend on experience, like the floor is white? Yes.
- 6.87** The question is: Can we have things that are really about the world, not just verbal truths, but really about the world, so synthetic truths, that are also a priori, independent of experience? Those would be synthetic a priori. That's exactly where the rationalists and the empiricists disagree.
- 6.88** By the way, nobody thinks there can be analytic a posteriori judgments. After all, if the meanings of the terms establish it, like bachelors are unmarried, who needs experience? I don't need to survey bachelors to find out. It's already true by virtue of the meanings of the terms. So the empiricist says, no, there are no a priori synthetic truths. Everything is either purely a verbal truth or it's really a truth about the world, dependent on experience. But the rationalist says that no, there is this third category. There are things we can know truly about the world that are independent of experience.
- 6.89** Leibniz puts it this way. He says, "If some events can be foreseen before we've made any trial of them, it's manifest we contribute something of our own. The senses, though necessary for all our actual acquiring of knowledge, are by no means sufficient to give us the whole of our knowledge. The senses never give us anything but instances, particular or individual truths. We've got to be adding something of our own."
- 6.90** Here's the idea: we infer general truths from particular cases. I say, "Wow, lightning, thunder, lightning, thunder, lightning, thunder." I think that lightning and thunder

always go together. Or I notice this cat makes this sound, meow, and this cat makes that sound, meow. And then I start concluding that all cats meow. Somehow, I go from these particular instances to a universal claim. What enables me to do that?

- 6.91** He says the argument from those particular cases is not valid. No matter how many cats I examine, no matter how many storms I see, I've just looked at finitely many particular cases. Nothing there allows me to conclude that this is always true. But nevertheless, I do, and I seem to have real knowledge of the world in doing that. What makes that possible?
- 6.92** Something's got to be added other than the experience because the experience is just going to add more of those particular cases. I think this cat meows, that cat meows, that cat meows— is there anything that will allow me to conclude that all cats meow? No matter how many I survey, I'm never going to get to all. He says that tells us one thing that's very important: we're adding something.
- 6.93** Now, let's turn to a different sphere. Think about logic. I think, "Aha, here's a valid form of argument: If P, then Q. P. Therefore, Q. Modus ponens." Do I gain that from experience? No, I must use that in organizing the data of experience. What about metaphysics? I think the world consists of substances, objects, that they have properties and stand in relations. Have I learned that from experience? No, that's something I'm deriving from the structure of my mind. That's how I think about experience. It's not like I have to then survey more things and I find, "Oh, over here, there's this bowl of oatmeal, and it's really mushy now. I don't know. Where are the objects?" It's not like that. My mind is organizing things into objects of this kind. That's happening independently.
- 6.94** What about ethics? Do I learn that, for example, murder is wrong on the basis of experience? Well, the empiricist would say yes, but Leibniz is going to say, no, this idea of wrongness, I don't get that from experience. That's something I bring to experience. Yes, I may learn that these things have really bad effects and so on, but what enables me to supply this is not something I find in the experience itself. It's something I am contributing, my mind is contributing.
- 6.95** Anyway, you don't have to accept all of these arguments, all of these points. But he's saying that even if I'm looking at experience, it's always particular. I never get to the universal. I'm adding something. Then, in math, it's not even clear where the experiences would be. Or, in a basic metaphysical claim, there are substances that stand in relations. Where's the experience? Or in "this is wrong, that's wrong, that's unjust," where's the relevant experience?
- 6.96** So he's saying, "All the instances that confirm a general truth, however numerous, aren't sufficient to establish the universal necessity of the truth." Here, he's adding necessity. He says it doesn't follow that what's happened will happen in the same way. So maybe all the cats I've seen meow. Maybe there are cats I haven't met that don't.

- 6.97** Indeed, in the history of science, sometimes things like this have happened. All the swans we've observed have been white, and then in the middle of Australia, we find black swans. So it could be that all the ones we've seen are not indicative of the entire class and that we're making a mistake in saying all on the basis of those.
- 6.98** Notice here, he talks about the universal necessity. It's not just going from the particular instances to this universal claim: all. It's also going from contingent things to universal things and necessary things. He says, I look at this cat, it meows. This cat, it meows. Well, all of those are contingent things. Nothing made it necessary that that cat meow or even that that cat existed. But now I want to say, no, there's some really law-like relationship between cats and meowing or between lightning and thunder.
- 6.99** Where do I get this idea of necessity? I'm seeing contingent and particular things. I'm concluding something that is law-like and necessary, and also universal. Where's the necessity coming from? Where's the universality coming from? It's not coming from experience. Something is in between.
- 6.100** Somehow, I go from particular facts to a universal conclusion. Somehow, I go from contingent facts to a law-like, necessary conclusion or one about causation. I say lightning causes thunder, and that implies there's some necessary connection between them. But none of that follows from the mere instances. My mind has to be supplying the necessity. It has to be supplying the connections. It has to be the universality. The idea of things being organized in regular patterns according to the laws, that's not coming from experience. That's coming from me. That's got to be innate. That's the idea.
- 6.101** There is an ambiguity here. What is the necessity? If I'm talking about causation, lightning causing thunder, does the necessity attach to the conclusion? Like, okay, I've seen lightning, there must be thunder. Or is it the connection? Surely it's the connection. Last night, in fact, I saw lots of lightning that wasn't accompanied by thunder, at least here, because it was too far away. Presumably, there was thunder somewhere, so I could investigate that. But we might say, really, it's something about the connection, presumably, that is being supplied here, where the necessity attaches. I want to say there is a necessity.
- 6.102** One way of thinking about this is to imagine dropping something—this is fragile and valuable, so I don't want to drop it. But the idea is, if I were to let this go, what's going to happen? You've seen people drop things before. They fall, right? So you'd say, "It's going to fall." How do you know? Have you seen clickers fall? Probably not. I've seen other things fall. So how do you know it applies to clickers?
- 6.103** You've just seen particular cases, and now you're going to include, "Oh, there's some causal link. There's something like gravity, and when you let this go, it's going to fall." Well, you're right, it is going to, and you're right to think there's some necessity to it. It's not just that it will fall; it's got to fall. There's some necessity to that. But the

necessity isn't coming from the experience. There's just been a bunch of stuff we've seen. No necessity comes from that.

- 6.104** If I see a bunch of cars drive by one evening, and I tabulate them—once, my daughters and I did this just for a little lesson in statistics: How many of the things driving by are passenger cars? How many are SUVs? How many are pickup trucks? How many are other kinds of trucks? We tabulated all this. Does that mean tomorrow it's going to be the same mix? No, of course not.
- 6.105** So there is something about a certain experience that allows us to attribute some necessity to it. Think it's law-like. What is that coming from? It's not just coming from the experience. It's coming from something else that we use in organizing our experiences.
- 6.106** Leibniz says that the universal and necessary premises that are missing here somehow have to come from somewhere. They're not coming from experience. They must be innate. They must be a priori. They've got to be synthetic because, after all, they're allowing us to draw conclusions about the world. It's not just a verbal truth that events in the world happen due to certain causes, that causal relations exist between the events in the world.
- 6.107** In fact, it seems like something that doesn't really have to be true in a broader sense. We see lots of things in the world that seem to be random. And so the idea that the world is more than random, that it's law-like, that's something that is being contributed by us. It's not necessarily there, in our experiences. It is not something that is just a verbal truth, like events always have causes. That's not verbal. That's a real claim about the world.
- 6.108** Now, if there are these synthetic a priori truths, what on earth are they? You might think, okay, great. You've convinced me that we're contributing something of our own, but what? The rationalist is going to tell you something. For example, Avicenna says, "Here are some examples I'll give you: the whole is greater than its parts," or "things equal to the same thing are equal to each other."
- 6.109** I remember in my high school geometry class, a girl in the class who could not understand that. She kept saying, "Why? Why?" The coach, who was our geometry teacher, would be getting very red-faced because he was like, "Look, A is equal to B. Is that right? B is equal to C. Therefore, A is equal to C." "But Why?" "Things equal to the same thing are equal to each other." "Why?" Leibniz would say that, actually, it's a really good question. Why? I can't point to experiences that convince me of this. Instead, I've got to say that this is just part of the basic structure of the brain.
- 6.110** The empiricist will say, "I beg to differ. I think it's a definition of equality, and it's the meaning of equality that tells me this." An empiricist is going to say, "I've got another explanation for all of these." But in any case, Leibniz would say that Janie, who was

raising these questions in that class, was raising a good question: Where is that coming from?

- 6.111** The answer is it's not coming from experience, and in his view, it's not just coming from the meanings of the terms. It is something that is this synthetic a priori judgment. It's a deep axiom, as it were, that we know intuitively, and she was having trouble recovering that bit of knowledge. What the coach was saying was not triggering that and activating it for her. But he would say, it's nevertheless a really good question. Where is it coming from? It's got to be somewhere else. That's what my theory means to say.
- 6.112** In Descartes, well, it's certain things like the "I think" and the "I am." Also, anyone who thinks has to exist while thinking. Nothing's made from nothing. He thinks that's an important synthetic a priori truth. It's impossible for anything to be and not be at the same time. What's been done can't be undone. You can't change the past—I think that's an especially interesting one.
- 6.113** Leibniz has the principle of sufficient reason, which says there can be no fact without a sufficient reason why it's so and not otherwise. One form of that is that every event has a cause, but this is deeper. He's saying everything has an explanation. Everything has some reason why it's that way and not some other way.
- 6.114** In Immanuel Kant, who was also a rationalist, every event has a cause; this is his version of this. He thinks the truths of arithmetic are synthetic and a priori in this way. His example is $7 + 5 = 12$. And by the way, earlier in Augustine, his example is $7 + 3 = 10$. So I don't know if Kant is explicitly thinking of that one or whether he's coming close to it by accident. But why would you think that the truth of arithmetic is something that is actually synthetic and really true about the world, not just a verbal truth, and also, is independent of experience, is a priori?
- 6.115** Well, what are you thinking? Kant explains it this way. You are imagining seven things—sadly, I don't have seven fingers on my hand to illustrate—but you're thinking of seven things and then adding five, and then you put them together to get 12. That idea you can put them together, he says, is not just a verbal truth.
- 6.116** I think in set theory, he would put it this way: the union of any two sets is a set. I can take this group of seven things, this group of five things, and I can put them together to get a larger group. That is not just a verbal truth. It's not just by the meaning of union or set that we know that the union of any two sets is a set. That's something that is another assumption: a basic axiom of set theory, maybe.
- 6.117** But it's also something that makes us say, wait a minute, that idea of unifying two things into one is a claim about the world; it's not merely verbal. On the other hand, we don't go around taking groups of things and putting them together to do research. If I said, "I'm going to apply to the National Science Foundation to do research on whether you can actually combine groups in this way," they would laugh at me. It would be

ridiculous, right? So We're saying that's synthetic, but it's also a priori. It doesn't depend on experience.

- 6.118 Geometry—between any two points lies one and only one line. Well, that seems to be true, but it's not a verbal truth. It also doesn't seem to be derived from experience. What enables us to say that? It is something that is synthetic and a priori.
- 6.119 In medieval philosophy, there are all sorts of other candidates: "God exists." Or, "The soul is immortal." Or, "The world consists of substances and their attributes," something that is really implicit in Leibniz and would be part of Chomsky's universal grammar. "The will is free." "Every substance has an essence." Or, "You ought to seek the good. You ought to avoid evil. Happiness is intrinsically good. Courage is a virtue." All of these would be potential candidates for being this synthetic and a priori truth.
- 6.120 The upshot of all of this is that the rationalist is looking at our experience of the world and saying, "I don't see how we get from that experience of the world, which is always particular, always contingent, to saying anything that is universal, that is necessary, that is law-like, that involves causation." It's in its purest form, maybe in mathematics, where you think, I don't even see how experience is relevant to this, and yet we claim to have a lot of mathematical knowledge. We're right to think we do have that. The skeptic is wrong.
- 6.121 On the other hand, what makes it possible for us to have that knowledge where we're adding something independently of experience? It must be because our minds have certain innate concepts and are able to put them together to have certain innate bits of knowledge. Next time, we'll look at the empiricist alternative.

Lecture 7: On Empiricism

At a glance — On empiricism.

- 7.1 I've said that there are two great traditions in Western philosophy. One of them, really a series of footnotes to Plato, and the other, a series of footnotes to Aristotle. We've already looked at the tradition that stems from Plato, the rationalist tradition that extends through Descartes, Leibniz, and a variety of other figures. Today, I want to talk about the footnotes to Aristotle, this other grand tradition, which is an empiricist tradition.
- 7.2 Last time, we already talked some about what empiricism is, but here I want to look at the two really most important figures, at least since the medieval period, of that empiricist tradition, the followers of Aristotle. That's John Locke and David Hume, both of them writing in English, so they're more accessible in a way than the people who are writing in Latin or French or other languages.
- 7.3 But from another point of view, their thought is, well, while utterly commonsensical, also tricky in ways that are not evident on the surface. We're going to have to think carefully about why Locke and Hume, for example, end up in different places despite the fact that they start out in the same way. The fact that they write in English and the fact that they write in common-sense terms can actually mislead us and make us think that this is very simple.
- 7.4 Indeed, as a student, I thought, this is simple, these guys are getting everything right. I was thoroughly convinced. Now I see that it's a little more complicated than the language suggests. They can lure you in with the seeming simplicity. That's not to say I now think they're wrong. I think these arguments are very serious arguments, but we have to watch them carefully.
- 7.5 John Locke is a 17th-century philosopher. He was, by trade, a medical doctor who attached himself to the Earl of Shaftesbury. He was the private physician of the Earl, which gave him a lot of time to get involved in politics, among other things, but also to write a series of works. Our own Declaration of Independence and Constitution is based on his work in political philosophy, but today I'm going to be focusing on his thinking about the philosophy of mind and more broadly about his philosophical approach.
- 7.6 We've said empiricism is the idea that, first of all, all of our ideas, all of our concepts come from experience. Secondly, that all of our knowledge of the world comes from experience. There is some knowledge that is purely analytic, as the empiricists tend to have it, or is a trifling proposition in Locke's terminology.
- 7.7 The idea is certain things like "a soul is a soul," or logical propositions, or "bachelors are unmarried"—those are just verbal truths. If you understand the language, you know that they're true. But if we're talking about truth about the world, all of that comes

from experience. If all of the building blocks come from experience, we can't really have knowledge of the world built out of them independently of experience. That, too, has to come from experience.

- 7.8** Locke puts it this way, and here we have to be careful because he says that most of our experience is experience of the world outside of us, but we also have internal experiences through reflection. I am aware of my own states of mind. So yes, I can perceive the world: I can hear things, I can taste things, I can see things. But I also can reflect, and I'm aware of my own mental states. That means there are two sources, really. There is sensation of the outside world, but then also reflection, this awareness of my own mental states.
- 7.9** So he says, "Let's suppose the mind to be white paper, void of all characters, without any ideas. How comes it to be furnished? Whence comes it by that vast store, which the busy and boundless fancy of man has painted on it with an almost endless variety? Whence has it all the materials of reason and knowledge?" In other words, we seem to know a lot about the world, but where are we getting all of this? It seems as if all we have is sensation, perception of the world around us, and then the awareness of our own mental states.
- 7.10** Is that enough? He says, yes, it is enough. "I can answer the question with one word: experience." In that all our knowledge is founded, and from that it ultimately derives itself. The only source I have is experience, perception of the outside world, but then also reflection, awareness of my own mental states.
- 7.11** Now, you can also recognize that the thought that I have not only an awareness of the outside world, but an awareness of my own mental states, is going to enable him to respond to certain arguments that the rationalists give. For example, what about the "I think, I am" of Descartes? Well, that's reflection. Descartes is reflecting on his own mental states.
- 7.12** Avicenna's flying man, having no perception of the outside world, he's still got experience. He's got experience of his own mind. And so Avicenna is right that the flying person in a sensory deprivation situation could be aware that he exists. However, it's because he has this internal experience. He's not experiencing the outside world, but he's experiencing the inside world.
- 7.13** We do have these two kinds of experience. Perception: vision, hearing, smell, taste, touch, and it's now argued that there are some other senses as well. If that's true, like an awareness of motion and so on, then fine. We have that awareness of the world. But we also have reflection: the notice the mind takes of its own operations. I can be aware of my own mental states. I know when I am seeing things. I know my own thoughts. I know when I'm afraid. I know my own feelings, in other words. All of those are internal kinds of perception.

- 7.14** Now, what is an idea? Descartes, I've said, pioneered this new way of ideas, and Locke goes along with that completely. But what is an idea? It's a term that's a little bit slippery. Here is what he says about it, the objects of understanding. He says that an idea is "whatsoever is the object of understanding when you think." It's "whatsoever it is the mind can be employed about in thinking." It's "that which his mind is applied about while thinking." One way of putting this is that these are first-order cognitive abilities.
- 7.15** What do I mean by that? It's a cognitive ability. That is to say, if I have an idea of a cat, then I have the ability to recognize cats, for example, maybe identify when this cat is the same cat, again. I've got a certain set of abilities that go along with having that idea of a cat. But it's first order, that is to say, it's not an idea about an idea; it's an idea about a cat. So these first-order abilities are abilities to recognize things in the world and maybe internally, to recognize things about my own mental states, to recognize fear, to recognize something I see as opposed to something I taste or something I hear. Those are first-order abilities.
- 7.16** The reason I want to stress that first-order part—and I think it's important—is that Locke and other empiricists do not deny that there are higher-order abilities, that the mind does come equipped with the ability, for example, to combine ideas or separate ideas or perform logical functions. We'll come to that more in a moment, but think of this as an ability to recognize and identify things in the world or things in my own mind, things that are my own mental states.
- 7.17** Well, I generally refer to these as concepts rather than ideas because I think it's clearly tied to abilities, maybe in a way that idea isn't. Idea suggests an image to a lot of people, and that's really not an accurate way. It's tied to abilities, not to little mental pictures.
- 7.18** But here's the idea: all of our concepts come from experience; none of them are innate, none of them are inborn, at least these first-order ones. What that means is that my mind comes something like a blank sheet of paper, a blank slate. On the other hand, paper does have certain characteristics, and it can, for example, receive writing, or at least most paper can. Take a page out of a magazine—it's slippery, and if you try to write on it with a pencil, it won't work. That's a good example of a higher-order ability that something might have. The mind has the ability to absorb information from its surroundings. It has the ability to reflect on itself.
- 7.19** Anything that is innate in a mind is like that. It's this higher-order thing, the ability to manipulate these other abilities, the ability to actually do things with the raw material of experience. For example, we can abstract ideas, we can combine ideas, we can negate them, and we can perform other kinds of logical operations—I'll say a little bit more about that in a minute, and how we build bigger ideas out of the ideas that we receive from experience.

- 7.20** But here is how Locke expresses it. "Men, barely by the use of their natural faculties, may attain to all the knowledge they have without the help of any innate impressions. All ideas come from sensation or reflection." Hume says the same thing. He says, "All our ideas are nothing but copies of our impressions,"—those are the basic units of sensation or reflection—"or in other words, it's impossible for us to think of anything that we haven't antecedently felt either by our external or internal senses." Hume talks about external senses and internal senses. For Locke, it's sensation and reflection, but it's the same distinction.
- 7.21** Let's move on to judgment empiricism. The idea is that all of our knowledge of the world comes from experience. There are no synthetic a priori truths, no truths that are synthetic in the sense that they're really about the world, they're not just verbal, but are also a priori, independent of experience.
- 7.22** Last time, I defined things this way in terms of this little chart. The empiricist says, "Yes, we have some knowledge that is analytic a priori." That is to say, I know it independently of experience. It's just verbal truth. "A soul is a soul," or "bachelors are unmarried," or the empiricist typically says "mathematics: $1 + 1 = 2$," that is something that is analytic and a priori, according to the judgment empiricist.
- 7.23** Then, there are all sorts of things. The vast majority of our knowledge is synthetic and a posteriori. It is really about the world, but it's something that comes from experience. "The floor is white," that's something I learn from experience. I can't deduce that independently. If I think—what? Istanbul—actually, that's not true. Istanbul is not the capital of Turkey. Okay, that's a good example. It's an example of a synthetic proposition. It's about the world, but in that case, it's false. We know that it's false on the basis of experience. It should be Ankara, not Istanbul.
- 7.24** But that's the idea: we get that from experience; we have to learn that from the world. If I simply say: Which of those is the capital of Turkey? And I'm basing that on just verbal things, I can't know that. But now the empiricist says, rationalists, you think you're so smart. Figure it out without experience. Obviously, you can't. So we're going to have to examine the things that the rationalist takes to be inborn in us because the empiricist is going to say that there's no such thing. They have to fit into one of those two boxes. Either they're things like "bachelors are unmarried," in which case they are analytic and a priori, or they're synthetic and a posteriori.
- 7.25** Hume puts it this way. He doesn't use that language of analytic-synthetic and a priori-a posteriori, but he distinguishes matters of fact and relations of ideas. I think in a way, it's the same distinction. He's saying a matter of fact is dependent on experience. In other words, it's a posteriori. It's dependent on experience. There are lots of things like that that are dependent on experience; they are synthetic. They're not just verbal truths.

- 7.26** But then there are things that he describes as relations of ideas. That's his language for the things that are analytic and a priori. That is to say, they can be known by a mere operation of thought, and in the end, they turn out to be just verbal truths. Locke describes those as trifling propositions, and he thinks of them as trivial. But once you get to the point of thinking that it includes all of mathematics, it no longer feels as trifling, which is part of the reason that, after Locke, people say, "Let's not call them trifling. Let's call them relations of ideas or analytic propositions" or something like that.
- 7.27** Now, what's wrong with these synthetic a priori judgments, the kind of thing that Plato or Leibniz or Descartes would have thought has to be introduced to explain how we get knowledge of the world. Here's the problem. Locke says synthetic a priori judgments would have to contain certain concepts. After all, judgments are about propositions. Propositions are made up of concepts or ideas.
- 7.28** But if we don't have any concepts independently of experience, we can't have any knowledge independently of experience. So he says that concept empiricism actually implies judgment empiricism. If you don't have any building blocks, you can't build anything. You have no ideas, then you can't have any knowledge because knowledge would have to involve ideas. Hume has this distinction I've already alluded to between impressions and ideas. It's more explicit in Hume than it is in Locke. Let me say a little bit about that.
- 7.29** His idea is that I have sensations, awarenesses of the outside world that are raw. Later philosophers refer to these as sense data. They are things that are sensations. They're purely perceptual. They're independent of ideas. I just have the way the world appears to me at a certain time. Now, already that's complicated because I'm seeing things, I'm hearing things, I may be smelling things, feeling things. All of those are happening at the same time. But somehow I take that array of sensations and construct this perception of the world. I've got simple sensations here, simple impressions, Hume calls them, but they fit together to form a complex impression, a complex perception of things.
- 7.30** These are things, these impressions that are received from the senses, either external senses like vision and hearing and so on, or from the internal sense, what Locke calls reflection. So awareness is of my own mental states. And what are ideas? He says, Ideas are just copies of these things. So I have an awareness of something that is gray for example, and then I am able to abstract the idea of gray from this. The idea of the clicker, let's say, is just a copy of the impression that I have. The idea of gray is just a copy of the impression of gray that I have.
- 7.31** Now, there are, as I mentioned, simple and complex impressions. Correspondingly, there are simple and complex ideas. Here, I get into one of the trickier questions in Hume because he thinks, Okay, I've got this perception of the world. I am seeing things right now. I'm looking at people, I'm looking at cameras, I'm looking at screens. I'm

seeing all sorts of things around me. So I've got this highly complicated impression or perception of my surroundings.

- 7.32** Does it consist of simple parts? Hume's answer is yes. There are certain components. We might imagine this on a computer screen, let's say, and examine it pixel by pixel to see what's going on. Or we might think of the various cells in the retina, the rods, the cones, and so on, and think about each one of those as giving us a simple impression of what's taking place in vision, for example. So he thinks all of those can be broken down into these simple components.
- 7.33** That turns out to be very important in his view. Why? Because these complex ideas and complex impressions are compounds of other ideas and impressions. But the simple ideas and the simple impressions are not. They are the units out of which everything else is built.
- 7.34** So we have two rather bold claims here. One is that we can break our perceptions down into these simple components and see it as a combination of the simples, but then also say that the ideas corresponding to things can similarly be broken down into these simple units that are the copies of simple impressions.
- 7.35** So we've got this structure of complex things built out of simple things at the level of sensation. Then corresponding to that, more or less one to one, is this idea of ideas, also complex, breaking down into simple ideas that relate directly to those simple impressions. This gives us a method. If we want to know what somebody's talking about and really understand an idea or understand a claim, understand a theory, we figure out what impressions it traces to.
- 7.36** So Locke has that method, and Hume picks up the same method. The thought is we trace the origins of our ideas. You have an idea, let's figure out where it comes from. It's probably a complex idea, so we can say, "It's complicated. Let's break it down into its simple components and then see what impressions those components correspond to." We trace knowledge to the ideas that it's made up of, trace those ideas to their simple parts, and then relate the simple parts to impressions. In that way, we can understand things.
- 7.37** Sometimes we'll find that there's this very nice tracking. We break things down into the simples. The simples correspond to these simple impressions. There they are in the world. That justifies what we said. And so, yay, we've got knowledge.
- 7.38** But sometimes it's not going to correspond quite so easily. Locke says that now we're in the realm of faith or opinion, belief, but not really knowledge. Hume is going to say something much more radical, because if we can't trace it back to these simple impressions, Hume is going to say that it's utter nonsense. Locke will say that you don't really have knowledge. Maybe that's faith, maybe that's opinion, it's belief, but it's not knowledge.

- 7.39 Hume will say that it's garbage. Get rid of it. That's a difference. It's the same method, but as it were a different conclusion. If Hume says that you can't trace it back to any impressions, then what's the content? It's not even that what you're saying is false. It's more likely that what you're saying is utter nonsense. It doesn't correspond to anything.
- 7.40 Here, in general, is the empiricist method. We analyze complex ideas into the simple ideas of which they're made up. We find the origins of these simple ideas in experience—that's going to be simple sensations or reflection, simple impressions. Then we say, what is the content of the idea? Well, it lies in the simple impressions from which it comes. We not only have this tracking method to say we get back to the impressions, but then we say that's the content, that's the real content of the idea.
- 7.41 Here's a picture of how we might do that. We get a vision of something that is complex. In this case, it's nine different squares of different colors, and it's not that hard to think, we've got different colors here, so we can divide it into those nine squares. Actually, we have the idea of a square, so we're going to have to talk about the origin of the idea of the square as well as of the colors.
- 7.42 But then we trace each of those back to some origin. We can abstract particular colors out of this. We can do it one by one. Here's one of those higher-order abilities that the mind has. I can look at complexes, whether of ideas or of impressions, and start splitting them up into their simple components. So I can abstract things.
- 7.43 I can go into an animal shelter, for example, or into my house and see a bunch of cats. When I do that, I think, "They're different in various ways, but I can abstract the idea of a cat." Or I go into a furniture store, I see a lot of tables. I can abstract the idea of a table. That itself is not simple, but then I can say, "Flat surface, legs"—that's a bit simpler. And then, I can start tracking those back and breaking them down into their simple parts. What I'm doing throughout all of that is I'm abstracting certain components from this complex.
- 7.44 Here's an example. We have a bunch of clowns. They are dressed differently, but nevertheless, we can recognize them all as clowns. We can abstract something from the appearance of all of those strange beings and say they have something in common. The Platonist will say that yes, they have being a clown in common. They have this abstract form. But the empiricist says, that no, no no, they have funny noses and funny hair and funny lips, and so on, and start breaking it down into the simple components.
- 7.45 We can also combine things. We can take different shapes and put them together. The idea of combining ideas is something that is built into the mind itself. We don't have to learn that from experience. That is one of those higher-order things the mind is equipped for.
- 7.46 Now, it's not an idea that applies directly to the world, but it is an idea about ideas or about impressions. It's a way of having an ability to do things with our other abilities,

combining them to form complexes. So I can have the idea of a golden mountain. I don't experience a mountain made of gold, but I can think gold plus mountain, and I can put them together in a way that makes sense. I can envision that and have an idea of it.

- 7.47** The idea does have content. I can say that it's a combination of gold and mountain. Then I can trace those back to the impressions that constitute them ultimately and constitute their content. I can say that that is an idea that actually does have content. So Hume is not going to say, "That's just nonsense." He's going to say, "I understand exactly what you mean. There's no such thing, but I can understand what you mean well enough to actually verify and experience there is no such thing."
- 7.48** That's the same thing with a unicorn. I can say, "Imagine a horse with this one horn sticking out of its head." I can take the idea of a horn and the idea of a horse, put them together to form the idea of a unicorn. It's not hard to do that combination. It's entirely meaningful. I can say that I understand horse, I understand horn, I understand what it is for something to be poking out of somebody's head. I can do all of that and it has content, but then I look for that content in the world and I don't find it.
- 7.49** Similarly, with a flying car or all sorts of other things, I can take ideas—indeed, in a sense, this is what any inventor does. They take ideas, put them together in new ways, and then create an object corresponding to it. They say, "Nothing like this really exists in the world, but I'll make it exist. I will form it." That's how a lot of innovation happens.
- 7.50** I can negate ideas. I can say that I understand what clowns are, for example. So what about people who aren't clowns? I can think that's a clown. So I'm looking for somebody who is not a clown in this context. I can put in a negation. Here, what I've done is go to complementary colors. That's not really exactly negation. But nevertheless, I can say, "I want something that is not blue. I want something that is not red. I want something that's not brown, not yellow," and so on. I know what it would mean to be yellow, so I know what it means not to be yellow. I know what it is to be a cat, so I know what it is not to be a cat.
- 7.51** In general, that ability to negate is something that's built into the mind, too. It's not something that applies directly to the world. If I say, "Not—are there any nots around here?" I mean, N-O-T, nots. Well, no, it's not something that's first order. It doesn't apply to the world. It applies to our ideas. It's an ability to do something with another idea.
- 7.52** I can actually extend things like this to infinity. Even that is something that is a mental operation. I can think, "What if you just kept going?" Indeed, that's part of the empiricist account of arithmetic, for example. I can say 1, 2, 3, 4, and I can recognize I could just keep going, and I could extend that infinitely, so I can have as many numbers as I want. That thought that I can do that in an unlimited way is part of how I recognize that I've got an ability to do things. In this case, I can't complete the task. I can't say

that I will now count all the numbers for you—it would be a very long video; I can't do that—but I can, and I could just keep going.

- 7.53** I can do other logical functions. I can disjoin something. I can say, "What about something like that or something like that?" Some ideas we build disjunctively out of that. We say, "We're looking for this or that." It can be hard to think of intuitive examples like this, but there are examples. Jade, for example, is something that is recognizable and tends to look the same. But actually, there are two kinds of jade that have very different chemical compositions. They just happen to look alike. You could say what jade is. It's really this or this. It's two different kinds of things we call jade.
- 7.54** Something similar applies to certain family terms like uncle. What's an uncle? Well, it could be the brother of a parent, or it could be somebody married to a sister of a parent. Those are two different things. In a lot of languages, they would be separated out. One, after all, is a blood relation, and the other is just a relation by marriage. But in English, we lump them together. It's this or that, really, that's an uncle. There's no one thing exactly.
- 7.55** Then we can have conditionals: if this, then that. That, too, is a mental operation that the mind has. We can take ideas and combine them. We can think, for example, "What is it for something to be soluble? If you put it in water, it dissolves." So if we have the idea of dissolving, the idea of placing something in water, we can have the idea of solubility. That's, by the way, controversial, but I think it's right. In any case, that's something that enables us to say that we can build complex concepts out of things that are really given in experience or complexes built out of those. We can start performing all these logical operations on them.
- 7.56** That thought, that that's how we build ideas and that's how we build knowledge, in some sense, is wonderful because we can now construct all sorts of things out of what you might think is pretty limited raw material of the impressions that we actually receive and experience. But it does place limits on what we can do as well because we're limited to those raw materials. We're limited to these tools and these abilities in building them.
- 7.57** Locke says, "All those sublime thoughts which tower above the clouds and reach as high as heaven itself, take their rise and footing here;"—in experience, in other words. "In all that great extent wherein the mind wanders in those remote speculations, it may seem to be elevated with, it stirs not one jot beyond those ideas which sense of reflection has offered for its contemplation."
- 7.58** So we start here with experience. We have simple ideas. We start making more and more complex ideas. We form propositions out of those. We can gain lots of knowledge, but we can construct that tower, and that's all we have. We cannot get anywhere else. All of it traces back to experience. So it does impose a limit.

- 7.59 Now, we can abstract, we can combine, we can negate, we can disjoin. Doing that allows us to have ideas that don't correspond to anything in experience, and to form propositions that don't relate very closely to experience. They can be highly abstract, and their connection to experience can be highly indirect.
- 7.60 But Locke says, be careful about that, because now we can diverge from experience and from the structure of the world in pretty radical ways. To have knowledge, our ideas have to match the structure of the world, and what we say has to match what's really true of the world. It's easy for us to start talking about unicorns and golden mountains, and all sorts of things that don't really exist. The more abstract our terms get, the greater danger we're in of saying something that really has no real relation to the world anymore.
- 7.61 This raises a certain question. Let's go back to Descartes and his demon. I was talking about the demon who would trick us utterly by filling our minds with things that don't match the world. Now, both Locke and Hume think that's not a problem because we've got these ideas coming directly from the impressions. But wait a minute. In Descartes, it's what if our innate ideas are all inadequate? That is to say, what if they don't match reality? What if it really is square pegs that we're trying to insert in round holes? If we're thinking about building ideas, what if they're all inadequate?
- 7.62 Locke is concerned about that. He thinks it's a real problem. What if the ideas that I have in my head actually don't match the world at all? They don't adequately describe its structure. So, I've got this set of ideas to apply to something, and they don't match the world at all.
- 7.63 If you want examples of this, think about the history of science, where people talked about things like phlogiston, for example, and it doesn't correspond to anything in the world. Or go back further, they were talking about bodily humors and so on. Now we look at that, and we think that that doesn't match anything in the world.
- 7.64 It's not a trivial point. What if all our ideas are like that? What if at every point we're saying things that people in the future will say, that's a bunch of punk. None of those ideas match the way things really are. But of course, they're destined to be similarly dismissed by future generations. So what if it's just the case that our minds are not built to deal with the world? Locke says that we can be assured because some ideas do perfectly represent the archetypes, which the mind supposes them taken from, to which it refers them. So sometimes our ideas really do match things.
- 7.65 In particular, all our simple ideas are adequate. What's an example of a simple idea? I hear a sound, for example, and I form an idea of that sound. That idea is adequate. Let's say it's a simple sound. Most sounds we hear aren't like that, but let's say it's a pure tone [sings a tone] or something. We have an idea of that, and that idea matches it exactly. Or a particular color patch. We have an idea of that color, and that matches the impression exactly.

- 7.66** So he says, "Here's the key to defeating Descartes's demon." It isn't some fancy argument. It isn't proving God's existence and all of that. Instead, it's just a matter of saying, "Where are you getting the simple ideas that you're using to describe the world? Oh, from experience?" Well, that idea does match that impression. It's why Hume says, "These are mere copies." We've got a copy. It's true, it's a copy, and you might worry the copy machine is not very good or something, but really, there is that direct tie, the level of simple ideas and simple impressions.
- 7.67** So all our simple ideas are adequate. They're nothing but the effects of certain powers and things, he says. Here, he does bring in God. He says, "They're fitted and ordained by God to produce such sensations in us." So, of course, they correspond. But I think it's not like he puts great stress on that religious idea. It's more like, "Hey, look, I've got this idea of white, and I'm looking at a certain patch of white. How could things go wrong? My idea is of that, and I've got direct experience."
- 7.68** So he says, at the level of simple things, of course, it's adequate. When I think about certain kinds of primary qualities, he calls them, then yes, they are adequate. I think about something being solid. I think of this, and I think, "Oh, yes, it's solid. It resists pressure." Or, "It's extended. It's this long," for example, "and this wide." Well, then those things are directly adequate to it. I can measure it, you can measure it. We can say, "Yes, this is the way this object is." And so those ideas are adequate.
- 7.69** But now, other ideas, he says, maybe not so much. For example, ideas of substances, as referred to real essences. Here he's thinking about Aristotle in the background. We've got substances, things like this [holds up a clicker]. They have certain essential properties. He says that our ideas of substances aren't really adequate. Why? Well, because we're imagining a bunch of qualities, a bunch of relations here in this thing. But if we say, "What is it that is actually the thing that has those properties and stands in those relations?" We don't know how to answer it. He says, "It's something I know not what."
- 7.70** What is it that's gray and extended and this long and this wide? He'll say, "Something I know not what." He says that's a problem. These aren't really adequate. In other words, we've got a bunch of qualities here, a bunch of relations, and we don't really know what holds them all together. We have these ideas of particular features of this thing, but what is the thing that has all those qualities? We're not sure. We don't experience it directly. We experience its qualities.
- 7.71** I've said that Hume is a bit more radical than Locke. Locke will say, trace it all back. If you can't quite trace it, maybe you're wrong because you're saying something about the world that can't be traced back to experience. Or maybe this is just a belief of yours, but it can't consist of knowledge because, after all, we cannot trace it back and really assign it a place in experience.

- 7.72** Hume is more radical. He has the same method. He's going to similarly trace the complex ideas we have back into the simple ideas, look at the simple impressions they came from and say, that's the content of that complex idea. But if he can't do it, he's going to say, there's something really wrong with that idea. Maybe it has no content at all, or maybe its content turns out to be something radically different from what we would have thought.
- 7.73** He expresses these ideas in a book he wrote when he was 23, *A Treatise of Human Nature*. He was very disappointed that it didn't make much of a splash when it came out. He later wrote that it fell stillborn from the press. And so he wrote a short version later so that people would actually read it and get interested in the original. But that's my well-loved copy there. And you can see that it's something that now is considered one of the great works of Western philosophy. It's a very long and very important book, but also in a way, a very radical book.
- 7.74** Here's one way of looking at the contrast between Locke and Hume. Locke has these empiricist starting points, these empiricist convictions. But when it comes to hard cases like causation or God or other things that motivated rationalists, Locke says that, of course, things cause other things. Of course, things have powers. Of course, there are necessary connections. Of course, there's a God. And he gives us a long argument, borrowed from Aquinas, about God's existence. But it's much worse than Aquinas's argument, partly because he's trying to be a strict empiricist. Aquinas was, too, but he's forgetting about some of the background in Aquinas and trying to fill it in himself and doesn't do a great job.
- 7.75** But here's the thought. He is actually saying, "These things seem to make sense, so I've got to explain how these actually do relate to experience." Hume says, "I've got this hard-headed method, and if I don't see how this relates to experience, it's gone." So he never got a university position, partly because he was suspected of being an atheist, which Locke certainly was not. He did support himself by writing histories, so he did fine. But nevertheless, these were somewhat scandalous works when they came out because he was willing to discard anything that couldn't be traced back.
- 7.76** Here's, as I mentioned, the core of his method, the simple ideas into which we break down the complexes, come from simple impressions. They represent them exactly. They are, strictly speaking, copies, adequate and accurate copies. He says, "All our simple ideas in their first appearance are derived from simple impressions, which are correspondent to them, and which they exactly represent."
- 7.77** We don't have any problem at the base level. There we've got an exact correspondence between idea and impression, sensation of the world. So we analyze the complex ideas just as Locke would. We find the origins of these simple ideas and experience just as Locke would. The content of the idea lies in those simple impressions, again, like Locke.

- 7.78** But now, he's more skeptical than Locke because he says, "All ideas, and especially abstract ones, are naturally faint and obscure. The mind has but a slender hold of them. They're apt to be confounded with other resembling ideas." When we've often employed any term, though without a distinct meaning, we're apt to imagine it has a determinate idea next to it. So he thinks the further we get from experience, the more confusion arises, the more you might be building that idea in a way that's different from the way I built it.
- 7.79** If we're talking about our idea of white or specifically like that white color, then we're going to be in agreement; there's an exact match. The moment we move even to the generalization of white, for example, you go into a paint store, and somebody says, "Is that white or is that off-white? Is that cream? Is that vanilla?" All of a sudden, you start thinking, "I don't know what white is anymore." You start realizing that different people can draw the line in different places.
- 7.80** My wife and I draw the line between blue and green in different places. It's not that we disagree about the color. We both have, Hume would say, a completely adequate idea of that color. It's just that we build blue and green out of things in different ways, so that what I call blue, she calls green. We're differing on the borderline cases.
- 7.81** Ideas get weaker and weaker, and the ties to experience become more and more remote, and it makes it easier to have these disagreements. You get highly abstract to something about, I don't know, communication or democracy or whatever. Now we're far from those simple impressions, and people can have very different ideas about them. He says that sometimes we have such different ideas or such puzzling ideas, you might wonder whether there's any content at all. Maybe people are just talking garbage.
- 7.82** Indeed, I've spent my life in universities. I can tell you that half the time I get these emails that tell me there's a talk coming about blah, blah, blah. I think that just sounds like complete and utter nonsense. Hume would say, guess what—it probably is. He would say, "When we entertain any suspicion that a philosophical term is employed without any meaning or idea, as is but too frequent, we need but inquire from what impression is that supposed idea derived? And if it be impossible to assign any, this will serve to confirm our suspicion. By bringing ideas into so clear a light, we may reasonably hope to remove all dispute, which may arise, concerning their nature and reality."
- 7.83** So he says that by the time we get up here, it's not like now, the realm of opinion. He says, no, it's now the realm of nonsense. So we trace the origins of these ideas. Sometimes we find impressions, and we have real content. Sometimes, though, there is none. We find out there is no impression underlying this. Sometimes it's contradictory. We find out that actually, this is built in a way that makes no sense. Sometimes it's just not at all what it seems. That turns out to be the case for a lot of instances.

- 7.84** If he looks at these synthetic a priori judgments that the rationalists talk about, he sometimes says that they're analytic and a priori, they're just verbal. Sometimes they're synthetic and a posteriori. We're getting them from experience. Sometimes they're nonsense. We have knowledge of logic, definitions, mathematics—that's the analytic a priori part, the relations of ideas. Then we have the matters of fact, the synthetic a posteriori— that's natural science, history, and so forth.
- 7.85** But he says that a lot of times we're not going to find it to be either one. "When we run over libraries, persuaded of these principles, what havoc must we make? If we take in our hand any volume of divinity or school metaphysics, for instance, let us ask, does it contain any abstract reasoning concerning quantity or number? No. Does it contain any experimental reasoning concerning matter of fact and existence? No. Commit it then to the flames, for it can contain nothing but sophistry and illusion." So go through the library, you're going to find all sorts of nonsense. Commit it to the flames.
- 7.86** Let's apply it to some of those things that the rationalist said were synthetic a priori truths. "The whole is greater than its parts"—that's from Avicenna. He would say, that's by definition. What is a whole? It's made up of parts. That's just a matter of the meanings of the terms. "Things equal to the same thing are equal to each other"—that just comes from the meaning of equality. "Nothing's made from nothing," that is to say, if you start out with nothing, things don't pop randomly into existence. That's a claim about the world. If that's true, it's coming from experience.
- 7.87** "It's impossible for anything to be and not be at the same time"—that's just logic; that's analytic. So it's a verbal truth. "What's been done can't be undone"—that's a matter of our experience of the world. We realize we can't change the past, and that's something we learn from experience. "Every event has a cause"—that, too, comes from experience, and we can imagine an experience that would defeat it. Something just happens at random, and we can assign it no cause. That could happen. So it's something that arises in experience.
- 7.88** What about things like "God exists?" Here, Hume says, existence is no problem, but what about the idea of God? Where does that come from? And now, a question mark. Can I trace that back to experiences in the world? Well, maybe I can, maybe I can't. He's dodgy about this. But in any case, that turns out to be a tricky question. Or "the soul is immortal." I can easily get the idea of mortality from death. And immortality, I just negate that, so that's not a problem.
- 7.89** But the "soul," do I have an idea of a soul? That, too, is going to be a question mark. "The will is free." What is the will exactly? What is freedom in this sense? Question mark. "Every substance has an essence," as Aristotle would think. Well, we've already seen in Locke, substance is a problem. What is it that holds all these qualities together? We don't really know. "What makes something essential?" He thinks that we don't really know that either. "You ought to seek the good." I don't know where that comes from. "Courage is a virtue." A lot of question marks are going to arise.

- 7.90 Yes, a lot of things are going to flunk the test. We're going to say it doesn't belong here; it doesn't belong there. It's not that we're not sure what to do. We're sure what to do: it's nonsense. So get rid of it. Commit it to the flames.
- 7.91 Let's go back to Leibniz's arguments for rationalism. Leibniz said, wait a minute. All experience can give us our contingent truths, and particular contingent truths. But somehow we get universal conclusions, and we think we get law-like, necessary conclusions. We think we can infer things about causation. So there must be a synthetic a priori principle that is operating there that allows us to get to universality, and causation, and laws, and necessity. And Hume says, no. There's nothing like that.
- 7.92 Here's what's happening. These inferences are simply induction. We see particular cases, we infer a general principle. All the observed ravens have been black; we infer that all ravens are black. I've eaten bread, and I've found it nourishing, so I infer that when I eat bread, I will find it nourishing. When the sun sets, it rises the next morning, so I infer that the sun will rise the next morning. But it's not as if there's some a priori principle lurking behind. It just seems to be working out. Let's go with it.
- 7.93 Here's the scandal that he points out. He says, I want to find the origin of this. Leibniz says that it's something that is built into the mind. In a funny way, Hume actually agrees with that, but it is a funny way because he says, if I'm looking for a rational justification for these moves, like the sun will rise the next morning or I'll be nourished by this bread, he realizes this isn't a priori. It could go wrong. The next raven I find might be white. The next bread I eat might be poison. Maybe the sun will go nova, and actually it won't rise the next morning.
- 7.94 So wait a minute. It can't be a priori. It isn't really strictly necessary in that sense. I can imagine things going wrong. But also it's not a posteriori. I can't justify induction on the basis of experience. Why? I'd be appealing to experience. I'd say, I've been making these inductive moves going from particular to general all the way along, and it seems to be working out, so I guess it will continue to work out. That's to say, I've been doing it in these particular cases, so it will continue. That's itself a move from particular to general, so that would be circular. So in short, he says, "I can't justify these moves."
- 7.95 It's not that Leibniz says that you can't justify them logically, so there's got to be some hidden thing that justifies them." Hume says, no, there's nothing that justifies them. It couldn't be a priori because we can imagine it going wrong. It couldn't be a posteriori because that would be arguing in a circle. So we tend to assume that the future will be like the past. But why do we think that? It's not built into the mind. It's just, in the end, we say it's worked up to now. It has been. But that's just to appeal to the very thing at issue. It's a circular argument. We can't very well say, "Why will the future resemble the past? It has up to now."
- 7.96 That leads him to say that there is no rational foundation for this. We don't have a synthetic a priori principle that supplies the rational foundation, but there is no rational

foundation. That's not going to do it. It can't do it since things could go wrong, and we can't justify things in circles. In the end, it can't be rational. He concludes that all these inferences from experience are the effects of custom, not of reasoning. In other words, we just do it. We're in the habit of doing it, but there is no justification.

- 7.97** He says, look at how this actually works. If I put my hand in a flame and I go, "Oh, it's hot," and I say that all flames are hot, well, that seems like a pretty radical jump from one instance to a generalization. But if I keep doing it, then it seems like I have a very good reason for thinking this. "Oh, that was hot. That's hot, too." The more I do this—I mean, in this case, it seems like one would be enough, actually. But in a lot of cases, that's not true. You can't find that one patient is helped by administering this drug, for example, and conclude that all patients with that symptom are going to be helped by that drug. But the more you test, the more acceptable it seems.
- 7.98** But Hume says, that's weird, isn't it? There's no rational justification. In one case, it would seem like a ridiculous leap, but in another case, it seems to make sense. That tells us that there is some difference between the one case and the multiple cases, and it's evidence that it is based on habit or custom, not on reason. Why? Because I actually have a difference. Here's why it's different. I think in one case, I can't draw this conclusion, but in multiple cases, I can. And yet I've just got the same type of thing. "This flame is hot, that flame is hot, that flame is hot"—why would the repetition of that make any difference?
- 7.99** He says, here's why it matters. It affects my feeling of expectation. If something happens once, I'll think, "Whoa, look at that." But if it keeps happening, I start expecting it to happen. At that point, I realized there's a difference, but it's not a rational difference. It's a difference in my feeling of expectation. I see lightning and then thunder, lightning, thunder, lightning, thunder, and eventually, I see the lightning, and I expect the thunder. I conclude that there's a causal relationship, that the lightning causes the thunder.
- 7.100** What justifies it? The answer is my feeling of expectation is the source in experience. It's not a priori. We can imagine it otherwise. I can imagine that lightning occurs and there's no thunder, or the thunder just occurs without any lightning. Easy to imagine that. I've experienced it. But wait, he said, in this case, do I experience the causal link? No, I see the flash of lightning. I hear the thunder. I don't see the connection between them. I don't experience the connection between them. It's just one thing and then another thing.
- 7.101** And that is generally true. He says, we've got contiguity, in other words, this then that, and succession, this then that. But there's no connection. We never experience the connection between events like this. So if we're looking for the simple idea of causation, and then we say, "Where is the impression from which it's derived?" There's nothing in the world that we experience corresponding to the causal link itself.

- 7.102** If we think, but what happens in one case, first time a child, let's say, witnesses a storm, lightning, and then thunder, they think of those as two separate events. After a while, they start linking them. The difference is not a rational one; it's not a matter of logic. It is a matter of the feeling of expectation. The child sees the flash of lightning and expects the thunder.
- 7.103** So he says, "When we look about us towards external objects and consider the operation of causes, we are never able in a single instance to discover any power or necessary connection, any quality that binds the effect to the cause and renders one an infallible consequence of the other." We never see the necessary connection. We never experience the causation. It's just one thing happens, and another thing happens. I hit the billiard ball, it hits another ball, that one moves. We see that happening, but we don't see the causation. We just see one motion followed by another motion.
- 7.104** So he says that if that's right, it doesn't look as if in the world we find any impression that corresponds to our idea of causation. "One event follows another; but we can never observe any tie between them. They seem conjoined but never connected." We don't see the connection. It's just one thing, another thing. So in the end, we've got to trace this back to an impression. That's the whole method. But how can we do it?
- 7.105** Well, he says, it looks like somehow we get from this constant conjunction to causation. But we don't find anything in the world. There is no impression. There's no sensation of any connection in the world. In the end, Leibniz would say, there must be some reason then that supplied a priori. But he says that can't be right. Because that would mean it was just a priori, that is to say, necessary and independent of experience, that the world just keeps following in the same pattern. And that's just not true. In fact, it's certainly the case that we can imagine things going differently.
- 7.106** So we can't prove on the basis of logic that the world has to keep going in the same way and that the same causal patterns have to apply. We can imagine a change in the course of nature. Indeed, sometimes there are changes in the course of nature. Sometimes, let's say, the magnetic pole of the Earth might shift, and then, wow, things are different, and the patterns that used to exist don't exist anymore. We, again, get led into that circle if we think it's experience that justifies this.
- 7.107** We've got to find something that makes the repetition actually give us an idea that we didn't have before. He says, Here's the thing: it's just the feeling. The child experiences the lightning and thunder and starts having a feeling of expectation. So there is a new impression in the mind, but it's not an external impression. It's not an impression of something out there. It is internal. I start feeling something. I start expecting the thunder when I see the lightning. That is the origin of the idea of causation. From one instance, we infer nothing. From multiple instances, we do infer a causal link, but nothing in the world really changes. Where is that coming from? It's coming from our feeling of expectation.

- 7.108** That implies something pretty dramatic. The idea of necessity, the idea of causation, it isn't something that we find in the world. It comes from an internal impression of the mind. So it exists in the mind, not in objects. The necessity is in us. It is not in the world. Here's a case where it's not as if we find that causation is nonsense. We find an origin, but it's purely subjective. It is a subjective origin. It's not an objective thing in the world. So the source is not in the world. The source is in us.
- 7.109** Leibniz would agree, yes, and from a rational part of us, it's a matter of these synthetic a priori principles. But Hume says, no, no, no, it's not rational at all. It comes from this feeling of expectation. It is a matter of custom and habit, but that implies it's a social thing. He thinks it's just a matter of us starting to have an emotional response. So the origin is within us. We project this regularity onto the world, but actually it's just a matter of our own feeling and reaction to the world.
- 7.110** So he says, "The mind has a great propensity to spread itself on external objects, and to conjoint with them any internal impressions, which they occasion, and which always make their appearance at the same time as the objects." So this is something we simply project onto the world. Well, all sorts of things are going to turn out to be like this. It isn't just necessity. It isn't just causation. It turns out to be substance. What is it that actually holds these qualities together that stands in certain relations?
- 7.111** Locke would say, "Something I know not what." He would say, I guess, the idea is fuzzy. Hume says that it's just that these qualities go together. We project that this is an object, but it's us saying this is one thing. It's not really one thing in the world. The idea of unity, the idea of substance is something we project onto the world. Matter—that's something we are projecting onto the world.
- 7.112** The self, that I am I. It's part of the reason I worried about the "I think" and "I am" in Descartes. Hume would say, "Who is this I? I don't know where you're getting the idea of yourself. Where's the impression of yourself?" He says, I look inside myself and all I see are thoughts, feelings, perceptions. I don't find a little me. And so in the end, I'm projecting this idea of a self onto the world. That's true of the identity of all sorts of objects.
- 7.113** It's true also of morality because, actually, I call murder wrong, let's say, and I call generosity good. I look for the wrongness in the world. I look for the goodness in the world. I don't find it. What do I find? My own reaction, my own emotional reaction. I see a murder, and I'm horrified. I see an act of generosity, and it pleases me. He says, in the end, the source of all of those moral ideas is my own feelings of approval and disapproval. In the end, there's no rational way to get from the "is" to the "ought." It's purely a matter of feeling.
- 7.114** To say "that is wrong" is really a way of saying, "I disapprove of that." To say "that's good" is a way of saying, "I approve of that." In all cases like this, the source is an internal impression. We're imposing everything onto the world. In the end, he says, all

our reasoning is concerning cause and effect, but also concerning substance, concerning the self, concerning identity of objects, concerning goodness and badness and other moral qualities, all of that is derived from nothing but custom or our own internal reactions, our feelings. It's part of our sensitive nature, not our cognitive part. It's a matter of feeling.

- 7.115** Let me just say a few words at the end here about how this works with objects, because it's maybe not quite so intuitive. Heraclitus said, "You can't step into the same river twice." In some intuitive sense, that seems wrong. Yes, the water is flowing by, and there are different stages of this river, but we think of the river as something that has a unity, even though it's different water and the boundaries may change a little.
- 7.116** On the other hand, as soon as you think, "Is the Missouri the same river as the Mississippi? Is that all one river or is it two rivers?" You start realizing that seems a little bit arbitrary. Indeed, the same is true with the Colorado. You could say it's a matter of river stages, but you have a sense we're calling it that river. It's the same with all objects. Really, we are defining the boundaries of the objects.
- 7.117** Here's the classic case I will finish with, because it's so beautiful in illustrating the point. It's the Ship of Theseus. The example comes from Plutarch. Theseus sets out to sail, and he is on long journeys in the ship for many years. Well, some planks start to deteriorate, they start to rot or they get broken, and so they're replaced as they go sailing along. Eventually, it turns out there is not a single plank left of the original ship. Is it still the same ship?
- 7.118** Interestingly, in the Stanford Encyclopedia of Philosophy, there's an article on the Ship of Theseus problem, and it's been revised many times, and not a single sentence remains unchanged from the very first version. So it is itself an example of the Ship of Theseus problem.
- 7.119** Now, Hobbes actually makes this problem even more interesting because he says, imagine there's a collector who has been following Theseus around. He's a big Theseus fan. He gathers up all these old discarded planks, and he actually recreates the ship in the original form, the original shape, with the original planks. Now, Theseus is still sailing along in the boat, and now this guy has reconstructed it and put it in a museum saying, "Here is the ship of Theseus." Theseus, meanwhile, says, "What do you mean? Here's my ship." We can get into complicated questions of ownership here, but which is truly the ship of Theseus? Is that the original shape, the original matter and planks and so on, reconstructed? Or is it the one that he's still sailing, even though no individual part is the same as a part it had at the beginning?
- 7.120** What should we really say? Hume says in the end that it's not a question about the world. It's a question about language. This is a grammatical rather than a philosophical difficulty. There is no truth of the matter, no fact of the matter, about which is really the ship of Theseus. It's how we choose to talk.

- 7.121** He says, in this case, I think we would choose to say it's the ship that Theseus is still sailing around in because it's been a gradual process. But if it had happened fast, if Theseus had said, "I'm done with this ship, just tear it apart," and somebody then quickly rebuilt it, then we'd be inclined to say that now maybe that one is the ship. So he says, at the end, it's not a question about the world. There is no fact of the matter. It's just how we choose to talk.
- 7.122** That's going to be true of identity, of causation, of moral qualities, and in the end, of the self, which is a pretty scary thought. Next time, we'll look at the idea of the idealists who say that actually, that idea that we're projecting things like this onto the world, can be taken even further. Maybe we project the world itself.
- 7.123** How does science play into this argument? How far along is science while Hume is talking about these ideas, especially causation?
- 7.124** Okay, excellent. John Locke thinks that science plays into this in a pretty fundamental way because he thinks there is a distinction— and we'll talk a little bit about this next time—between the nominal essence of something and the real essence of something. In Aristotle, there are certain properties that are necessary to being a thing, and those are the essential properties. Aristotle thinks it's not that hard to identify what they are.
- 7.125** Hume thinks it's all nonsense. It's a matter of us projecting things because it's a matter of necessity. "Oh, this is necessarily that?" I'm necessarily a human being, but not necessarily, let's say—what? A certain height. He would say that you're talking about certain properties being necessary, but there's no identity to anything, including me. When you say that property is necessary to being me, that necessity is something you're supplying. So in the end, I can't really talk about this. It's a matter of how we project our concepts onto things. That's it.
- 7.126** Locke says, wait a minute, wait a minute. Yes, it is true that I associate certain things with a term. So some necessities are purely verbal necessities. So I might just conclude a human being has the following properties necessarily. If it doesn't have those properties, I'm not going to call it a human being. That's a verbal matter. Those are the nominal essences. This is just part of what it is to call something that.
- 7.127** But then, he says there's also a real essence which has to do with the real internal constitution of the thing. That's where science comes in. So what is water? You might think it's this tasteless, odorless liquid that is necessary to life. You find it in rivers and lakes. That's part of the nominal essence of the thing. Those are things that we associate with the word. But he says, really, what is water? It's H₂O. That's the real internal constitution. That's the real essence of it. That's what makes it water.
- 7.128** Aristotle says at one point, "What is the essence? It's what's necessary for being the thing." It's something like the definition or what the definition would correspond to. The essence is what really makes it what it is. Locke, I think, says, "Hold on a second. Those are two different things." What we associate with the word and what thereby is

in some sense true by definition, that's different from what makes it what it is. What makes water what it is is being H₂O. And then these are the things we associate with the word. But those are two different sets of things.

- 7.129** Whereas Hume says, "All this is just projected on the world by us. There's no fact of the matter." Locke says, "Yes, there is, and is revealed by natural science." Locke is writing right at the beginnings of the chemical revolution. So he is not yet in a position to talk about this in much detail. In fact, he's pessimistic about it. He says that maybe we'll never know the real essences of things. If only he had been alive a century later, he could have said that now we do know the real essences of a lot of these things. So I think he's unduly pessimistic, but he recognizes that that's the role of science to uncover those real essences.
- 7.130** Some things are purely artificial kinds, and so there probably is no real essence. For example, what makes something a tie? I don't know that there's a scientific answer to that. It seems to me something that isn't really scientific; it's a matter of social convention. And so there, maybe it is a matter of verbal truths, or maybe it's, as Hume says, just something we project onto the world.
- 7.131** But when you have a natural kind like water or gold or jade—well, jade is really one of those disjunctive things of two different natural kinds—but in any case, there, we do have a scientific answer we can give. Locke would say that it's not projected on the world. That's not a verbal matter. That's really the way the world is. And that's the thing that Hume can't really say.
- 7.132** Even though they start in the same place and start with the same method, they end up exactly on questions of science in a really different place. The Humian ends up making all this subjective—we're projecting all of this. But for Locke, no, there's a real objective matter. There is a real internal constitution that answers questions like, "What is this thing? What makes it what it is? What is its essence?"

Lecture 8: On Idealism

At a glance — On idealism.

- 8.1** We're going to be talking today about idealism. Idealism is the view that there really isn't a mind-independent world. That is to say, everything really, in some sense, depends on the mind. The world, as we think of it, is really something like a construction or a projection of the mind. Now, that might seem a really bizarre sort of view.
- 8.2** It emerges very early in Indian philosophy and very early in Chinese philosophy. Interestingly, it doesn't really emerge until the 17th and 18th century in Western philosophy. But for several centuries, it becomes the dominant view. And today, it competes with realism. I think the realists are slightly ahead if you took a poll of philosophers, and believe it or not, people do that. But nevertheless, there are lots of idealists, or as they tend to call themselves these days, "anti-realists," around. I want to talk some about that tradition and why some people embrace it and, in fact, think it's inevitable, why other people reject it.
- 8.3** The key figure is Immanuel Kant, who really shifts things around. He is not the first idealist in the Western tradition; Bishop Berkeley probably deserves that honor. But we're not really going to talk much about Berkeley, essentially because I think his reasons for being an idealist are not very compelling reasons, except for one. And that is, it is, in his view, the only way we can really defeat the skeptic. The skeptic says there's no reason to believe one thing or another. From one point of view, the skeptic sees this huge gap between our minds and the world and says, "I do not see how to get across that gap.
- 8.4** And Berkeley says, "Well, what if the world were a projection of my mind?" If my mind's task is to actually represent the world accurately, I don't see how I could be short of doing that. But if my mind is projecting the world, not a problem. It's as if I'm the author of a story. If I'm writing a work of non-fiction, I've got to try to get things right. But if I'm creating a work of fiction, I'm making up what's right, and it's not a problem anymore. So the idealist, like Berkeley says, "I know how to defeat the skeptic, make the world my own construction. And then, of course, it matches my ideas because I built it out of those ideas." Now, Kant, as we'll see, is not quite that simple an idealist, but that is one of the motivations for taking this turn. Let's talk about the contrast in a little more detail.
- 8.5** The realist says, "Some things are mind-independent." Now, it's important that there's a "some" there because presumably, there are all sorts of things that are mind-dependent. The whole branch of science known as psychology is mind-dependent. After all, it's the study of the mind. If I'm telling you something about my own thoughts,

my own dreams, my own emotions, then of course all that I'm talking about is mind-dependent because I'm talking about my own mental states and mental episodes.

- 8.6** In fact, I might be a realist about a particular thing. I might say, "I'm a realist about this. I think those things really exist in a way that's independent of the mind." So a scientific realist, for example, is someone who says, "I think the basic entities of science are things that really exist independently of us." But a realist, as such, just says, "Some things are independent of the mind. Not everything is like psychology."
- 8.7** The idealist says, "Everything is mind-dependent," and that is a sweeping universal claim—everything is really a projection of the mind. Now, you could be an idealist about a particular thing without being a sweeping idealist in this way. You could be an idealist about, let's say, ethics. You could say, "Well, I think actually Hume is right, that we're just projecting good and bad, right and wrong, and so on in the world. That is a mental construction. But of course, I think electrons really exist." You could be a realist about some things and an anti-realist or an idealist about certain other things.
- 8.8** But we're going to be talking for the most part about idealism as a sweeping view that says everything is dependent on the mind. Everything, including the objects of science, including the objects of everyday life, all of those things are really constructions of the mind. Now, one way of thinking about this, given what we've been doing already, is to go back to Locke's distinction between primary and secondary qualities.
- 8.9** Locke is a realist. He's somebody who thinks that certain things really are independent of the mind, even though his theory is really thoroughly within the new way of ideas. You could interpret Locke as a kind of idealist because everything is built out of ideas. But I think in the end, he thinks, "No, no, no. Some of our ideas actually match the world." Not all of them, of course. Horse, that matches the world. They're really our horses. Unicorn, that doesn't match the world. There aren't really unicorns. And he thinks that's true of our terms for qualities as well. So adjectives, some of them really describe qualities of things in the world and other things don't.
- 8.10** Let's go back to the argument from comparison that the skeptics used, saying, "Here's why I don't think we can have any reasonable beliefs about the way the world really is." We have no way of telling what is really in the world and what is being supplied by our own sensory and cognitive apparatus. I have faculties that allow me to sense the outside world, but they shape it in certain ways. I'm sensitive to certain things about the outside world and not sensitive to others. There are fish, for example, that can sense magnetic fields. I can't do that. I can sense things, visually, for example, that a bat cannot sense, but a bat has sonar that I don't have. In short, I'm contributing a lot just by the faculties I have for perceiving the world.
- 8.11** But also then the brain processes all of that and produces out of what is, after all, a two-dimensional array on the retina, a three-dimensional representation. And so how does that work? I am, in a sense, constructing that three-dimensional representation of

things around me. I have no way, the skeptic says, of telling what the world really contains and what is being supplied by all of those levels of processing in my sense organs, and then in the transmission of the brain, and then in the brain itself.

8.12 Well, I can't tell—like the colors of the dresses. This was a few years ago, a famous online controversy. Is the dress really blue and black or is it really white and gold? It looks one way in some lighting conditions and a different way in other lighting conditions. And yet, as you can see from that little strip of fabric that somebody has put along helpfully, it's actually the same thing. It all depends on the background. It depends on the other things around it. And so is the color really in the dress or is it being supplied by our own faculties of cognition and sensation?

8.13 That's actually a pretty good argument that our color perceptions are being supplied by us. They're not really there in the world. If they were really there in the world, why would it matter what the background is, whether it's light or dark, what the lighting conditions are? And so on. You might think, okay, color is a good example of the kind of thing that we seem to be supplying. It isn't there really in the world. Well, what if everything's like that? That's the idealist worry. What if everything turns out to be like that?

8.14 Now, Locke does not think everything is like that. He says, wait a minute. He was before the main part of the chemical revolution, but already the atomic theory of matter was starting to predominate in science. Locke was aware of that. He spoke of perception for example, in terms of little tennis balls bouncing off objects and entering the eye. You could think of a photon, I guess, as something like a little tennis ball. So he's not completely off base. But he sees that the atomic theory, on the one hand, seems to suggest the world really is made up of certain things like atoms or whatever their components are.

8.15 But from another point of view, poses a real challenge because it seems to imply that the world is not at all what it seems to us. In other words, it's not just the color of the dress, let's say, that we think, "Oh, we must be supplying that—that isn't really in the world. It's not really in the object." We start thinking, "Wait, most of the things we perceive are not at all what they're like or what they seem to be like."

8.16 For example, it's not just color; things seem to have a certain texture, they seem to be solid. This lectern seems to be solid. I can't put my hand through it. And yet, according to the atomic theory, it consists of these tiny particles vibrating rapidly. It seems to be still, but no, it's vibrating rapidly, or at least the parts are. And most of it is empty space. It doesn't seem like it's empty space. Well, actually, in this case, being translucent, it sort of does. But in general, that's not true of solid objects.

8.17 And so maybe solidity, maybe motion, maybe texture, all sorts of things are like color in that respect. Maybe they are being supplied. And if we could see things with a true scientific eye, we'd just see atoms and fields of certain kinds, we wouldn't see the

objects that we perceive at all. So from one point of view, you can say, "Look, things are radically not as they appear." And that's a scary thought.

- 8.18** Aristotle tends to not even consider that. There are ancient Greek atomists, but he's not one of them. He thinks, "Look, objects like the lectern caused my perception of it and are represented in my perceptions. The cause of what I'm perceiving and my representation and the object of that representation are just the same thing. And so I can perceive the qualities that it really has."
- 8.19** But once we have the atomic theory, we start realizing, "Wait a minute, what if the cause of my perceptions is radically unlike the object of the perception?" What if, in other words, the cause of this is really the atoms that make it up, and what's represented in my mind is this object that actually isn't very much like that collection of atoms at all? The objects might be mere appearances, and the things in themselves, those are the atoms. They're the real things. This, then, is some combination of those. But the qualities it has are radically unlike the qualities of the things that really exist.
- 8.20** It introduces this skeptical scenario that Zhuangzi and Philo and others talked about, and suddenly makes it real and dramatic. Wait a minute, if modern science is right, and actually, the succession of relativity theory and then of quantum mechanics makes this even worse. Study the objects of quantum mechanics, and you can think, "I don't even know what the world consists in anymore. I have no idea what the reality is." The fact that certain things like waves collapse when you perceive them but are different when you don't—the Schrödinger's cat experiment and so on—those things are terrifying. You start really—wait, what if there is no reality until I perceive it? What if it's all a construction? What if it all has a certain structure purely because I'm perceiving it?
- 8.21** Arthur Eddington saw this problem pretty early. He was, by the way, one of the key figures that actually worked to verify and confirm Einstein's theory of general relativity. But he says, "In the world of physics, we watch a shadowgraph performance of the drama of familiar life. The shadow of my elbow rests on the shadow table as the shadow ink flows over the shadow paper." Notice the echo of Plato here. All these things that seem to be the objects around us, what if they're just shadows? In this case, not shadows of the abstract Forms, but shadows of the atoms.
- 8.22** He says, "It's all symbolic, and as a symbol, the physicist leaves it. The frank realization that physical science is concerned with a world of shadows is one of the most significant of recent advances." So he's worried about the fact that there is not really one table, as Aristotle thought—the table causes my perception of the table and is represented in that perception in a way that's pretty accurate. What if there are two tables there? Eddington says, "One of them is the table as understood by physicists, and it's not at all like the table that I actually perceive." So the table in my representation has one set of qualities, but the physicist says, "Well, here's what's really going on," and it turns out to be radically unlike the table as I perceive it.

- 8.23** Well, here's one way of thinking about this: maybe some of the qualities match; it's maybe not different in every single respect. There are qualities, let's say, that according to atomic theory, the atoms have. Call those the primary qualities. Then there are qualities that only the thing has as it's represented by me as an appearance. Those are the secondary qualities. Locke says the primary qualities are the qualities that are really in the thing itself. They're possessed by the thing itself, and they are the ones that ultimately are described by physics and could be given a mathematical representation. But the other qualities are being supplied by us.
- 8.24** Here is how Locke puts it, "Take a grain of wheat, divide it into two parts, each part still has solidity, extension, figure, and mobility; divide it again, and it retains the same qualities; divide it on till the parts become insensible, they still have those qualities. These I call the original or primary qualities of body"—they include things like —"solidity, extension, figure, motion, or rest, and number." Now, even the special theory of relativity says that collection might be a lot smaller than you'd think.
- 8.25** For example, motion or rest, Einstein is saying that it depends on my frame of reference. I'm on the train, and it seems like you're just sitting there beside me on the train; you're stationary. But of course, to somebody outside the train, we both seem to be moving along rapidly. So are you in motion or at rest? Well, it depends on your frame of reference. What is the shape of your motion? What does it look like? From my point of view, you're just going forward like this. But from the point of view of somebody outside the train, maybe the track is curving and so on. So maybe your trajectory looks quite different.
- 8.26** So certain things that Locke would have said that's part of what physics takes as basic, those are really in the object. After relativity, we might say, "Oh, at least some of those are different." Now, not all of them, maybe. Rest mass, for example, might still be something that is really there in the object. But inertial mass is going to depend on velocity, and that's going to depend on a frame of reference. Maybe only a few of these survive once we move to relativity theory.
- 8.27** But in any case, that doesn't change the basic point. Locke is saying the primary qualities are inseparable from the objects. The atoms have them. Those things are had by the thing itself. It's not relative to an inertial frame; it is not relative to a perceiver. Those, he says, produce simple ideas in us that exactly match what they are. In that respect, at least, we're seeing the world as it is.
- 8.28** The secondary qualities are different. Descartes says, yes, these are the mathematical properties of things that are described in physics. They reflect the true natures of things. But the secondary qualities aren't like that. The secondary qualities aren't things like solidity, and extension, and mass and so forth. Instead, they involve the sensations these things produce in us. They depend on the primary qualities, and so there's something about the object that determines our color perception of it. But on the other

hand, that color or the sound of something, the taste of something, all of that is a secondary quality. That's a matter of it producing a certain sensation in us.

- 8.29** Those are things that can differ. They can differ with the setting. We're going to see the dress as different colors in different settings. They can differ person to person. People might perceive color differently. A person could be colorblind, for example. People can perceive sounds differently. Somebody might find a sound really loud, and another person might find it fine.
- 8.30** Taste is like this. In fact, cilantro is a good example. Some people think it tastes soapy. Some don't. I don't. But that means, it turns out, I lack a gene that enables me to taste a certain compound in the cilantro. Durian is a much more outrageous example. To most people, including me, it smells like rotting garbage. But some people actually eat it because they lack the gene that enables them to smell that. If you get past that smell, it apparently tastes delicious. I have never gotten past that smell, so I don't know from experience, but in that case, it's rather unfortunate to have the gene that allows you to taste it. The point is that the taste and the smell aren't in the durian or aren't in the cilantro. They are a matter of how that affects a certain perceiver, and people differ in the way they respond.
- 8.31** We look at something like red, and that's a matter of the effect of the object on our nervous systems. The redness is not in the object itself. Go down and it's not like red things are made up of red atoms, blue things are made up of little blue atoms and so on. It's not like that. It's a matter of the fabric or whatever it is, the surface, reflecting certain wavelengths of light and then us perceiving those in certain ways.
- 8.32** These are sometimes described as response-dependent. That is to say, to be red is just to be something a standard perceiver perceives as red. It's to have the power to affect a standard perceiver in certain ways. That does get determined by certain primary qualities of the thing, but the redness isn't that set of primary qualities. It's not in the atoms, it's not in the shape and so on. It's a matter of how it affects people.
- 8.33** We could put it this way: Descartes and Locke are realists about the primary qualities—they think they're independent of the mind. But the secondary qualities of things are dependent on the mind. They're idealists, basically, about the secondary qualities, but realists about the primary qualities of things. Once you start making that move, you start realizing, let's see if we can squeeze that group of primary qualities. What if that disappears altogether? Then it turns out we're idealists about everything. The secondary qualities, in some sense, they just exist in the mind, but the primary qualities exist in the things.
- 8.34** According to Descartes and Locke, our ideas of the primary qualities are adequate. But we are supplying these others, and so the secondary quality ideas are inadequate. They're not really in the thing, even though we perceive them as being in the thing. We perceive those colors as really being in the thing, but in fact, the thing is what it is. It's

just different lighting conditions, different backgrounds, and so on that make us perceive the colors differently.

- 8.35** Well, the first person to come along and really push this systematically in a direction that leads to idealism is Immanuel Kant. I've mentioned that Berkeley does this for a variety of reasons that I don't find very persuasive, but Kant comes up with deeper reasons. I want to talk for a while about Immanuel Kant's view. We've already discussed his views of ethics, but now I want to think about his broader view.
- 8.36** He calls what he's doing a Copernican Revolution in philosophy. Here's the way you might think about it. Rationalists like Avicenna, Descartes, Leibniz, think that universal and necessary conclusions—things about causation, for example, or all this or that, or necessarily blah, blah, blah—they all can't possibly be coming from a collection of purely contingent and particular bits of experience. We must be supplying something of our own. We've got to be adding something synthetic and a priori. That's knowledge of the world that's independent of experience at all.
- 8.37** Hume says, "Well, I agree with you that we cannot get, logically, from the particular and the contingent to the universal and necessary." So what's supplying it is not something from reason. It's just our own reactions to things. We are projecting that onto the world. It's a matter of custom or habit or feeling, not a matter of something that's in the world.
- 8.38** Kant's response is to say, "Hume, you're right that the source is in us. It's not really in the world. It's not a matter of synthetic a priori knowledge of things out there. But it is reason. It's not just custom or habit." It's not just a matter of custom, for example, that I react in a certain way, that I start thinking of lightning as causing thunder. That's not just the custom we have, like we say, "How are you?" or, "How do you do?" or, "Nice to meet you." When we meet a new person. It's not like that. It's something built into the structure of the mind. Admittedly, it's not a rational feature of the mind, but nevertheless, it is a tendency that is built into us. Kant says, wait a minute. What if it is rational? What if there is a reason behind it?
- 8.39** It looks as if the traditional rationalist, like Descartes or Leibniz, has a problem here because they've got to convince you that somehow you have this knowledge of the world independently of experience. We could be like Philo and saying that here's what's happening: God is stamping your mind and the world with the same stamp. The logos informs your mind, the logos informs the world. Yay, they match. That gives you synthetic a priori knowledge.
- 8.40** But as soon as we think about Descartes's deceiver, we realize, what if there isn't a being that's doing that? What if it's just random evolutionary processes that mean that my mind has no particular relation to the world? Or what if there's actually an evil deceiver that stamps my mind with the wrong stamp? Now, Kant says, as long as my concepts have to match the objects of the world, I don't see how to solve that problem.

I think that Descartes's evil deceiver, or just the fact that it might be random, suggests that that's not going to work.

- 8.41** But what if the objects have to revolve around our concepts? So instead of saying, my mind has to revolve around the world and match it somehow—and I don't see how I can be confident that it does that—what if the world revolves around my concepts and I can be guaranteed it is as if I am the author of a fiction and I'm constructing this, I'm projecting it. So, of course, it matches the structure of my concepts because my concepts are building the world. Well, then great. I can solve this problem.
- 8.42** Now, Kant calls this his Copernican Revolution. I actually think it's his anti-Copernican Revolution. After all, Copernicus says that we aren't the center of things. It's not like everything else revolves around us. We're revolving around the sun. Here, I think Kant is trying to glorify himself by saying, "Hey, I'm part of the scientific revolution, too!" But I think he's going in the opposite direction. He's saying that, actually, the world has to revolve around me. Instead of the problem, I have to revolve around the world because I don't know how I can do that.
- 8.43** Here's how he puts it, "It's hitherto been assumed that our cognition must conform to the objects, but all attempts to ascertain anything about these objects a priori, by means of concepts, and thus to extend the range of our knowledge have been rendered abortive by this assumption. Let's make the experiment whether we may not be more successful in metaphysics, if we assume that the objects must conform to our cognition."
- 8.44** If I've got to match my mind to the world, that's a serious problem. Maybe I can do it. I don't know. I don't know how I can ever be in a position to have confidence that I can do it because I can never get outside my own mind to see what the world is like independently of the mind. But if the world has to conform to my mind, I'm home, right? Sweet. It's got to match me because I'm building it, I'm constructing it. My mind is responsible for it. So, of course, it has to match my mind. It's being built by my mind.
- 8.45** He says this is just like Copernicus. As I've mentioned, I think, no, it's just the opposite. He says, "If the object conforms to the nature of our faculty of intuition," which is his term for sensibility— he's borrowing that from Avicenna, by the way. It's confusing because intuition is a term we think of as this magical awareness of something, and we can't really explain how, but he just means sensation, or maybe sensation plus reflection. He just means experience, really. "I can then easily conceive the possibility of such an a priori knowledge." If the object has to conform to my faculties, then, of course, I can know something about it a priori, independently of experience.
- 8.46** The realist says, "My concepts have to revolve around the world." The idealist says, "No, the world of objects revolves around us. It has to conform to us." And so he says, "Yeah, I seem to have this a priori knowledge of the world." And by the way, he doesn't so much argue for this as just assert it. He says, "I do know certain things synthetic a

priori." And his example, as I mentioned earlier, is $7 + 5 = 12$. I can know truths of arithmetic. And he says, they are a priori. I don't need to do experiments to see if $7 + 5 = 12$, or for that matter, $1 + 1 = 2$. I don't have to test that. I don't have to look around and say, "Anybody have anything so I can put these together and count them?" No, it's just true by virtue of—

- 8.47** Now, Hume would say the meanings of the terms $1 + 2$ or $7 + 5 = 12$, et cetera, an equality. But Kant says, no, no, no. And I've already mentioned the reason: I can take this group of seven things, this group of five things, I can put them together in a larger group. I can combine groups. Where does that claim come from? That isn't true just verbally. It looks like something that must be true, on the other hand, but I don't know how I could test it in an experience. That's why he's convinced that that kind of truth is synthetic and it is a priori. We know it about the world. We can combine different groups of things into bigger groups. But that's not something we're deriving from experience.
- 8.48** So he says that that must be possible. But if it's possible, what would make it possible? First of all, there have to be laws of the understanding. The objects have to conform to me. If there ends up being a necessity to that, the necessity is coming from me. In that respect, he's agreeing with Hume. But there must be these laws in my mind, in my understanding, that are expressed in a priori concepts. I've got to have these innate ideas, and moreover, these laws connecting them that are built in and that are then built into the objects as I perceive them. So all the objects of experience necessarily have to conform to these concepts and to these laws.
- 8.49** So let's take it apart. I have to have these innate ideas. These a priori concepts, they are called the pure concepts of the understanding. He also calls them the categories. And then there are going to be the laws of the understanding, the synthetic a priori truths that are made up of these innate concepts. But there's a trick. So far, it might seem that we are now saying, "Descartes, you were right. Leibniz, you were right. I've got the same laws of the understanding."
- 8.50** But it's not quite so simple because he's saying, these are going to be laws of the understanding, and they're going to govern sensation as well, but they apply only within the realm of experience. In other words, I am faced with this world that I somehow experience. "I don't know," he says, "what the world is really like."
- 8.51** From one point of view, you could see Kant as somebody who takes the argument from comparison, from Philo and from Zhuangzi, and just runs with it and says that it's absolutely true. I cannot tell what in the object of my experience corresponds to what's really out there in the world. So can I conclude something about what's really out there in the world on the basis of how my processing works? No. But can I conclude something about the objects as I experience them? Yes.

- 8.52** So the laws of the understanding and the a priori concepts, the categories, are going to apply to the things as I experience them. They're going to apply to things like the lectern, and to human beings, and to neckties, and to cats, and to clowns, and a variety of other things. They're going to apply to all of that as I experience them.
- 8.53** But now you say, what's the real reality? What is the, as he puts it, the unconditional equal to X, the thing-in-itself that actually is pre-processing, the way the thing is independently of the way I perceive it and so on. He says, "That thing-in-itself, it's unknowable. I don't know." Now, the scientific realist says, "I know. Natural science is telling me it's the atoms and so on." But Kant says that that's just one more level of our building a theory. Actually, all I can talk about are the things I experience or the things I postulate on the basis of that experience. But they conform to these laws because I'm constructing them to make sense of what's happening to me.
- 8.54** But what's really out there and causing these? Oh, I said, "causing" these things to happen to me. In the first edition, he talks that way when he's writing the Critique of Pure Reason. In the second edition, he takes that out because he realizes, causation—that's one of the categories. I can't apply that to things themselves. They apply only within the realm of experience. So I actually can't say whatever's really out there is causing this. So maybe I can't even say that stuff exists because existence is also one of the categories, as we'll see.
- 8.55** Actually, he's in the position of now saying—and by the way, this is why a lot of idealists now call themselves anti-realists, because it's one thing to say, "There's nothing beyond my perceptions. There are only the objects of experience. There are no things in themselves behind any of that." Kant's saying, I can't really tell you there are, but I think actually there are. We'll get to that argument in a moment.
- 8.56** Because he has a section of the Critique of Pure Reason where he says—this is called the Refutation of Idealism. "I'm going to tell you I'm not really an idealist," because he does think there are things in themselves. It's just that he thinks it's impossible to talk about them and that, really, technically can't even say they exist. But on the other hand, he can't make sense of things without them. We'll get to that in a moment I'm jumping ahead of myself.
- 8.57** Kant is giving us here a transcendental argument. We've already seen this in Descartes, where he's getting from the "I think," and "I am," to the idea that he can trust his clear and distinct perceptions in general. Kant is the one who is really, maybe the first person to spell out the details of this and call it a transcendental argument, even though I think he's not really the first to use it. In fact, I think it's already in Plato, but nevertheless, it's something that is part of this entire rationalist tradition, and Kant is in that rationalist tradition. If we're talking about footnotes to Plato or footnotes to Aristotle, he's a footnote to Plato, but actually a pretty radical one.

- 8.58** Now, here is the idea. If something is a necessary condition for the very possibility of something else, so that that thing would be impossible if this weren't the case, and that other thing actually happens, well, then you can say, necessarily then, that condition must hold. If B is a necessary condition for the possibility of A, and A is actual, then you can say, then necessarily B.
- 8.59** Here is how this goes in Kant. He says, a priori concepts and these laws of the understanding are necessary conditions for the possibility of experience, for the experience of objects as we actually experience them. But we do experience them that way. We have that experience. So there must be these a priori concepts and laws of the understanding, and they have a kind of necessity to them. They apply necessarily to the things that we experience. But of course, I can only conclude that about the things that we actually experience, the objects of experience.
- 8.60** So he says, I can know about things a priori, but only what I am placing in them, only what they have to be like in order to be objects of experience for me. The laws that govern that realm are in us. They're these laws of the understanding, so I can know things as experienced by me, not as they are in themselves. Now, this means he is in a funny position, partly agreeing with classical rationalists like Descartes and Leibniz, partly agreeing with Hume. Is there such a thing as a synthetic a priori truth? Kant says, yes, there are these laws of the understanding. And so in that respect, he's agreeing with Descartes against Hume. He's a rationalist.
- 8.61** But can I have knowledge beyond the realm of experience? Descartes says, "Yes, I can know that God exists," for example, "and that God is good." Hume says, "No." And Kant says, "No, I can know the objects of experience. In fact, I can know them with a kind of necessity. But can I know what the things in themselves are really like? No. Can I know the world as it is? No." So in both of those respects, he's agreeing with the empiricist like Hume and not with Descartes or Leibniz.
- 8.62** Well, let's go back to Plato. Plato's philosophy of mind, I describe this way. When I have the thought that something is a triangle, I'm partly directed at that object, the particular contingent object, and I'm saying that's a triangle. I am linking that in some way to a Form, a general abstract Form like triangularity. I'm saying it exhibits triangularity, or in Plato's language, it participates in triangularity. And triangularity is what enables me to talk about triangles. It gives content to my claim that that's a triangle, and it corresponds in some way to my concept of triangularity. Somehow, the good makes sense of all of that. And that in Augustine becomes God that makes sense of all of that.
- 8.63** Kant is putting the Forms in my mind. He says, let's think of those as a priori concepts, as innate ideas in the mind, which is also what Descartes does. So here he's following Descartes's new way of ideas. And now, the other big change, the thing that makes him very different from Leibniz, is the connection between my concept and the object. In

Descartes and in Leibniz, that object has to, in some way, trigger that concept, and the concept I have to be confident applies to the object.

- 8.64** But in this case, why should I have that confidence? Actually, the object, as I perceive it, is not the thing-in-itself. It's the thing as it's been processed by my sensory apparatus and by my cognitive abilities within the brain. And so the result of that is, well, I can know something about it and I can have confidence that that concept matches the object, but only in so far as the object is being constructed by my mind, is something that is a product of my sensory and my cognitive apparatus.
- 8.65** And so this, as an object of experience, I can know something about, and I can know something about it with necessity, but only because it's a mental construction. It itself is something that is mind-dependent. It depends, that is to say, it, as I perceive it, depends on my faculties of perception and of cognition in general.
- 8.66** Because if I get more careful about it, I realize the "cause" of my perception. Here I do have to put cause in quotes—because I can't officially apply it to this—but there's a thing-in-itself out there that must be in some way responsible for my having these sensations. Then I've got these a priori concepts, and I use those to organize these sensations. Then my mind produces an object as it appears, the appearance.
- 8.67** What's the relationship between that "cause," the thing-in-itself, and then the thing as it appears to me? I have no idea. And so that is the puzzle. I can know something about the appearance and know it with necessity, know it a priori, but about the thing-in-itself, I am utterly in the dark.
- 8.68** So Aristotle doesn't have this problem. He says, "Hey, the "cause" is the thing that I perceive." The lectern is the cause of my perception of a lectern. God says, "Something is," probably, but does it really look like this? After Descartes, after Locke, we know that some aspects of it aren't really in the thing itself. We have no reason to think that anything that we perceive is in the thing itself. We don't know about that thing-in-itself at all.
- 8.69** So for Descartes, there is a match there, but only on the primary qualities. Locke would agree with that. But for Kant, we have no way of knowing. To what extent does this agree with the thing-in-itself that presumably underlies my perception of it? Who knows? We can't talk about that or even think about that at all.
- 8.70** Now, it's natural for the idealist. And by the way, this is why Kant says, "I'm not really an idealist. I'll call myself a transcendental idealist, but I'm not a real idealist because I still have these things in themselves floating around, even though I can't really tell you they exist." But the idealist says, "Wait, you can't tell me they exist, and you can't say they caused me to perceive things. What good are they?" You say, "There's this unconditioned thing—I'm just going to talk about the unconditioned = X, the "Ding an sich," the thing-in-itself.

- 8.71** Hegel and other idealists say, "If it's not playing any role in your theory, just get rid of it." But then, great, I can know about things, but the things are just the mental constructions. So from the strict idealist point of view, Kant is a guilty idealist. He's an idealist who feels bad about being an idealist. He says, "I think there must be a real world, but I don't know what it's like. I can't tell what it's like. I have no reason to believe anything I think actually is true of it." And the idealist says, "Well, just have the confidence of your convictions and just say, 'there is no such thing as the thing-in-itself, there is just the world of appearance.'"
- 8.72** I've talked about these categories, the a priori concepts. I haven't told you anything about what they are. So let me just say very quickly, before we move on to Hegel and the pure, strict idealists, what these things are supposed to be. What are those necessary conditions? Well, I perceive things as being in space and time. I can recognize something about things before I even experience them. I say, "I teach at the University of Texas at Austin." Before you know anything of what it looks like, you can know, "Well, I guess it exists in space somewhere." Actually, now that we're in an online world, maybe that's not even true. But nevertheless, we can say, "Well, at least it exists in time." I mean, there's a time when it started existing.
- 8.73** And so we know something about it. And that sort of thing is possible because we tend to perceive objects in space and time. Are the things in themselves really in space and time? Kant says, "I don't know," but those are part of our faculty of sensibility. We perceive things in space and time. Are they really like that? We're not sure.
- 8.74** That's true of other things. We can say, yeah, something like the White House is extended in space. It exists in time. It has a certain character. It's being a house, stationary. It's the kind of thing that we can know about, even if we've never seen it. Similarly, I can ask you about other things. I can say, "Oh, yes, I met someone yesterday." Before you know anything about this person, you can know something about it, and not just the verbal things about a human being, let's say. You can actually know that person exists in space, that person exists in time, blah, blah, blah.
- 8.75** We have all sorts of experience of the world, but all of those experiences are extended in space and time, and all of them have certain kinds of qualities, and we can know about that in advance. Oh, there's my kitty cat who just died recently. She was my companion for many, many years. I don't know why I went on and on with all of these material objects. I got fascinated by this. But the point is, all of those objects have something in common. Pizzas and cats and sunsets and buildings and institutions like universities, they all have some things in common, just as objects of experience. They're all extended in space and time.
- 8.76** Moreover, not only are they extended in space and time—because those are simply forms of sensibility, everything we can perceive is perceived in space and time. Things exist in space and time, that's something that is a synthetic a priori truth. But now there are all sorts of other categories and a priori concepts we use. Like unity, we call things

objects. We just use the term "thing." We describe things as one. I point to things and say, "this," or, "that," "the." All of those are basic logical functions built into the mind.

- 8.77** The same thing with plurality, recognizing a group of things as, "some," or, "several." And totalities, "all," "every," "each." Those things are just built into the logical structure of the mind. The same thing is true for certain qualities. The concept of reality or negation or limitation. Yeah, that's true, that's false. I don't know. Like the infinite, it's the not finite. Maybe it's just a negation. On the other hand, I think he has in mind here that sometimes I'm putting a different kind of boundary on there. Unhappy, for example, might just not—it seems stronger than just not happy. Maybe it's a different kind of opposition that's at stake there.
- 8.78** Then, there are all sorts of relations. The relation of being a substance or having a quality, standing in a relation. There are relations like "if/then," "causes," "depends on," "determines," "grounds." Then, "if and only if," type relations or other logical relations among things, "being part," "being whole." All of those are built into the mind, he's saying, as a priori concepts. We're not getting them from experience.
- 8.79** And indeed, Locke would say, I think that many of these are just those second-order or higher-order abilities that, of course, the mind has. So I don't have to build them in as a priori. They are inborn, but on the other hand, they aren't the kind of thing we're really fighting about between the rationalists and empiricists. So some of these are like that, but some of them aren't. And notice this one, this is a big one and a way of trying to respond to Hume: possibility, existence, and necessity.
- 8.80** He says that those are just built into the mind. It is true, we don't get them from experience, but they are part of our mental apparatus. We can sense when something might happen, when something has to happen. And where are we getting that idea? Hume says that it's this subjective feeling in us. Kant is saying that no, it's not some subjective feeling. It is instead part of our mental equipment that we already have even at birth.
- 8.81** Now, maybe there are other categories that we could supply here of a logical kind, but the point is: these allow us to form some of these laws of the understanding. What are they like? Here are some examples. "Every object stands under the necessary conditions of the synthetic unity of the manifold of intuition in a possible experience." Now, that's a complicated way of saying that everything could be experienced. What we can talk about existing is only what we could possibly experience.
- 8.82** That's actually a bold claim. In fact, remember when I was talking about Fitch's paradox, it might also be an inconsistent claim in the end. But nevertheless, his idea is, "Look, to exist is to be knowable, to be perceivable." Berkeley had said, "To be is to be perceived." Kant is saying, "To be is to be perceivable." I can only talk about the things that are existent insofar as I talk about them as possible objects of perception.

- 8.83** Here's another one. "In all change of appearances substance is permanent." In other words, the world does consist of substances. Those substances change over time. They stand in relations. They have qualities. In other words, those Aristotelian categories, he thinks, are basic laws of the understanding.
- 8.84** "All alterations take place in conformity with the law of the connection of cause and effect." In other words, every change, every event has some sort of cause. That, too, is a classic rationalist synthetic a priori truth. He thinks that's just built into the mind. We automatically look for causes, and we assume there is a cause.
- 8.85** Then finally, "All substances [...] are in thoroughgoing reciprocity," which is another way of saying there's one universe. There is one collection of things in the universe. It's not like there are parts of the universe, or a multiverse, or this collection of objects that just can't be related to this collection of objects—there's no way to get there from here. No, it's all part of one universe.
- 8.86** In any case, that enables him to say that things like this really are synthetic a priori judgments, but they apply to the objects of experience, not necessarily to the things-in-themselves.
- 8.87** So he draws a distinction between phenomena—the appearances, the objects as we perceive them—the categories apply to them, the synthetic a priori truths apply to them, we can know them with universality and necessity. But the noumena are the things in themselves—they are unconditioned by our cognitive faculties. They're the way things are or would be independently of us; the categories don't apply to them. These a priori principles don't apply to them, and we can't know them at all.
- 8.88** This brings us to critics of Kant, like Hegel. Hegel was someone who existed in Germany, maybe a generation after Kant. He critiques Kant on a number of different grounds, but the basic one we've already mentioned. If you can't know anything about these things in themselves, what are they doing there? They play no role in the system at all. The pure concepts of the understanding don't apply to them. These principles, the laws of the understanding, don't apply to them.
- 8.89** Notice what that means. We can't talk about them being possible or being necessary or even existing. We can't talk about them having causal relations to anything. So they don't fall under any of these categories, including existence or causation. Well, then what are they doing? We can't say they cause things to appear as they do to us. We can't say they actually are the things that are the inputs to our sensory apparatus. We can't even say they exist. So let's get rid of them. They don't do anything.
- 8.90** But if we get rid of them, then we end up saying, "Great, now everything is a construction of the mind!" You at least had these shadowy things out there that were somehow responsible for all this stuff, but we've gotten rid of them, and now everything is a construction of the mind. Now, what about the mind itself? Hegel says,

"Well, actually, I think the same thing is true of the self," because in Kant, there is something he refers to as the transcendental unity of our perception.

- 8.91** In Hume, the idea that all our thoughts, feelings, and perceptions are part of one's self is just kind of something imposed by us. He says, "At best, the mind is a kind of theater, and we imagine all this is taking place in the theater that is me." But he says, "I have no perception of myself. I have no real content to this idea of myself." And Kant says, "Well, then, but look, there has to be. I mean, it's my perception. It's my thought. It's my feeling. There's got to be a me." That's a necessary condition for the possibility of this kind of experience." Let's call that the transcendental unity of our perception.
- 8.92** But Hegel says, "Well, wait a minute. That's a thing-in-itself. That can't play any role. So let's get rid of it, too." We get rid of that noumenal self, that self-in-itself, that real thing. And now, how do I have a self then? What do you mean? I'm not like you. I just have a collection of thoughts, feelings, and perceptions. Hegel says, "Well, I gradually evolved this idea of a self, but that's an achievement." That's something I achieve in this process that is actually a kind of complicated process that he describes in the Phenomenology of Spirit. Notice "phenomenology," the study of the phenomena, the study of the appearances, because there's nothing beyond the appearances. And he traces the development of the self through all these stages. The last one is unhappy consciousness.
- 8.93** And finally, how do I overcome this sense of myself as disunified? I recognize you as a self. You recognize me as a self. I recognize that you recognize me as a self. You recognize that I recognize you as a self. And so that mutual recognition in society, in community with others, enables me to think of myself as a self. But that's an achievement. That's a result of all these appearances. That is not something that is presupposed as a given.
- 8.94** That, by the way, is something that inspires much of 19th-century philosophy. It's too bad I don't have time to go into it deeper here. But the idea is that the self is not something-in-itself. It is instead something that is achieved. It's not a fiction, as Hume thinks, but it's something that I gradually come to have as I interact with other people.
- 8.95** There is something else we can talk about in Hegel because Kant thinks you have these forms of sensibility. You perceive things in space and time, and everything is subject to the laws of the understanding and the categories, these a priori concepts. But Hegel says, "Why should I think that everybody, no matter when they exist or in what culture they exist, perceives things in the same way or uses the same set of concepts?"
- 8.96** He says that Kant thinks there's a universal and necessary set of these laws and concepts—they're constant, they're there for everybody in every circumstance. But he says, why should we think that's true? Maybe people don't always construct the world in the same way at all times and places, in all circumstances, in all cultures. What if they vary?

- 8.97** So Hegel is a historicist. He says, if you were in ancient Egypt, you'd use a different set of concepts in understanding the world. Some of them are likely to be in common with ours. You would also see things in space and time. But on the other hand, are the basic logical concepts you would use the same? Maybe, maybe not. What if you were in medieval Europe? Maybe you would have the same set of concepts we have as the really foundational concepts, but maybe not.
- 8.98** Maybe these things evolve over time. We know that other kinds of concepts evolve. Surely, the ancient Egyptians had no concept of electricity, and the medieval thinkers had no real concept of, let's say, quantum mechanics. So, of course, our concepts evolve over time. Why think there is this constant core of things that include things like, well, things being in community, causal relations, negation, and blah, blah, blah, all those other things that are in those categories. Maybe they evolved, too.
- 8.99** Imagine that you lived in the desert—not too hard in the current context. You might say, okay, you're going to have a certain set of concepts for understanding your environment. If you live in the middle of a city, you might have a different set of concepts you're going to use for navigating your environment. If you live in the jungle, still another one and so on.
- 8.100** Hegel says that the way we construct the world develops over time. It develops systematically. He thinks he can tell you some very high-level laws about how it does that. But in any case, philosophy varies with historical circumstances. Kant acts as if he can stand above all times, all cultures, and say, "Here are the concepts we all have automatically." Hegel says, "I'm not convinced there are any. Maybe there are, but you haven't convinced me there have to be." Maybe I have to have some concepts that are fundamental in order to process reality, in order to frame objects of the understanding and have knowledge, but I don't see why it always has to be the same set.
- 8.101** So he says, "Philosophy is its own time, raised to the level of thought." I think his view is, we should be careful about thinking that we have the key to being human or understanding anything, and that must be universal at all times and places. He says, maybe it changes, maybe there's some common core, but we need an argument for that. It looks like most of our concepts develop over time. Why not conclude that they all do?
- 8.102** Now, to be fair, Hegel does think things progress in fairly regular ways. This is the "march of Geist," the march of the Spirit, and it is progressing toward absolute knowledge. Now, why does he have this confidence, this idea that we're making at least progress and we're getting better and better concepts and better and better theories? Well, because we're getting more and more experience of the world. And so as we accumulate that experience, he thinks we are progressing in these stages toward absolute knowledge. But it's not a straight line. It comes with all sorts of bends and dips and so on.

- 8.103** But eventually, he imagines a future in which we attain absolute knowledge, where all possible experiences have been experienced by us, and yay, we know. And in that situation, maybe we could be like Kant. But he says, "No, we're not there." There are these dynamic principles that lead us toward that kind of knowledge, but we don't have it yet. And I'm not going to talk about the details of that. I'll skip past that. But throughout, all of this is informed by the social context, by the interactions between people, by our own communities.
- 8.104** There's nothing, he thinks, that is really just given to us in sensation. Everything is shaped by our concepts. In Kant, there's a pretty sharp divide between sensibility and understanding, between what happens in the sense organs and what happens in the brain. Hegel is not so convinced we can draw that distinction. He thinks what we see is in part shaped by our concepts. We're looking at the world looking for something. We have concepts we're looking to apply, and we identify those things. Sensibility is really being directed by the understanding, and so he's not convinced there is anything that's just raw data coming in in perception that then we work with conceptually. He sees them instead as intertwined and interacting.
- 8.105** Okay, well, it's that idea of Hegel's that actually leads to the American philosophical movement known as pragmatism. The pragmatic theory of truth is really that thought that we are progressing toward absolute knowledge. In one sense, the pragmatist says, "There's no difference in meaning without a difference in practice." The pragmatist is always looking for the practical payoff, the practical difference. That's one aspect of pragmatism.
- 8.106** But the other aspect is to say just as Hegel thought. We're heading toward this stage of absolute knowledge, we can think about these mysterious dynamic laws he talks about to give him this confidence and say, wait a minute, wait a minute. It's not some mystical thing. It's just scientific method.
- 8.107** Why do we have confidence that we're getting better at understanding the world? Because scientific method is a method that actually allows us to accumulate experiences, conduct experiments, and make revisions. In other words, it is empirically grounded based on observation, based on experience, but also it is self-correcting. That enables us to have some confidence that scientific method is leading us to better and better understanding of the world.
- 8.108** Moreover, instead of having this confidence that it's going to lead to absolute knowledge someday, think of the truth as just whatever the limit of that kind of scientific inquiry would be. Instead of saying science is inquiring after the truth, say truth is what science will produce at the end of time. In the infinite limit, if we can have all possible experiences, and do all possible self-correction.
- 8.109** What are we really interested in? The pragmatist says, stable belief, belief that we're not going to have to give up in the face of further information, in the face of further

experimentation. That's the best we can do. For now, we don't know what the truth is. The truth is what the ultimate scientific community, the ideal scientific community, would agree on. We don't yet know what that is, but we can say we hope to find things that at least won't be overturned later.

- 8.110** What gives us the confidence is that science is self-correcting. It consists of a regular pattern of making observations, formulating hypotheses, testing consequences, and then revising our hypotheses—getting better and better. This really is the first test of a bulletproof vest. Okay, pretty dramatic test. "I'm wearing the vest, shoot me!" And he survived, proving this, right? But if somebody said, "Hey, this will protect you from a bullet," pretty scary. But we test it out, we find out, "Yes, it does." Okay.
- 8.111** Instead of defining science as the search for truth, we say, "I'll define truth as what science would ideally produce at the end of scientific inquiry." It's what would ultimately be agreed to by those who investigate in this way. It's the ideal limit of scientific inquiry. Now, anything we think along the way, we could be wrong about. We can't say these are necessary laws of the understanding we can have full confidence in now, but we can hope that they are stable and don't get revised. If they get revised, we can have confidence that ultimately they'll be revised for the better.
- 8.112** Okay, so notice that does allow him to reject some of Leibniz's arguments, saying, "Yeah, how do I go from these particular contingent truths to things that are universal and necessary? I do it very provisionally, recognizing I could be wrong. So let's inquire further and see if I need to correct all of that."
- 8.113** I'm going to conclude here with two thoughts. First of all, Nietzsche, who leads us in a radical direction that is somewhat pessimistic. Nietzsche says, "Look, Hegel thinks all of this leads ultimately to truth, whether it does now or not. Kant thinks we already have these ultimate truths there in the laws of the understanding. But what if there are no universal truths about the world? What if there is no such thing as absolute knowledge, absolute truth?"
- 8.114** Protagoras had said, "Man is the measure of all things." That's a relativist view, and he meant each individual person. But what if we think that truth is relative to, I don't know, a culture, a society, a historical era, an interpretive community, an individual person? We might think there is no ideal limit to scientific inquiry. There is no law of the understanding.
- 8.115** Maybe our understanding of the truth doesn't change in rational ways. Maybe Hegel and the pragmatists are wrong. Maybe in the end, science isn't even driven in this rational self-correcting way? What if it's driven in irrational and arbitrary ways? Then there's no reason to think it converges on the truth or converges at all, and that's pretty scary.
- 8.116** He concludes science needs to become more playful. Just try out interpretations because he's not convinced that scientists actually move in a direction in a rational way.

There are contemporary philosophers of science who think that's right. In the end, he's left with authenticity. Be the person you are, become the person you are. There's no guidance outside yourself you can really look to. You're the only test.

- 8.117** And that leads him to say most dramatically, "God is dead." And here he really means just in any sense of absolute truth, absolute knowledge, absolute anything, is gone. That's a scary prospect. He said that we're now on the horizon of the infinite. In a way, it's exciting because there are no boundaries, but it's also terrifying. He says, "Hours will come when you recognize it's infinite, and there's nothing more terrible than infinity." You are out there on the sea. You don't have a compass, and there is no land to sail to. And so you're in trouble.
- 8.118** And he predicts that the 20th century will be a century of great wars as a result of this because nobody has anything to anchor, anything. But he hopes we can approach life as a child at play rather than as a warrior, hating all those who disagree with us.
- 8.119** I do want to finish with one other thought, though. And that is the objection that the realist has to all of this. Because you might think, okay, it's true that in Kant, there is no role that that thing-in-itself actually plays. And yet that leaves us with a kind of puzzle. It's a puzzle that I call the missing explanation argument. Here's why. I do something that is perceptible by all of you. I clap my hands, say. You all hear a hand clap. That's amazing from an idealist point of view. If we get rid of the thing-in-itself, then, wow, you have this mental episode. So do you. So do you. Now, it's not exactly the same one. People sitting in different positions are going to hear it a few milliseconds apart and so on. But nevertheless, it would be amazing to think of this.
- 8.120** It's as if we all had the same dream last night. We'd say that's so weird. How did we all have the same dream? If you get rid of the thing-in-itself, there's no reason to think that our experiences have anything to do with the experiences of anyone else. Or, for that matter, that my experiences at one moment of time are going to match my experiences at another moment of time. Dreams are such that there's sudden discontinuities.
- 8.121** But I look around this room, I cover up my eyes, I look again, you're still here. What explains that? Why are you still here? Well, the idealist has nothing to say. Once you get rid of the thing-in-itself, how can you answer that question? The thing-in-itself is what would give you an answer. There's still that same thing, whatever it is, that I'm actually perceiving.
- 8.122** And so Bertrand Russell, thinking about pragmatism, but also thinking about idealism more broadly, says, wait a minute. There is something about this view that cannot be right. Something must explain why the world seems continuous to me, why your experience seems to match mine, at least roughly. And the idealist, the pragmatist, has no such explanation. So in the end, he says, "Look, as far as I can tell, it is possible that the world could just end tonight. And I can't do anything to stop it." He says, "No

matter what the idealist thinks, no matter what the pragmatist thinks, it is not I who made the world."

- 8.123** And that is Russell's plea in the end, I think, for realism. He says that there's got to be something independent of the mind. Otherwise, we have nothing that can explain why minds actually experience the world as continuous and why your mind in any way corresponds to my mind in what we're experiencing. I don't want to leave you with Nietzsche's pessimism. I'll leave you instead with Russell's claim, "Look, I am not God. I am not the one who is projecting this entire world."
- 8.124** May put you on the spot here. With all of the different philosophers, how would you define Bonevacism?
- 8.125** How would I define my own philosophy? That's a tricky question. I find myself drawn—and by the way, I did not know this at the time, actually. One of my teachers, Nicholas Rescher, was somebody I took some courses with and I knew quite well. But at the time that I was studying with him, he was mostly focused on the philosophy of Leibniz and a variety of other historical figures, and that's what he was teaching. I did not realize that in the end, my view of a lot of questions and his view were very much the same.
- 8.126** But after I left graduate school, he began writing a series of things, and I just recently published a paper describing that. And in doing that, I was not only describing his views, I was to some extent describing my own. I called it the Unfathomable World. Here is my picture of things, and I think Rescher's picture of things.
- 8.127** The world is real. It does exist independently of the mind, but it's also immensely complex. What we do in constructing ideas about it and theories about it and just common sense views of it, is that we have to simplify. We create these simple models of an incredibly complex reality. In doing that, we are at best approximating what's really going on out there. To some extent, I think the skeptic is right to say, "Hey, what if our ideas don't match reality?" Because I think we've got these simple models that only match reality partly.
- 8.128** Think about, for example, well, the kind of physics I studied. I found that I was hopeless at trying to help my daughter—who was in engineering—with her physics courses because I thought, "Oh, I know lots of physics." Then in engineering physics, there's stuff like friction. In theoretical physics that I studied, there's no friction. We're all just point masses in a frictionless universe and elastic collisions.
- 8.129** Anyway, there's something about Newtonian or even relativistic mechanics that's quite beautiful and oversimplified. I think that sort of picture of the world, that picture where, "Oh, yeah, all collisions are elastic and there is no friction and so on." It's a model. It's a model that doesn't match the reality, which is much more complicated. But I think that's what we're doing all the time. Even in engineering physics you're doing that. You're just adding in a few more things. I think that's true of all of our thinking about the world. We're constantly constructing these overly simple models.

- 8.130** Now, as we go on, I think we do get better at it. We replace inadequate models with more sophisticated models. Sometimes we go backwards and actually forget things. In fact, another teacher of mine, Wilfrid Sellars, said, "Philosophy starts with a certain set of simple models. They become more and more complex. Eventually, they get to the point where they can actually match reality pretty well. But they're now so difficult and so complicated that everybody looks at them and says, 'Oh, that's really boring,' and seeks to throw them out and start with a new set of insights."
- 8.131** In his view, that's roughly what happened to medieval philosophy. It got very sophisticated, very complicated, and got better and better at describing reality—at least before the scientific revolution, part of our understanding of reality—then people just dropped it. Why? Partly because the black plague and nobody knew Latin anymore, but partly because they said, "Oh, all these distinctions, it's complicated, it's boring, it's intricate, it's difficult." So they gave up. I think there's an element of that, too, which is why I'm not so convinced that it's this steady path toward improvement.
- 8.132** But I think that's, broadly speaking, what happens. I think it happens in ethics. I think it happens in all sorts of areas. I am a realist in one sense, thinking there is a mind-independent world, but also someone who thinks our models cognitively don't match it all that terribly well because we have to oversimplify it. It's not necessarily infinite in its complexity, but it's a very high degree of complexity, and we can only take fragments of it and understand it a bit by bit.
- 8.133** So part of what I see, and I think Rescher sees about this, is our theories are bound to remain local. I can have a theory of this, a theory of that. But if you're looking for a grand theory of everything, you're probably not going to get it.
- 8.134** Going back to the pulling ideas from experience, I was wondering if you had any explanation for ideas formed by people who may be undergoing drug use. In that case, would the idea, or would the drug itself, be the experience?
- 8.135** Okay, yes. It's an interesting question to ask about altered states of consciousness and what people are experiencing then and what that tells us about reality. Let me go back to Philo's *On Drunkenness*. We tend to assume that the world that you perceive when you're drunk is less accurate than your perceptions of things when you're sober. But some people have taken at least certain kinds of drugs and have thought it gives them a deep insight of the world. That's not just true of the Timothy Leary LSD 1960s set. It's true of a variety of traditions throughout the world.
- 8.136** In addition to drug use, or something like that, you've got these meditative traditions. For example, within Buddhism, you have a number of different schools who say that meditation is something that can give you a deeper insight into reality. The same thing is true in Hinduism. Within those contexts, you think, all right, there's this altered state of perception. The view is that somehow that altered state lets you see reality in a

different way, gives you concepts to understand reality in a different way and gives you knowledge you couldn't otherwise have.

- 8.137** Now, one thing I find interesting about a lot of those traditions is that they say, yes, there's this deep insight and deep transformation that happens to you mentally. But you can't really put it into words. People will say, "I've had this experience and it is blissful and it is something like a breakdown between my own mind and the world. I feel this unity with the world, this harmony that I can't really describe or explain." That sort of thought, I'm not going to discount at all. I think that might be very important. But I think it's also revealing that people say, "I don't know how to put that into language."
- 8.138** That actually, I think, is maybe part of this idea of complexity that I have, where I think a lot of things we can't actually put into language. Suppose I'm trying to describe my own feelings Wassily Kandinsky, the painter, said, "What I'm doing in my paintings"—which after his early stages were highly abstract— he wrote a book trying to describe what he was doing concerning the spiritual in art. He said, "I'm trying to give you certain kinds of experience and create certain feelings, have a language in these paintings of feelings, and you're not going to have any words to describe those feelings. I am trying to give you a language for things you don't know how to express now."
- 8.139** At least when I look at those paintings, I get it. That painting will give me a certain kind of feeling and a certain state of mind. If you say, "What is it?" I can't tell you. That's why I'm not an art critic. I'd say, "Look at this!" I don't know how to express it, but I get that there are all these feelings and all these awarenesses, let me put it very broadly, that I don't know how to describe. I think there's a lot in the world that is really—I don't know if I want to say it's ineffable, absolutely—in other words, that you couldn't use language to describe it.
- 8.140** Maybe it's just that given any existing language, we don't have terms for that. We don't know how to describe it. I do find it really interesting when you look at terms for emotions or feelings in different languages, you find different kinds of things. In Danish, there are certain terms for states of mind that as soon as you learn the term, you realize, "Oh, I totally get it." Like feeling comfortable at home, we don't have a word for that in English, really. I can express it in some way. "Imagine yourself coming in on a cold winter's day, sitting there warm and having a nice cup of cocoa. That feeling, okay?" I don't have a word for that feeling, but the Danes do.
- 8.141** When you start realizing that, you think, okay, maybe there are all sorts of things that my language, and any given language won't have terms for, but that are really important. I think sometimes that's what people are recognizing through meditation or through drug use or something. They're having an experience they don't know how to describe, but it really is an experience. It's really a different kind of thing. There might be a real insight into the world sometimes in this. It's just that they don't have the language to tell you what that is, really.

